All For An Alien's Love Book Four

ONE GALAXY UNDER GOD

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by L. M. Ridd

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Dedication

For JPL

Chapter One

The lone alien warrior arrived in the dilapidated barn, owned by the two Earthlings - *Zarcons* - known as Norman and Zelda Maddock. The report he had received from Cambra Vernier regarding the Maddocks' treatment of his ward was disturbing, so he immediately transported to the surface of the planet below, to investigate the matter himself and to rescue the boy he had vowed to protect. Once he arrived on Zarak, or Earth as it was known by its inhabitants, Kaanig Dammen Altair was quick to locate the battered child lying on the cement floor of the barn. His top man had not lied or distorted his findings. The child, James Donaldson, had indeed been severely beaten and was in desperate need of immediate medical attention.

Wasting no time, the alien quickly knelt to lay hands on the small Zarcon. Registering a soft heartbeat, he gave a sigh of relief then bowed his head to pray over him. Voicing soft petition to the Source he served, he pleaded for the boy's healing, then jerked his head up suddenly at sound of someone entering the barn. Easing back on his knee, he rested an arm there expectantly, to peer over with some surprise at the older Zarcon moving toward him.

"*Hey!"* the man bellowed at sight of him, striding quickly toward the alien and drawing his weapon. "*What* are you doing? *Get away from him!*"

Kaanig Altair was not intimidated by the older man, who appeared nervous and pale as he observed him. Removing his hand from the child, Dammen slowly rose to his full height of over seven feet and glared down at the opposition, an air of authority about him that the man, Sheriff Matthew Hammersfeldt, could not refute. He gazed silently at the lawman, then stooped down to carefully and gently lift the lifeless child into powerful arms. With a furious scowl, he silently dared the Earth man to try and stop him from taking the boy.

"Here now…" the sheriff began, raising a tentative hand.

But Dammen ignored him and began walking away. Turning with the child, he stared at the man as he lifted his wrist to give an order into a strange device that only his people could understand.

"You will tell no one of this," he ordered the sheriff, in English this time, glaring at him so emphatically that the older man nearly fainted in fear of him.

Then the alien vanished in the blink of an eye, leaving the other man quaking in terror at what he had just witnessed.

Chapter Two

"Do everything you can for him," Dammen ordered his personal physician, Paxis K'hati, in Kathian, the dominant language of their planet, as he carefully laid the unconscious child on a padded bunk in the medical unit of his vessel. "I want you by his side until I order you to leave, understand?"

"Yes, Ziros," Paxis said, nodding. Grimacing at the blood covering both the boy and his sovereign, the physician hurried to produce a thin sheet to wrap the boy in, as they gently removed his messy garments. "I'll take very good care of him."

"I'll check back in awhile," the Kaanig told him. Then he departed the room, joining the man waiting for him in the corridor. His second-in-command, Cambra Jeiel Vernier.

"I think he'll recover," Dammen told his friend, trying to wipe away the sticky feel of the blood still on his hands, "but it will take awhile."

"Hard to believe anyone could do that to a child," the cambra said.

"I know. I just wish we had gotten to him sooner." Dammen paused regretfully. "I was seen."

Jeiel turned startled eyes on his sovereign. "What happened?"

The taller man frowned and ducked his head.

"Nothing," he said. "I merely warned the Zarcon I encountered not to tell anyone of what he had seen. I can only trust him to proceed accordingly."

"And the girl?" Jeiel asked. "What of her?"

Dammen pursed his lips with concern, his noble brow crinkled. "I don't know," he replied. "I wanted to find her, to bring her safely away, but with the child's life at stake, I had to just take him and go."

The cambra fell thoughtfully silent as he considered the safety of the boy's sibling.

"We will rescue her," he assured his friend, patting him on the back. "Do not worry."

"We need to track her," Dammen said. "We need to make certain she comes to no further harm until we can get to her. She's alone now."

"I will put my men on it immediately, Ziros, do not fear."

As they spoke, they arrived at the Kaanig's quarters. As the door opened and Dammen stepped inside, he gave his friend a weak smile, guilt over his inability to protect Jimmy Donaldson and his sister marring his countenance.

“I have faith in your abilities, Jeiel. And your men’s.”

“I know, Ziros,” Jeiel replied. “We will keep you advised.”

Nodding mutely, Dammen retreated inside his quarters, leaving his best friend to check on the young woman’s safety. Both knew that had they forced themselves into the Maddock household to rescue Cassia, James’s sister, that someone might have gotten hurt in the process. Although the Valtorians had the ability to do so, they had no desire to terrorize Cassia by forcefully kidnapping her. To annihilate Zarcons was not their intent either. They only wanted the girl, the one the Altair had promised her father he would care for after her parents died. Had the aliens used brute force to steal her away from the planet, she might never accept her role in Valtor. The Kaanig did not want to jeopardize all that he had planned.

Chapter Three

It was four days – *solarities* – before eight-year-old Jimmy Donaldson ever opened his eyes, revealing orbs the color of a cerulean sky. Groggy, he squinted about him at the strange environment, noting the pale orange walls and white ceiling above him. He was lying on a padded, maroon-colored bed that glittered when he moved, but he found himself too weak and in too much pain to get out of it. A thin tan coverlet lay lightly atop him, and he knew he was naked beneath it. He couldn't figure out where he was or why he was there, until he remembered Norman Maddock's wooden cane crashing down on him. Squeezing his eyes shut at the memory and at the pain he still felt, he gave a sob of gladness that he was still alive.

"Cassia?" he croaked, although his throat was dry. "Are you here?" He peered over at the open doorway leading to another room. From his bed, he could see someone moving about, laying some strange items out on a worktable. It was a man he didn't recognize. At sound of Jimmy's voice, the man immediately turned and moved toward him. Noting Jimmy's wakeful state, he grinned and pulled forth a small light which he shined into the boy's eyes, then happily turned to relay something into an intercom. The words he spoke into it were foreign, but Jimmy barely noticed as he watched the man. Middle-aged, the man was dressed in an odd, mid-length green jacket and had long graying black hair tied back in a queue. His skin was darker than average, and he reminded Jimmy of Indians he used to see on television.

"Is Cassia here?" he finally asked the man, when he was done relaying his message. "My sister?"

"I'm afraid not," the man replied, in English this time, peering down into Jimmy's face with friendly concern.

"But, I want to see her," Jimmy insisted. *"Please."*

But the man ignored his request, aware that he could not make promises.

"I am Paxis," he told him. "I am a physician."

Jimmy stared at the man, comprehending. "You are helping me get better?" he said.

"Yes," Paxis said with another smile. After caring for the young Zarcon for four straight solarities, he was more than grateful that his patience and skills had paid off. He knew his sovereign would be pleased.

* * * *

Kaanig Altair stopped just short of the door to the med bay where Jimmy Donaldson lay, putting a hand to the door frame. Facing this child was going to be difficult, he knew, considering all that had happened, but it had to be done. There was no one else who could carry out this dreaded task, so he had to be careful of how he handled it.

Source help me now, he prayed silently. *Our future depends on it.*

With that, he whisked his hand over the sensor that opened the door and stepped inside, pausing to stare with some trepidation at the small child who was now under his care and protection.

At his entrance, both Jimmy and Paxis turned their heads to look at him. To Jimmy, he was a giant of some proportion, who seemed to grow larger as he approached the bed. At one nod from Dammen, Paxis hastily bowed and departed the room, after giving one last finishing tug on Jimmy's coverlet, pulling it more securely about him before he left.

"Ziros," he said as he bowed, then departed, leaving Jimmy alone with the man.

"You're so big," Jimmy commented aloud, without thinking.

Dammen stiffened self-consciously, not having taken into consideration how his size and appearance might affect the boy. Before he could reply, the boy continued, "Are you an alien?" His tone was almost hopeful and full of wonder.

Speechless this time, Dammen's lips curled slightly as he peered down at the child from his great height.

"Why do you ask?" he said at last.

Jimmy shrugged. "I don't know. You guys just seem…different."

The Kaanig lowered his eyes as he thought about this, then laid a hand to the boy's shoulder and gently squeezed it.

"Where I come from, you would be considered an alien," he told him.

At this revelation, Jimmy's eyes widened, and he grinned. "Wow, really. Me? An alien? That'd be so cool."

His response brought a soft chuckle from Dammen as he realized the boy was not afraid of him…or of the fact that he truly was an alien.

Jimmy gave him a thoughtful stare. "What's your name?" he said. "And have you ever been on *Star Voyage*?"

A dark brow lifted quizzically at this last question as the man considered his reply.

"You may call me Dammen for now," he answered. "But I'm sorry. I do not know this *Star Voya*ge to which you refer."

"It's a T.V. show, silly. Don't you watch T.V.?"

Shaking his head, Dammen shrugged and put up his hands in ignorance.

Jimmy pursed his lips then and did his best to pull his covers closer to his neck. A cast on his right arm made even that simple chore difficult.

"You don't know what you're missing," he told the alien matter-of-factly.

The Altair smiled then, feeling completely at ease in the company of this young lad. Such innocence was foreign to him. His position often kept him quite busy with other leaders throughout the galaxy, so he spent little time with children. Plus, he had no children of his own.

"Putting all that aside, James - or should I call you Jimmy?" Dammen said, moving closer, not explaining how he, in fact, knew his name. "I want to know how *you* are feeling."

At the question, Jimmy's eyes watered as he recalled the ordeal he had been through.

"I want to see Cassia," he said by way of reply, his lip trembling.

"I am sorry," Dammen said, sighing inwardly at this dreaded question. "That is not possible right now."

"But why?"

The Kaanig sighed aloud this time and reached over nervously to tug the blanket up even more closely about Jimmy's neck. These were the words he had dreaded more than ever.

"You were hurt, Jimmy. Badly. I needed to remove you from the bad people so I could take care of you. I was not able to bring Cassia with us at this time."

"But…why?" Jimmy persisted, crying now.

"There was no time. I had to get you to safety."

"Is Cassia still with the bad people? The Maddocks?" Jimmy asked, wiping his tears away with the back of his hand. "Alone?"

Dammen's heart broke then, at the fear and anguish in the child's tone.

"Yes," he said, his own eyes watering, realizing he had left his sister in the hands of a deranged couple. "I will…get her…later."

"When?"

"I do not know. But I promise I will. I give you my word."

Backing away from the bed, the Kaanig peered down remorsefully at the boy, wishing that none of this had happened to any of them.

Lapsing into silence, Jimmy's lips quivered. "She's all alone with them, Dammen," he said, his words speaking volumes. "Please get her soon."

Unable to reply, Dammen merely nodded, gave the boy's shoulder an understanding pat, then hastily departed, unable to suffer any more of this conversation.

Once back in his own quarters, the galactic ruler, a man feared by friend and foe alike, gave way to the tears he had been trying so hard to contain. Tears for a child he hardly knew and for a future that had yet to be written.

Chapter Four

"I think my sister would really like you," Jimmy said, peering over at Kaanig Altair, his new friend who was teaching him how to ride a boréa, a magnificent horse-like creature. It had been a month – *menta* – since he had arrived on Planet Konatha, the Altair's home, and brought to his palace at Travaar. It had been almost four mentas since Jimmy's ordeal, and he was almost fully recovered. So far, Dammen had toured him about his massive estate and told him he was going to teach him many things.

The Altair glanced over at the boy with curiosity. He was sitting astride his own massive stallion. "Why do you say that?" he wanted to know, not quite certain that Cassia Donaldson would care for him the way he hoped she would.

"You're very good looking," Jimmy explained, "and really nice to me."

Dammen snorted at this. "You think she will like me because I am kind to you?"

"Oh, yes," Jimmy explained emphatically. "Cassia doesn't like people who are mean to me. I know she'll be happy, too, when I tell her how you rescued my kitten and brought him here for me."

Dammen smiled then, secretly hoping things would be that easy.

"Jimmy," he began, carefully considering his next words. "Would you mind if I was joined – that is, *married* – to your sister?"

Jimmy turned in his saddle, the expression on his innocent face giving himself away.

"Oh, why that'd be great," he exclaimed happily. "Are you going to marry Cassia?"

"Yes," Dammen admitted, somewhat embarrassed. "I would like to."

The boy beamed ever broader at this discovery. "I would like that very much," he said. "And I'll bet Cassia would, too."

"Do you…think Cassia would ever grow to l—"

But Dammen stopped himself. Whatever was he doing, asking a child his age about love?

"Grow to what?"

"Never mind," Dammen said, shaking his head. "It wasn't important."

"Can you teach me how to fight some more?" the boy asked, changing the subject abruptly, clearly having no inkling of relationships between men and women yet. "After we finish riding?"

"Um, maybe later," the Altair remarked. "I have some things to attend to first." He had no intention of keeping Jimmy abreast of what was happening with his beloved sibling. Not yet.

As it stood now, Cassia Donaldson was still locked away in some fanged mental institution, having been blamed for Jimmy's supposed murder. Once he got her out of that mess, before something horrible happened to her as well, he knew he would seek out those responsible and deal with them in his own way. Right now, the problem was of how to locate Cassia and remove her from her prison, without impacting the world around her. He had no wish to involve Zarcons in his mission or change the way things were on Zarak, her planet of origin. He wanted to steal Cassia away, with no one being the wiser. From experience, he knew how Zarcons treated outworld visitors to their planet so he knew better than to make a noticeably destructive entrance in order to rescue her.

As Dammen directed Jimmy back to the stables with their mounts, he turned to the boy, curious to see his reaction to his next words.

"If I married your sister, Jimmy, that would make us brothers. Would you like that?"

It was as he had expected. The child's eyes widened, and he gave a wide smile of pure joy at the thought of being related to whom he considered "the coolest guy he'd ever met."

"I would like that, Dammen," he said happily, still unaware that his future brother-in-law was the ruler of an entire galaxy, and extremely powerful. "I would like that very much."

Dammen's heart lifted at his comment, pleased that Cassia's brother was so accepting of having an alien for a relative.

"Then brothers we shall be, Jimmy."

"For always?"

"Yes, for always."

As they rode side-by-side companionably, Dammen secretly hoped that Cassia wanted what they wanted and that she would be as accepting of their joining, their *f'shsta*, as Jimmy was. Had he not chosen Cassia as life mate, things would have been much easier, but now he had many things to consider with regard to their relationship, and that is what scared him the most. Once she learned that he was responsible for her parents' tragic deaths, he worried that she might refuse him for that reason alone.

Peering over at Jimmy's cherubic face and blond curls, Dammen also realized what he had to do in order to bring his plans for Cassia to fruition. As difficult as it was going to be, he had to keep her from reuniting with Jimmy until the time was right. He did not want Cassia to feel grateful or obligated to him in any way. No, he wanted Cassia Donaldson to fall in love with him as the man he was...and for no other reason.

Chapter Five

The Rhenian timescan read nearly three beohsa ae - *three a.m.* - when the muffled sobbing intruded into the peaceful stillness of Kaanig Altair's bedchamber. At the uncommon noise, he stirred uncomfortably and then tried blocking the sounds by burying his head under a pillow - *or headlay* - as they called them in Valtor. Still, when the sobbing continued for almost an hour – an *oron*, Dammen knew he could no longer ignore Jimmy Donaldson's pain. Sighing, he reluctantly got out of bed, naked, and slipped into a robe, belting it into a knot about his waist as he plodded tiredly down the hall toward Jimmy's room. Having only been at Travaar a little while, it was understandable that Jimmy was not only homesick but still missing his family a great deal. Dammen cringed inwardly, wondering how he was ever going to replace what the boy had so tragically lost…because of him.

The man he had posted outside Jimmy's room was noticeably disturbed by the boy's crying but seemed relieved at seeing his sovereign heading toward him. Standing aside, the man bowed respectfully as Dammen made to enter the room.

Moving quietly, Dammen entered the bedchamber, peering through the darkness at Jimmy's bed. Lying on his side, Jimmy was curled in a fetal position with his face buried in his own headlay. Without hesitation, Dammen drew the door closed quietly and proceeded toward him. Sitting down beside the boy, he slowly, gently drew him into his arms, cradling him against him, understanding all he was going through because of him.

"It will be all right," Dammen whispered tenderly as he rocked the child consolingly. "I promise." But, as the boy continued sobbing, seemingly unaware of the strong arms about him, the Altair's heart lurched with guilt. "I'm so sorry, Jimmy," he said finally, nudging the boy's fair head with his chin. "So very sorry, you'll never know.

Later, when Dammen finally trudged back to his own bed, his heart felt heavy with regret due to his inept handling of the Donaldson incident. He should have swooped in immediately and stolen both children away before anything happened to them. But he hadn't, and now he regretted his decision not to interfere in Zarconian affairs. He had the capability to steal Jimmy and Cassia away before anyone might have even been aware of his presence, but he had failed to act. And now, he thought dismally as he entered his room, now he would pay for that mistake for the rest of his life.

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It took almost a month for the sobbing episodes to end. After a few solarities of being dragged from bed in the early morning hours to console Jimmy, Dammen had finally given in and carried the boy into his own bed. After awhile, Jimmy seemed more secure and, soon enough, the crying subsided. Meanwhile, a bond had forged between the two that surprised everyone. Kaanig Altair, most of all. It was almost as if Dammen had become not only Jimmy's surrogate father, but his brother as well, so close had they become.

"Jeiel," he said one morning. "I want you to help me with Jimmy. I want him kept so busy with training, education, travel, or just plain fun, that he won't have time to mope around or think about his family."

“I understand, Ziros,” Cambra Vernier said. “It is the only way, to be sure.”

“The fact that he now trusts me implicitly is a godsend, and I won’t have it destroyed by childish emotions. I want the boy to mature quickly, to be trained in every aspect of Valtor so that he will be as competent as I’m hoping Cassia will become one day in governing the empire.”

“Yes, Majesty. It will be as you say.”

Dammen gave his friend a firm look. “May I have your word on that, Jeiel?”

“Aye,” the cambra replied. “You have my word.”

Satisfied, Kaanig Altair patted his friend’s brawny arm and nodded. He knew he could always count on his top man to accede to his wishes.

“Good, Jeiel. Then he is yours, your responsibility, whenever I am not around.”

Bowing in acquiescence, at the seriousness of what the Altair was asking him to do, Jeiel stared soberly at his friend and sovereign lord.

“Aye, Majesty. The boy will never leave my side, and I will protect him with my life. By your command.”

“Then begin today,” Dammen continued. “Train him in all aspects of combat and weaponry. Increase his current training to include aspects of our technology as well, but only those that all the H’San are familiar with. Our secrets will come later. Is that understood?”

“Yes,” Jeiel replied.

“Then see to it. Jimmy is in with the tutor right now. You can arrange with Kitar a suitable daily schedule. I want the boy so tired at night that he’ll fall right to sleep. Even if he has ceased his open grieving, there is nothing to say that it won’t begin again, especially if I’m not around. You need to establish a bond with him as well, Jeiel. He must have more than one person he can trust and feel comfortable with.”

“By your command, Ziros. I understand.”

“I want daily reports on his progress, Jeiel, across the *miÆ* or however you want to do it.”

“Yes, Ziros. As you wish.”

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“And, Jeiel,” Dammen said, turning, “please don’t let me down. I have too much on my plate right now, and I really need someone to partner with me in dealing with the Donaldsons.”

“I won’t let you down. You know that,” Jeiel said, although he knew what was really troubling Kaanig Altair. His future life mate had still not been brought safely to Valtor, and it was troubling him a great deal. But Jeiel vowed he would not see his sovereign and best friend suffer. He would help him in any way he could, if only to ease the guilt Dammen still felt in his heart at the pain he had already inflicted on the Donaldsons. Jeiel knew that once Cassia Donaldson was safe at Travaar that the Altair

would ease up on himself. The last thing a galactic ruler needed was further stress in his life. The fact that Kaanig Altair needed a life mate, someone he could really trust, was clear to him, and he prayed that Cassia Donaldson would indeed be the female Dammen so desperately needed in his life.

Chapter Six

Two years – *scalons* - passed before Kaanig Altair made the decision to place Jimmy into a public education facility. He and Cambra Vernier had given the boy top-notch training in the art of war, combat, fighting skills, military tactics, and equestrian skills, as well as teaching him several of the many languages used in Valtor. Now, Dammen felt it necessary for Jimmy to be among others his own age and took it upon himself to privately enroll him in a small school located in Zaratan, the domed city below Travaar.

School officials were given strict instructions regarding Jimmy's identity and protocol, so none of the other students or teachers would single him out for specialized treatment. He was to be treated as one of the Kathian natives and given no special courtesies, and all problems were to be directed regularly to the Altair himself, for him to deal with. Jimmy was to be treated like everybody else and allowed to grow through his own experiences. Each day, he was also instructed to walk several blocks from the school so that no one would observe the imperial guard sent each day to collect him. The same man was also sent each morning to deposit him at the same location.

One solarity Jimmy did not appear after school as he was supposed to, so the H'San immediately informed the Altair that something was amiss with the boy. Dammen was quick to arrive on the scene, accompanied by Jeiel Vernier, to see what the problem was. Not wanting to call attention to themselves, they covertly entered the school in search of Jimmy.

They checked with the school administrator, who had no idea where he was. After a quick investigation, Jimmy was located in back of the school, surrounded by a gang of bullies who had him up against the wall of a storage shed in a threatening manner. At sight of this, both Jeiel and the headmaster started toward the group, anxious to break it up, but the Altair halted them, curious to see how Jimmy handled himself. He didn't have to wait long.

As the largest boy, clearly the lead bully, started pummeling Jimmy as two other boys held him firmly in place, he suddenly brought his leg up, as he had been trained, kicking the bully in the chest. As the bully stumbled backwards, Jimmy immediately broke the others' hold on him, freeing himself. Then he brought his arm back, curled his fist, and punched the bully in the jaw. As the bully fell back beneath the punch, Jimmy snapped forward, jumping up to nimbly get atop him and place his knees tightly about the older boy's neck, squeezing him painfully. Shocked by this turn of events, the other boys stepped back, gaping. Using the leverage afforded him now, Jimmy forced the older boy backwards onto the ground, still using his knees. Once the bully was on his back, the other boys darted away in terror as Jimmy started giving the bully a taste of his own medicine. Only when the boy started crying and begging for release did Jimmy ease off of him.

"Come near me again," he warned the boy, moving away to retrieve his scattered things, "and you'll get more of the same."

Confident the bully would no longer bother him, Jimmy strolled away. "And you'd better hope I haven't missed my ride." As he did, the Altair and his two companions hurriedly ducked into a vacant room, not wanting him to know they had witnessed the episode. Lifting his wrist com - his *d'lab'r* -

Dammen quickly ordered his man to the pick up area, informing him that all was as it should be. Then he and Jeiel departed, both immensely pleased with Jimmy's handling of the situation.

Once Jimmy returned to Travaar, they made no mention of what they had seen, but waited for him to share his experience. Since he didn't, they didn't bother to pry. They did, however, upgrade his combat training to a new level that afternoon, feeling he was more than ready. By the time they were done with Jimmy, they knew he would be a fine warrior, a well trained instrument who could handle himself well in any battle situation.

Chapter Seven

It was Jimmy's first solarity back to school after the two menta respite allowed all Kathian children each scalon, during the hot summer mentas prevalent in that part of Konatha. Once in his designated classroom, he stopped mid stride at sight of the girl who had taken the seat in front of his assigned desk at the back of the room. She was striking, with her long blue-black hair, dark skin and eyes. What made her different was the extreme loveliness of her nymph-like face. She radiated sensitivity and happiness, as evidenced by the small crowd of boys hanging about her. Laughing and joking, the girl displayed dazzling white teeth, as well as two prominent dimples on her cheeks. She was breathtaking, and Jimmy Donaldson was instantly smitten.

Suddenly shy as he made toward his seat, the group of boys hovering about her quickly parted as he moved past them. Some had learned an early lesson the previous scalon about ganging up on Jimmy Donaldson. He had easily overpowered them all at some point or another, winning every battle. Eventually they had given up testing him and were actually somewhat fearful of his amazing fighting abilities. To deliberately block his path was not something they intended to do.

* * * *

The new girl, Jaada Gellon, peered up at Jimmy as he moved past her, suddenly curious as to who the blond-haired boy was who seemed to have gained so much respect from his peers, at so young an age. She half-expected a fight to break out as soon as she saw him coming. His entire appearance was different, and she knew instantly that he wasn't Valtorian. Her interest piqued, she made a mental note to find out more about this fair-skinned, exceptionally built, and confident young man. Too embarrassed by her sudden interest in him, she was afraid to turn around and greet him, as she had the other boys in the room. No, she would have to question some of the girls later. Perhaps they could enlighten her.

As it was, the teacher made Jaada, the only new girl in school that scalon, stand up in front of the class and share something about herself. Usually self-assured, this time she found herself tongue-tied as she observed the outworlder intently watching her from the back of the room. Overcome by his pale beauty, she discovered a powerful attraction between them that stunned her, and she was hard-pressed to force any words past her lips. She couldn't take her eyes off him. However, assuming the girl was just shy, the teacher abruptly brought Jaada back to reality, verbally nudging her with questions about her previous home, her family, and her hobbies.

"I'm originally from…Rhenia," she stated through numb lips, her black eyes shining happily as they swept the many new faces studying her with curiosity. "From the Netarin district.

"My father is an imperial warrior and has been relocated several times, most recently to Konatha, where he now serves directly under Cambra Vernier, head of the imperial forces. It's always been hard on my family to keep moving around, but it's always fun and interesting because we get to meet so many new and interesting people."

"How long do you normally stay in one place, Jaada?" the teacher asked, fluffing back her own thick black hair as she studied the teenager.

At this, Jaada turned in surprise. “Um, actually, it varies,” she said. “Usually a few scalons, sometimes only a few mentas. One time, only three solarities.”

“It must be difficult to make friends then,” the teacher said. “And then to have to leave them so soon. It can be very difficult, I’m sure.”

“Y-Yes,” Jaada stammered, suddenly sad as memories of past friendships tore through her brain. “It has been.”

“Do you stay in contact with any of them?”

“No. It’s not possible. My father is strict with our use of our com devices for frivolous usage. Sometimes I write to people, but eventually they all quit writing, too busy with their normal, everyday lives to keep in touch.”

The teacher gave an empathetic nod.

“I hope you will stay with us a long long time, so you won’t have to lose more friends. We are very happy to have you here with us, Jaada. Welcome.”

At this, Jaada smiled warmly at her teacher, happy to have a kind woman who understood her secret pain.

“Thank you,” she murmured as she returned to her seat, amid clapping, happy smiles, and numerous greetings from most of the class. As she made toward her seat, she glanced up a bit self-consciously, instantly meeting the bright blue eyes of Jimmy Donaldson. He wore a soft smile on his face as he studied her. But he pretty much stayed to himself, ducking his head in his own quiet way as she drew closer.

Sliding into her seat, Jaada was very aware of when his attention became focused on her again, especially when he had the daring to reach a hand over to boldly stroke her hair, which cascaded behind her, about his desk. He didn’t seem to mind but merely enjoyed feeling the soft texture of her hair as it lay atop his digitexts. Since that was all he was doing, Jaada didn’t protest. But after a few micron she quickly sat up, yanking her hair from his desk with annoyance. Laughing to himself, Jimmy studied her reaction and then sat back quietly in his seat, his eyes barely straying from the back of her.

Afternoon repast couldn’t come soon enough for Jaada. So unnerved by the boy behind her, she practically bolted from her chair and outside to the yard, where many students chose to have their noon - *nubian* - meal during nice weather. Plopping onto a bench under a shady tree, she tore open her tote and nervously placed some berries into her mouth. She ignored all the new faces looking her way as she tried to keep her attention focused on her meal. She was unaware that Jimmy Donaldson had approached her from behind and was gazing down at her in uncertainty. Jimmy had never met a girl who intrigued him as much as this one did, but he still wasn’t very good when it came to speaking to one.

“Um, sorry about your hair,” he said at last, startling her. “I just think it’s so beautiful.”

At this, he captured Jaada’s attention as he moved to sit beside her on the bench, straddling it. He merely sat staring at her, making no move to pull out his own lunch.

“It…It’s okay,” Jaada said, unsettled by the way he was looking at her with those wonderful blue eyes, the color of which she had never seen before. No one in Valtor had eyes that color.

“Rhenia, huh?” Jimmy continued. “I’m originally from Earth.”

“Earth?” At this, Jaada gave him her undivided attention.

“Oh, sorry,” he said. “I meant Zarak.” He snorted. “Sometimes I forget myself.”

“I’ve never met anyone from Zarak before,” she said, impressed by this news. “Does everyone there look like you?”

Jimmy chortled at this, a grin touching the mischievous eyes he was so famous for at Travaar.

“Like me?” he said. “Why no. Not everyone looks like me. There are many different kinds of people on Earth. Some have blond hair, some dark hair. Even our skin colors are different.”

Jaada snorted as she refocused on her fruit. “Everyone looks pretty much the same in Valtor, give or take a star system,” she said.

“That’s not true,” Jimmy said, sliding closer to her. “I think you’re more beautiful than any girl I’ve ever seen here.”

At this, color suffused Jaada’s face, and she turned to gape at this strange boy, blushing profusely.

“Really?” she said, her tone full of doubt.

“Yes. You are.” Jimmy peered at her through his long, light brown lashes, so like his sister Cassia’s. “I’m Jimmy, by the way. Jimmy Donaldson.”

Jaada nodded, unable to speak. This boy was affecting her in ways she had never before experienced, and the feelings overwhelming her right now were incredibly exciting.

“J-Jimmy?” she repeated stupidly.

He chuckled again. “Yes, that’s right.” Then he suddenly turned away, overcome by basic desires, and opened his own repast tote, pulling forth the exact same fruit that Jaada was eating. They shared laughter at this discovery then remained companionably silent as they each concentrated on their meals.

* * * *

No one bothered them, but everyone in the yard had clearly observed how taken the two were with one another, and this bothered the other girls watching them. Already dislike of the new girl was brewing among some of them, since many had had their sights on the outworlder for some time now. The fact that he had never paid them any mind at all irked them tremendously because they knew that Jimmy Donaldson was the greatest catch in the entire school. He seemed to excel at everything and was extremely good looking as well.

“Hey, Donaldson!” one of the girls snapped, unable to take it any longer. She sauntered over to where the two were sitting. “You want to come over to my house after school and hang out for awhile?”

* * * *

Jimmy was dumbfounded by this since none of the girls had ever asked him anywhere before, most being too in awe of him, of his good looks and talents. Now, it was clear that the girl was vying for his attention because he had dared single out the new girl for his company. Glancing over at the sea of female faces glaring in his direction, he realized now that they were jealous of him sitting beside the new girl.

“Uh, sorry,” he told the girl named Capricia, lowering his gaze. “I usually go directly home after school.”

“But that’s not fair!” Capricia pouted, stamping her foot. “You’re old enough. Why can’t you just call your parents and ask them?” she said.

At this, Jimmy’s head came up with a firm retort. “Because I don’t live with my parents. That’s why.”

Unable to come up with a suitable comeback, Capricia lifted her hands to her hips, digging at the dirt with her foot in indecision.

“Well, perhaps another day then,” she said.

At the disappointment in her voice, Jimmy lifted his eyes to hers, for the first time made aware of how interested all the girls were in him. So wrapped up in his life at the palace and with all the sporting events he was involved in, he barely paid attention to the opposite sex. Until now.

“Perhaps,” he said, trying to be considerate, although he knew he never would. He had no interest in her or anyone else, except for the beauty who was sitting beside him. No female had ever made him feel as she did, and it was puzzling to him as to why. Capricia Sementa was lovely in her own way, as were many of the other girls. It’s just that Jaada had sparked something inside of him, jumbling his emotions and twisting his gut, even as he sat there with her trying not to admit it. Jaada was special, and he knew he wanted to get to know her even better.

With a snort of anger, Capricia crossed her arms, shot Jaada a scathing look, then stamped back to her friends, furious at being rebuffed.

“Why don’t you live with your parents?” Jaada said then, as they both watched Capricia storm off.

“They’re both dead,” he said softly, his words biting into her heart.

“Oh, I’m so sorry,” she said, truly meaning it.

Jimmy turned to her then, his face a mask of inner pain. “Don’t be,” he said. “It was a long time ago. They died in a car accident.”

“A what?”

“A car acci—” He paused then, realizing she had no idea what a car was.

“On Zarak, people use cars for transportation. Something like your rallids here. Intergalactic space travel is but a dream there. The technology is not as advanced as it is here. Cars are more dangerous and accidents more common.”

With this discovery, Jaada fell silent, and they remained quietly in one another’s company until it was time to return inside. However, both knew that this was the beginning of a special friendship they both hoped would last forever.

Chapter Eight

The sound of clanging metal caught the attention of Kaanig Altair as he was passing through the training bay of Landor, located just beyond the palace of Travaar. Moving in that direction, he entered the huge facility, pausing just inside to observe Jeiel Vernier clashing swords with his exceptionally brilliant ward, Jimmy Donaldson. It amazed him even now how skilled the boy had become in the handling of such weaponry.

"You twist, then turn, and then jab your opponent. Like this," Jeiel was heard saying, just before Jimmy surprised him with another one of his daring backward leaps across the mat, flipping himself several times out of his mentor's reach.

"Ha!" he taunted. "Try and do that to me now."

Shaking his shaggy head and grinning, Jeiel lowered his sword as he observed the dynamic acrobatic skills of his trainee.

"Well," he began, "if you're way over there, I'll never be able to teach you anything."

With that, after thinking about it, Jimmy again flipped his sword safely beneath him, securing it to his side. Performing a few forward flips, he landed with a self-satisfied smirk in front of Jeiel.

"There, jab me all you want to," he told his instructor, only then spying Kaanig Altair standing by the door, observing them.

"Dammen!" he yelled by way of greeting, giving a wave. "Did you see that? Jeiel thinks he can beat me?" Laughing, he quickly brandished his sword, only to have Jeiel easily knock it out of his hand with a powerful and skillful thrust. "Hey," he complained, dismayed now by what had just happened.

"You've a lot to learn yet, my friend," Jeiel countered. "Now let's say we take a break." Turning, he again lowered his weapon and moved toward his sovereign, who seemed amused by the spectacle. "Ziros," he said, bowing.

"If he's getting too cocky," Dammen said, "we'll need to break him of that."

"It's his age, I think. He only gets this way when he's training with me. It's all part of the fun of competition, remember?"

"Well, we'll see," Dammen said, not totally convinced. "He is quite flexible though, isn't he? I've never seen any of our men do acrobatics while battling it out."

Jeiel shot a glance back at Jimmy who was shadow thrusting and jabbing behind them.

"He is very skilled in that area, Ziros. Nimble and quick as well."

"A great asset," Dammen agreed, although his expression had sobered.

"Is it time, Majesty?" Jeiel asked, recognizing his master's intent.

Dammen sighed. “Yes, finally, Jeiel. We'll go now and bring her to Travaar. I have everything in order. I’ve already talked to Menakam and confirmed what you told me, and he has agreed to help me get my little Kaaniga into shape.”

“Very well, Ziros. I’ll prepare to leave immediately.”

“The ship is ready, Jeiel. I’ve overseen the supplies and fueling we’ll need to get to Zarak and back again. We can waste no time. I want Cassia out of that fanged institute and brought here safely. We have to do whatever we can to make it happen. I’ve delayed long enough.”

“Aye, Ziros. By your command.”

With that, Cambra Vernier departed, making ready for the most important mission that Kaanig Altair had ever planned to go on. To rescue the future queen of the Valtorian Empire.

* * * *

“Where has Jeiel gone?” Jimmy asked, looking about as he observed his friend hurrying from the room. “Is he coming back?”

“Not today, I’m afraid.” Dammen moved toward his ward, placing a hand on his shoulder. “Go shower and change, and I’ll take you back to Travaar for repast. Later, I’ll take you aboard my star cruiser and give you your first lesson on how to fly one.”

Jimmy’s ears perked up at this. “Really?” the boy said in disbelief. “I’ve been waiting ages for this. Yahoo!” Dashing away to carry out the Altair’s directives, Jimmy was as eager as any child to learn something as exciting as that, unaware that Dammen had another purpose in mind.

As Dammen watched him hurry away, he frowned and dropped his head wearily, his thoughts turning to the young woman he should have stolen away a long time ago. Recent reports had informed him of the seriousness of Cassia’s situation, but he had had to postpone his rescue of her until Menakam finally responded to the offer he had made.

But even as he considered the agreement he had made with his estranged half-brother, a deep fear entered his heart because no matter what happened now, he knew that nothing could be changed. That had been part of the agreement, and Dammen only hoped now that everything he had planned for his bride would turn out perfectly. Otherwise, he would experience a sense of failure that he had never experienced before, not in all his days as a galactic ruler. Cassia Donaldson had suffered enough because of him, and he had no desire to hurt her ever again.

* * * *

“You chart courses here, on this panel,” Dammen instructed his charge, indicating how it was done. “Once the course has been plotted, the helmsman immediately locks in the coordinates prior to engagement.”

“Wow,” Jimmy breathed, “just like on *Star Voyage*.”

Dammen frowned. That fanged *Star Voyage* again, he thought. He was going to have to find out what that was all about, or Jimmy would drive him crazy making references to it all the time. He had

hoped Jimmy would have forgotten much of his home world by now, but it appeared that such was not to be the case.

He stepped away from the terminal and peered down at the boy, aware that Jimmy was growing so fast that he could no longer actually be called a boy. Jimmy had, in fact, reached his eleventh year and was showing all signs of mentally and physically being well past that stage in his life. The advanced training and education Jimmy had received had done wonders for him, aiding him in becoming the mature youth he now was, as Dammen had hoped and intended for him to be. To look at him, one would actually think he was much older.

"What's wrong, Dammen?" the boy asked, catching the strange look on his guardian's handsome face as he looked down at him.

"I need to speak with you about Cassia," he said.

"Cassia! *At last!*" Jimmy said excitedly, as a bright smile erupted on his face. "Is she finally coming here?"

"Here, sit down first," Dammen said, indicating a seat, although he himself chose to lean back against a console and cross his arms. "And yes to your question. Jeiel and I plan to leave for Zarak shortly."

"Great!" Jimmy exclaimed. "I can't wait to see her. It's been years."

Dammen lowered his dark head, sighing softly as he considered what he had to tell him.

"I know it's been a long time since you've seen Cassia," he said slowly. "But I need to tell you now that it will be another scalon or more before I can allow you to see her still."

"What?" Jimmy shouted in disbelief, jumping up from his chair. "But…*why?*"

"Do you remember when you first came here? When I told you I wanted Cassia for my wife, my life mate, but that I wanted her to love me as a man and not as the ruler of a galaxy. Do you remember that?"

"Yes, I do." Jimmy sadly ducked his head then, the light having disappeared from his eyes as he slumped back into his seat.

"I need to keep her away from you until she is certain that she loves me," Dammen explained, although his heart was heavy and full of regret. Even now he wasn't certain he was doing the right thing by keeping the two siblings apart. "If she were to find out who I truly am and that I helped rescue you and helped you to get better, she might say she loves me because she feels an obligation to me." Dammen peered over at Jimmy with black eyes full of anguish. "I don't want her to feel obligated to me, Jim. I want her to truly love me as I am. Can you understand that?"

* * * *

It was a few minutes before Jimmy raised his blond head to peer up at the man he cared about more than any other in the universe, a man who had given him so much to live for and who cared as much for him as he did for Dammen.

“I understand,” he replied slowly, giving a sad nod. “It’s just that it is going to be so hard for me, knowing she is so near yet so far away.”

“I realize this, Jimmy,” Dammen responded, “but it’s necessary. In order for your sister to love me, you cannot be around to distract her heart or her thoughts. She has to love me completely before I can even tell her what her role in Valtor really is. If she knew I was the Kaanig and responsible for your parents’ deaths, she might and probably would hate me.” Dammen lowered his head with remorse, his own painful memories clouding his thoughts. “I don’t want Cassia to hate me, Jim. I love your sister, and I want her to love me back.”

“But, you’ve never met her, have you?” Jimmy said, peering up him curiously. “How could you love her?”

“I saw her, at your parents’ funeral, when she was protecting you. She was yelling at some lawman who was trying to drag you away.”

Jimmy gave a sad smile and nodded. “I remember,” he said.

“Your sister is beautiful and strong. These are the traits that made me fall in love with her. She showed me how loyal and protective she is of someone she loves.”

Jimmy sighed and lowered his head, staring down at his hands in his lap. It was a long while before he finally lifted his head with resolve and stood up.

“I’ll do whatever you ask,” he said at length, putting a hand to Dammen’s arm. “I won’t like it, and it will be hard for me, but I will do it.”

As Dammen considered him, his lips slowly curled into a gentle smile of relief.

“Thank you, Jimmy,” he said in a low voice. “You truly are a man now. But believe me, if everything works out the way I’ve planned, the rewards will be worth waiting for.”

And as Jimmy Donaldson observed the Altair’s sad countenance, all because of his love and worry over his sister, he knew that Dammen was right. It would all be worth whatever suffering they had to go through in order for Cassia to win the crown. And because Jimmy loved them both so much, he knew he would do whatever he had to in order to help bring it to pass.

Chapter Nine

Jimmy hadn't been in school for several solarities, and Jaada wondered why. When he finally appeared, her whole countenance lit up. From where she stood in the hallway by her locker, she observed his large frame moving down the hall. He hadn't noticed her yet, so it gave her a moment to study his exceptional physique, the golden blond hair shagged loosely about his lean face, and the well-muscled forearms hanging on him. Dressed in warrior's togs and black Kathian boots, he was extraordinarily sexy, as evidenced by the looks of longing every female in the corridor was casting in his direction. He looked like some wild man from Vultron, yet Jaada knew he was the kindest person she had ever met.

"Jaada," he called, spying her. He made toward her, only to suddenly be intercepted by Capricia Sementa and a group of her friends. Shoving herself right up against him, Capricia began running a curious hand up and down his muscular arm as if she owned him.

"Tell me you'll come over to my house after school today," she cajoled in her most sexy voice. "I've missed you lately. Where have you been?"

As Capricia tried coercing him, Jimmy lifted helpless eyes to peer over at Jaada who was eyeing the scene with disappointment and concern. Angry, she finally walked off to class, leaving him to untangle himself from the many female hands boldly running over his powerful physique. Not long afterward, he walked into one of the classes they shared. But this time, because of the assigned seating, he was forced to sit two seats in front of her and to the right.

* * * *

He glanced sadly at her when he came in, but she immediately turned away, avoiding his eyes. Sighing, he sat down and spent the morning feeling like an idiot because he had let the other girls overwhelm him like that. He had every capability of removing himself immediately from the situation, but he hadn't done so. Chiding himself because he had secretly been enjoying all the female attention (Heck, what guy wouldn't?), he now realized the mistake he had made, but vowed it would not happen again. As it was, he had rejected Capricia's invitation for the second time. Even now, his interests and thoughts were only on one person. Jaada.

He caught up with her later. He found her alone in the library, working on a paper. It was fortunate that there was a vacant console beside where she was sitting. As he deposited his pile of disks beside the *v'd'mr,* along with some digitexts, he looked down at her until she felt the need to glance up at him. Her eyes widened as a disgruntled frown formed across her rosy lips. However, before she could say anything, Jimmy reached out a hand to stop her.

"I'm sorry, Jaada," he said. "I hadn't intended for that to happen. In fact, nothing like that has ever happened to me before. You have to believe me. I just didn't know what to do."

She gave him a once over, miffed look. "I don't own you," she said. "Whatever you do is your own concern."

He scowled then, not caring for her manner towards him. She saw what had happened. What had she expected him to do? Shove everyone away from him with brute force? He sat down, suddenly angry.

"But you do own me," he whispered emphatically. "Since the first time I saw you!"

Her mouth dropped then, her eyes wide as she stared at him. He was peering at her with those gorgeous, mesmerizing blue eyes, and she melted beneath them.

"But…you've only…just met me," she countered with disbelief.

"And why are you so mad at me?" he asked. "Tell me." He studied her frightened expression then, unlocking the truth in her eyes. "If you don't want me, then why are you so jealous of those other girls?

Jaada gasped then for it was as if he had peered right into her soul. She made a quick attempt to rise, but he grabbed her arm before she could flee. Glancing about quickly, he made sure no one was watching before he dragged her through the huge racks of digitexts and *v'd'mr* disks lining the enormous room. She protested only slightly before curiosity won out. Once on the second tier of the building, he found a small vacant room, pulled her inside and closed the door. They were alone with one another, with a member of the opposite sex, for the very first time. Not counting family members, of course.

"What…are you doing this for?" Jaada said nervously when he finally released his hold on her arm. Rubbing it, she began backing away from him. But he would have none of it.

"I told you, Jaada," he said, moving toward her with purposeful intent. "You own me. I *am* yours. If you want me. So you can do with me whatever you want to."

"What…do you…mean?"

"Only…this," he said, grabbing her about the shoulders and pulling her against him. Her strength was no match for his, but it didn't matter. She fell into his embrace the moment his lips captured hers. Wrapping his arms about her, she moaned softly at the incredible security he offered her, and slowly her hands moved to rest on the great strength of him. It was a first kiss for both of them, but no one observing them would have thought that. Jimmy's maturity had developed in many ways, due mainly to the incredible mentors he had had throughout his years in Valtor.

His lips burned against hers like a seasoned lover, and he could feel the heat rising between them, so much so that she finally managed to push him away, albeit reluctantly.

"We…shouldn't be here and…doing this," she said, her face flushed, although he could tell she was disappointed.

"You're right," he whispered. "But sometime, we'll be alone. Just the two of us, in a more appropriate place." As his breathing slowed, Jimmy ran a hand through his mane before turning to open the door. Jaada bit her lips with indecision before making a quick move to thrust the door shut again, tearing the knob out of his hand as she did so. Surprised at this, Jimmy turned to question her, only to find her hands about his neck, pulling him down so that her lips were suddenly against his again. Within moments, the heat had reached an even higher level before Jimmy had sense enough to tear himself away, before he did something he definitely knew he would regret.

“We can’t do this,” he said, his voice husky with suppressed desire. “Not here. Not now.”

* * * *

Although Jaada was nowhere near through with him, she nodded that she understood. As she straightened her clothes and hair, she realized now just how much she cared for the boy-man with her. She hadn’t fooled him, and she was so glad she hadn’t. And it was clear that she did own him and that he wanted her to own him. Every glorious bit of him. Jimmy Donaldson was truly hers, she realized, smiling happily, and no one, she vowed, was ever going to take him away from her, not if she could help it.

* * * *

The next few solarities passed quickly for them. Dazed by their affection for one another, they snatched every moment they could to be alone, whether meeting on their way to school, after the H’Sans had discreetly dropped Jimmy off, or whether in the library or some other quiet, out-of-the-way place in the school. They became inseparable, and this inspired even more jealousy among Capricia and her friends than they actually deserved.

Most of the spite directed toward them was unjustified altogether, since Capricia and most of her classmates never had any trouble getting the other boys to notice them. It just upset them that there was one boy in the entire school whom they couldn’t have. The fact that some newbie had snagged Jimmy her first solarity there was what angered them the most, and they vowed to get even with Jaada, if it was the last thing they ever did.

Even the boys, having seen where Jaada’s interest lay, felt betrayed and threatened by the relationship she shared with Jimmy. Whether any of them wanted to admit it or not, they were indeed jealous of them, of what the two obviously shared. That Jaada preferred an outworlder over them made them even more angry with the situation.

“Who does she think she is?” Capricia hissed at one of her friends, sitting behind her in science class. “He’s always with her, always got his arm around her. Kermina said she even saw them kissing just outside the gate the other day. No wonder Jimmy won’t come over. She keeps stopping him.”

“He’s always said no to you before,” her friend said wisely. “Is that why it bothers you so much? Because he rejected you? I doubt Jaada stopped him. It was probably his own decision.”

“Why should it bother me?” Capricia said, tossing back her head flippantly and ignoring the truth of her friend’s words. “I can get any boy I want.”

As the girls continued socializing in their usual cut ‘em up fashion, their mouths dropped wide at sight of the huge space vessel that suddenly appeared in the sky to begin a quick descent, landing soundlessly in the gigantic sports field behind the school. At their loud gasp of surprise, the entire classroom came to life and, ignoring their teacher’s protests, bolted towards the windows to view the uncommon spectacle.

“Why on earth would one of the Kaanig’s ships land here, do you think?” was one of the most commonly asked questions, but no one had an answer.

It didn’t take them long, however, to find out the reason for the unexpected visit.

* * * *

Kaanig Altair's presence in the school caused quite a commotion, and students came dashing from their rooms to witness this most powerful and familiar personage as he walked down the corridor, his overwhelming stature and presence radiating throughout the entire building. Accompanied by two brawny H'San, the students observed him entering the headmaster's office and closing the door behind him, while the sentries remained posted outside.

Jimmy was sitting in his Kathian literature class when Dammen arrived, although he was unaware of this since his classroom was on the opposite side of the school from where the Altair's ship had landed. When Dammen suddenly appeared in the doorway, all heads turned to look at this awe-inspiring figure. At sight of him, Jimmy's mouth dropped and he instantly glanced back at Jaada in fear, realizing what was about to happen.

"Come, Jimmy," Dammen ordered, not even introducing himself to the teacher or the other students, assuming they already knew who he was. "It's time." At the familiar way in which Kaanig Altair spoke to Jimmy Donaldson, all eyes turned with amazement and curiosity to look at him.

Overwhelmed by a powerful surge of rage, because of the Altair's lousy timing, Jimmy frowned and obediently stood up, knowing better than to keep Dammen waiting. Hastily grabbing his stuff, he packed everything he could carry, shoving it all into his bag. Then he reluctantly made toward the door, to where Dammen stood waiting. As the Kaanig stepped aside to allow him to pass, Jimmy shot Jaada a wide-eyed look that spoke volumes, then he turned sadly and departed, immediately followed by the Altair.

"Pardon the intrusion," Dammen shot over his shoulder as he left. He had closed the door, but the other students, unable to control their curiosity, dashed from their seats, following the Altair and his party all the way outside. Since the instructors were just as excited by the visit as the students, they allowed their students this unusual disruption, wanting to see the Altair take off in his famous craft as much as they did.

Jaada was the last one to leave the room and trailed the rest, feeling lost and alone now as she watched Jimmy depart with the ruler of the entire galaxy, secretly wondering why Jimmy had never told her before that he knew Kaanig Altair personally.

Once at the unit that would take them inside the ship, Jimmy halted and turned back to search the crowd, his heart all twisted inside at thought of leaving Jaada behind. When he spotted her, he murmured something to Kaanig Altair and, at Dammen's nod of approval, tore back across the field to say goodbye. The entire school watched with rapt fascination as Jimmy Donaldson took Jaada Gellon into his arms for a farewell kiss that left her shy and trembling in his wake. After mumbling a few words to her, Jimmy quickly turned and raced back to the ship, but only Dammen was aware of the pained look that crossed Jimmy's face as he turned to peer back at Jaada one last time.

"Find out who that young woman is," he instructed one of his men, "and everything you can about her. I'll meet with you when I return from Azor."

Later, once the Kaanig's famous cruiser, the Star Lord - *Le'pra Zh'r* - was put to flight, Dammen informed Jimmy of his reasons for removing him from the school, never once mentioning the girl Jimmy had kissed in front of the entire school population.

“I’m taking you to Planet Azor for a while, Jimmy, to stay with Cambra Vernier. Cassia is now at Travaar, so I cannot have you in the vicinity. I need to keep you separated from her, for reasons of which you are already aware. And I'm sorry, but you cannot return to school here either.”

As he listened, Jimmy nodded obediently, although he yearned to be back with Jaada. He told her he’d always be her friend, always be there for her, even if her father got shipped out again. But what was he supposed to do now when he had barely had a chance to say goodbye to her? Every promise he had ever made to her would be impossible now, and he couldn’t believe how much he missed her already. Faith, he wondered as he peered through the large port hole beside him, at the stars floating past them, would he ever see Jaada again? He ducked his head, embarrassed at the thought of Kaanig Altair seeing him cry again. Maka! Why did everyone he care about have to be taken away from him?

* * * *

Dammen frowned as he read the boy’s thoughts, now feeling more like a beast than he did before. Never had he thought that Jimmy would fall in love at such a tender age. But then, Jimmy was more mature than most of his peers, so it really didn’t surprise him that the boy felt this way over a girl. Still, knowing of the female now was a good thing since he, as Kaanig, had it in his power to rectify matters. And as he considered Jimmy’s sad countenance, he knew that this was indeed a matter he needed to fix. He had no wish to cause Jimmy Donaldson any further heartache.

Chapter Ten

"Her name is Gellon, Ziros. Jaada Gellon. Her father, Astar, is an imperial warrior and has been relocated thirteen times in the past twenty scalons."

At this, Kaanig Altair's thick dark brows raised with surprise and concern. He stared at the tech in disbelief. "That many?" he said. "A man with a family?"

"Yes, Majesty."

The Altair fell silent then as he considered this information, shocked that this expectation was inflicted upon men of such loyalty to the empire. He glanced over at Jeiel, who stood listening quietly, also thoughtful on the matter. He was as surprised as Dammen at this news.

"This will change, Jeiel," Dammen told him, giving him a no-nonsense stare. "Clearly, this soldier has more than paid his dues."

"I agree," the cambra said, nodding.

"I want this man and his family stabilized, on any planet of their choice. Immediately."

"Aye, Ziros."

"I also want him compensated," Dammen continued. "A scalon's wage and a promotion. Discover what he enjoys the most, what his skills are, then make it so. Provide housing assistance as well."

"By your command, Majesty."

"In fact, Jeiel, I want some of your people to begin an immediate scan to determine how many other of our troops are in similar situations. I think I may impose a change in policy for the future to accommodate these men who are willing to go where needed, despite the cost to them and their families. I will put a limit on the number of times these men can be moved around between planets and star systems."

"Aye, Ziros. I will see to it at once."

Dammen nodded then and signaled his other man to leave.

"Lay the information on my desk, Kyl. I'll go through the rest of it later. But make a copy for Cambra Vernier as well."

"Majesty." The tech nodded and departed then, leaving Dammen alone with Jeiel.

"I think I may invite this loyalist to Travaar," he said, moving to take a seat behind his large desk. "It would be good for me to meet these men at some point, to thank them personally for their outstanding service."

Jeiel thought about it and nodded. “I think that’s a good idea. We need to encourage future loyalty and show these men how much we appreciate them.”

Dammen shot his friend a look that bespoke other motives.

“I’m afraid that I also have another reason for inviting this particular fellow, this…Gellon…here. I need to know more of him, and I also want his family to come for next evening repast.”

Jeiel nodded knowingly. “It’s because of the girl, isn’t it?”

“Yes. I don’t want Jimmy angry with me for breaking up his relationship with her. He cares for her a great deal.”

“I understand, Ziros.”

“Bring Jimmy tomorrow night for repast, but don’t tell him the Gellons will be here, too. I want to observe their reactions upon seeing each other so I’m certain I’m making the right decision here. Meanwhile, do as I have ordered, and we’ll take things from there.”

“Aye, Majesty. It will be as you say.”

“Oh, and Jeiel,” Dammen said, drawing him back. “We need to keep Jimmy out of the garden.”

“Understood, Ziros. Perhaps Jimmy could invite this Jaada back to Azor for a few orons so she and Jimmy can be reacquainted without fear of him running into his sister.”

Dammen’s lips curled at this. “Sounds like a good idea, Jeiel.”

“Majesty.” Bowing, Jeiel turned and departed, aware of the necessity of keeping Jimmy from running into his sibling, at least until the appointed time.

* * * *

Jeiel sat observing his young charge in the midst of his hand-to-hand combat training with Ijon. Although his man was a formidable opponent, it seemed that James Donaldson was almost his match. Smiling at sight of the two facing off, both hands clenching the opponent’s with surprising strength, Jeiel could not believe how much effort Ijon had to put into trying to force Jimmy down. Ijon’s fingers were tightly clenched with Jimmy’s as each tried to force the other backwards. Bulging muscles and grunts of intensity were manifested on both sides, and Jeiel could only shake his head with amusement as he observed the two. Even now, the boy’s abilities impressed him to no end.

At length, Jimmy finally backed off in defeat, not quite the man he was hoping to become. As yet, his strength was still no match for that of a well-seasoned, well-trained imperial warrior. Breathing heavily, he leaned over to rest hands on his knees as Ijon slowly backed away, considering the boy with some amazement.

“You are very strong for one so young,” he told Jimmy with affirmation. “I did not think it would take you this long to desist.”

Jimmy straightened slowly, his chest frantically heaving with the extreme effort he had put into their little training session.

"I'm gonna take you one of these days," he promised. "Just you wait."

Ijon grinned at the underlying strength in his tone, but seemed unperturbed. "I look forward to it," he said lightly, moving a hand to his own brow, to wipe off the sweat there. "Any time."

But Jeiel chose that moment to interrupt their verbal jousting. "That was very well done," he told the boy. "But I think we should end here. Go clean up and meet me back at Adoniah. We've been invited to dine with the Altair tonight, so don't dawdle."

"Great," Jimmy said in English, smiling, still preferring his own language to Kathian. "I'll be ready in a jiff." With that, he moved to put away his combat gear and weapons laying about before scooting off to shower away the workout grime. When he had gone, Jeiel turned to exchange grins with Ijon.

"So, what do you think?" he asked. "Has he improved at all?"

Ijon laughed. "I've never seen anyone take more to fighting than that one," he acknowledged. "He will be an exceptional warrior one day."

"To be sure, Ijon. But putting that aside, do you have anything else to report?"

"Well," the warrior began, "I have noticed one weak area, one he seems reluctant to admit."

"Which is?"

"Sometimes his mind wanders. He has trouble focusing."

"What do you mean?"

"I'm not sure exactly. But whatever he is thinking about, he becomes suddenly withdrawn and…sad. I thought I even saw him crying a few times when he thought I wasn't looking."

Jeiel was shocked to learn of this, although he had noticed similar behavior during his own training sessions with Jimmy. That the boy was still grieving for his family was apparent and was something that needed to be brought to the Kaanig's attention. He felt that Jimmy should have gotten over his grief a long time ago.

"Thank you, Ijon. That will be all," he said, dismissing him. When he had gone, Jeiel paced about the training room for a while before, frowning, he turned and headed back to Adoniah.

Chapter Eleven

Jaada Gellon was sitting in the schoolyard eating her afternoon repast, feeling forlorn and abandoned. Jimmy had been gone for nearly four mentas now, and she hadn't heard from him in all that time. What was even worse, since his abrupt departure, her classmates had begun teasing her about her having known all along that Jimmy had something going with the Altair and that that was why she had singled him out for her affections. With callous and hurtful words, they had wounded her deeply, especially Capricia Sementa and her friends. They had been having a heyday with her ever since Jimmy had left.

As Jaada replayed over and over in her mind the nasty tricks Capricia had started playing on her since that day, a depression overwhelmed her that she had been trying hard to overcome. Once safely home, she cried herself to sleep each night, wishing that all the bad times would just go away and that Jimmy was there to protect her. She missed him so much.

"Well, well," Capricia began one afternoon, with her usual, snotty sarcasm. "What's wrong, Highness? Your important boyfriend not around to share repast with you today? That's too bad." With hands on her hips, she slowly sauntered around the bench Jaada was sitting on, smirking at her sad expression. "Poor baby. No one here to defend your honor today? What a shame." Then, before Jaada could stop her, Capricia suddenly moved forward to snatch Jaada's fruit drink from the bench. "Perhaps this will help."

Then, to Jaada's further dismay, Capricia proceeded to remove the lid and pour the drink all over Jaada's head, where the red, sticky liquid dripped down her face and over her clothes. Amid peals of laughter, Capricia stepped back, casting amused looks with all of her classmates who were sitting around, watching the scene with obvious delight.

"Hey, wait!" another boy yelled, hastening toward them. "You forgot the entrée." Snatching up a smaller container from the bench, following suit, he likewise removed its lid and unceremoniously dumped its entire contents over Jaada's head as well.

Laughing uproariously at this, the other students decided to join in the fun, surrounding the humiliated target, who was sitting in shock and disbelief, with upraised arms, unable to believe what they were doing. Making selections from their own meals, many other students began pelting Jaada with the messiest food they could find, dumping it on her and rubbing it into her white top, unaware that Jaada's father, the headmaster, and two accompanying warriors were on their way down the hall to get Jaada. The men's eyes widened with outrage when they came upon the scene, and the headmaster wasted no time in halting the shenanigans going on.

"*That's enough!"* he bellowed, his face red with fury, as Jaada's father hurried toward his daughter. At sight of him, Jaada burst into tears. Eyeing her messy clothes and hair, Astar Gellon's eyes filled with compassion and concern as he helped her up, uncertain what to do next. The headmaster glared at the students as they gaped wide-eyed at the adults, particularly at the two hulking H'San warriors standing by the door. Even if they had wanted to make a break for it, they knew they would never get past them. "What's going on here?"

Of course the headmaster already knew what the problem was. It had been going on ever since Jimmy Donaldson had been taken away by the Altair. And now His Majesty was here again, to get Jaada. He knew the Kaanig was going to be furious when he saw this little catastrophe.

"You are all on detention tonight," he blustered, uncertain how he should handle the matter. The fact that the entire class had ganged up on poor Jaada this time was the worst he had ever seen.

"Not just tonight," came the sudden deep voice of the Altair as he stepped between the two guards to stand in the yard. At sight of him in person, for the second time in their lives, the students instantly fell on their faces in fear, guilt washing over them at what they had done. Terrified, it was a moment before any of them even dared sneak a peek up at him.

At the sudden hustle to show him the respect he deserved, Dammen glared coldly at each student, quick to note how each one cringed as he stared down at them from his great height.

"I want each of these students detained for five orons after school tonight," he told the headmaster, ignoring the groaning that escaped everyone's lips at this directive, "then for two orons a day for the next thirty solarities. Increase their workload as well. Then, at the end of the menta, I want a written paper from each one of them of no less than 20 pages, sharing what they have learned. I want those reports sent to me personally through the *v'd'mr*. Perhaps then these hellions will have learned to show respect to all people and not just to me. And if anyone gets out of line, Zy Hemena, I want to hear about it. Give me their names, and I will personally speak with their parents. And no one is allowed to call in for any reason during that time period. No sickness, no appointments, no sports or after school activities. *Nothing* is to interfere! Is that understood?"

"Y-Yes, Majesty," said the headmaster, bowing in obeisance, his own fear and respect for Kaanig Altair emanating forth through his demeanor. He moved aside then as the Altair then focused his attention on Jaada, who stood in humiliation before him, dripping all sorts of disgusting items from her person.

"My apologies for not arriving sooner, pa'atay," he said to Jaada, in Kathian. "You may clean up in the locker room, then you will accompany me to Travaar since you will be dining with me this evening."

Jaada exchanged confused looks with her father, who nodded the affirmative and smiled.

"Th-Thank you, Majesty."

With that, Dammen immediately turned and proceeded back to his ship, not expecting anyone to question his orders or his authority.

"I'll explain it all to you later," her father whispered in Jaada's ear as he led her from the yard to collect her things from inside. "But I have wonderful news. So wonderful you may not believe it."

Upon hearing this, at seeing her father's excitement, Jaada finally smiled, realizing that things might not be as bad now as she had first believed they might be. And faith, she thought, dinner with the Altair at Travaar. It was something most Valtorians only ever dreamed about. Smiling as she thought about what the rest of her lousy day would bring, Jaada slowly and uncomfortably made her way to the locker room, her main wish being that she could get out of her soggy, ruined clothes as soon as possible.

Chapter Twelve

Jimmy stood in the main dining hall at Travaar, peering through one of the tall, curtained windows, at the twinkling lights of the garden outside. His thoughts were miles - *korons* - away, on all the people he had lost. Even now he could feel the familiar sadness washing over him as he thought about the family he still loved and missed.

Although he enjoyed the life he now had in Valtor, he knew that nothing could erase the feelings he still had for his parents and his sister. And now, even now, he felt an ache in his heart for Jaada. It wasn't just some passing fancy. He knew he was young, but he loved her and missed her terribly. If only the Altair hadn't removed him from her so quickly and without warning. If only…

"Jimmy."

* * * *

At the familiar voice of Kaanig Altair intruding into his thoughts, Jimmy hastily brushed the tears from his face and turned to greet his guardian. Yet even as he did so, Dammen was quick to observe his movements. Frowning with concern for him, it only verified what Jeiel had already told him.

Despite their best efforts to comfort Jimmy, the boy was still grieving for his family. There was little else they could do right now to help him overcome it, except…bring someone else back that he loved. Motioning to Jimmy, Dammen indicated the small family just entering the room behind him, with Jeiel.

"We have guests," he told him. "May I introduce one of my finest warriors." Waving a hand at the large warrior, the man's life mate, and the three children accompanying them, Dammen was quick to make the Gellons feel welcome and at ease in his home.

"Good evening," Jimmy said, stepping forward to lay his hand atop the man's in the traditional hand greeting of Valtor.

"The pleasure is ours," Astar Gellon responded warmly, smiling at the impressive man-child he had heard so much about from his daughter. "His Majesty has told me wonderful things of your combat skills. I know you will grow into a fine imperion."

"Thank you, ziros," Jimmy replied, moving to Pasana Gellon to share kind words of greeting with her as well.

Pasana turned then to introduce her children standing behind her, only then stepping aside to allow Jaada to move to where Jimmy could finally see her. When he did, his mouth dropped open with clear surprise.

"*Jaada!"* he gasped. "I didn't know…that is, I had no idea that…"

At this point, Dammen moved forward to explain his deliberate oversight in not sharing with Jimmy just who it was that had been invited to the palace for evening repast.

"I wanted to surprise you," he said. "That's why we avoided sharing their family name with you. These are the Gellons, Jaada's parents."

"Believe me," Jimmy said, unable to take his eyes from Jaada's own smiling face, "I *am* surprised, Ziros. Pleasantly surprised." Reaching out, he took her hand in his and drew her closer. "I've missed you," he whispered, for her ears only.

"And I you," she said. "I had only hoped I might see you again, so I am just as surprised as you are right now. I had no idea you would be here."

As the Altair observed their reunion, he knew he had done the right thing. The sadness evident on Jimmy's face a moment ago was no longer there, only joy at seeing the lovely Jaada again. He glanced at Jeiel, who smiled back, nodding in agreement at his unspoken message.

"Oh, and these are my brothers, Timson and Jedido," Jaada hastened to explain. "Tim is eight and Jedido is twelve."

"Hey, fellas," Jimmy greeted, giving a wave. "It's nice to meet you."

"Hello," they returned in Kathian.

The boys grinned at Jimmy Donaldson as they observed how he held their sister's hand overlong. Already their mischievous expressions foretold of future teasing of their sister for having a boyfriend at Travaar. Both could hardly wait to get home with her and begin their major attack on the matter.

"Shall we sit," the Altair suggested, kindly indicating their places. "Our repast will be ready shortly. "Jaada," he continued, "you may sit beside Jimmy, if you wouldn't mind. You boys," he added, already aware of what the boys were thinking, deliberately moved them closer. "You may sit here, right next to me."

"Really?" they gasped, mouths dropping in disbelief. "Right next to you?"

"Yes," he said, grinning, knowing that such an honor would erase their mischievous thoughts for a little while. He wanted nothing to ruin Jimmy's relationship with their sister, and this was the best way he could think of just then to prevent their interference.

* * * *

Jaada's parents were as dumbfounded as their sons when they were selected for such a high honor. Then again, everything happening to them lately was mind-boggling. Just to have been invited for an evening meal with the ruler of all of Valtor was amazing in itself, not to mention with Cambra Vernier as well. They were the two most powerful men in the galaxy.

Sitting beside their sons, the Gellons felt just as honored as they did and politely accepted everything offered them by the many servants who efficiently wandered about with well-timed precision, bringing in succulent appetizers or keeping their glasses filled, or doing whatever it was their duty to do. They felt so happy and comfortable in the Altair's presence, they barely paid Jaada and

Jimmy any mind. Sitting at the end of the long table, the two were deep in conversation, sharing all they had been through since their last meeting, which is exactly what the Altair had hoped they would. Although he focused on his conversation with Jaada's parents, he was also keeping a partial ear to what was happening at the opposite end of the table as well.

* * * *

Holding hands beneath the table, Jaada and Jimmy had little else on their minds just then except one another. That their feelings hadn't changed at all was something they hadn't expected. In fact, they realized after only a few moments that they had actually intensified during their forced separation.

"My father has been given a promotion," Jaada told Jimmy. "That's why we were invited here. The Kaanig is allowing him to choose a place to settle down in. We won't have to keep moving anymore."

Jimmy shared her enthusiasm, smiling, until a twinge of fear came at him. "So where will you be living then?" he asked, intently searching her face. "Here on Konatha?"

"I…really don't know yet," she told him, her smile fading. "I hope so. Otherwise, I may never get to see you again."

Frowning, Jimmy squeezed her hand in understanding. "That's what I was thinking, too," he said. "I don't want you to move away," he continued in a panic. "I want you here, with me."

"I know," she whispered sadly. "I don't want to leave you either."

She turned then to her father, who was sitting at the end of the long table, interrupting his conversation with the Altair and Jeiel.

"S'lpa, forgive me, but do you have any idea yet where we will be moving?"

At this, Dammen gave the two his full attention, having been afraid this subject might come up. Setting aside his drink, he waited patiently for Astar Gellon's reply, bracing himself for the response.

"Why, yes, dear," he answered, after a brief glance at his host, "I have decided to settle permanently on…Degma."

Her mouth fell open then in clear disappointment. "Degma?" she said. "Why there?"

"Why not?" he replied. "It's a beautiful planet, thriving, green. And besides, my sister lives there. You used to love going to Degma to visit her when you were younger. Don't you remember?"

Jaada nodded and fell silent. Degma was indeed a lovely planet, but it was *skuayl'a* - light years - away from Jimmy Donaldson. Heartsick at losing him again, she turned to meet his gaze, both aware of what this would mean for them both.

* * * *

As he studied them and read their thoughts, Dammen realized that allowing Astar Gellon a choice in the matter might have been the wrong thing to do. Frowning at his own stupidity, he hastened a servant over to quickly refill his goblet. Faith, why hadn't he seen this one coming? he wondered.

Because you're a nice guy, that's why, his conscience told him. *And you wanted to reward a man for a job well done.*

* * * *

Jimmy studied Jaada a moment, both feeling a bit out of sorts now, before turning askance at the Altair.

"May we be excused, Ziros?" he asked.

"Yes," Dammen said, aware the two wanted to be alone. "But stay out of the garden. It's off limits."

"But why?" Jimmy asked, wondering why the Altair would ban him from the most romantic place at Travaar.

"Don't question me, Jimmy. Just obey me."

"Yes, Majesty," Jimmy said, lowering his eyes diffidently. "It will be as you say."

With that, Jimmy took Jaada's hand and began leading her from the room.

"Jimmy, take the *ga'lif* to Azor. Cambra Vernier has lovely gardens there."

Jimmy brightened at this, turning his attention back to his sovereign. He glanced over at the cambra, who nodded his appreciation of the idea.

"Yes, Ziros. Thank you," he said. "Good idea."

With that, he led Jaada to the lower levels of Travaar, taking the long, scenic route, for Jaada's benefit, until they arrived near the War Room. Opposite that was the *ga'lif* through which he led Jaada to Planet Azor, his current residence.

"This is Adoniah," he told her, leading her from the *ga'lif*, through Cambra Vernier's war time bedchamber and down the long spiral staircase beyond. All the while Jaada peered around in wonder at the elegance of her surroundings, unable to believe she was first at the famous palace of Travaar, home of Kaanig Altair, and now she was at Adoniah, home of his top military commander. No wonder her schoolmates were so jealous of her, she realized.

"Follow me," Jimmy said, still leading her by the hand through the foyer and toward the main entrance of the mansion.

"James," came a weathery voice. "Is there a problem?"

At this, Jimmy and Jaada halted, peering back at the older man standing behind them in the foyer.

"No, Sajak," Jimmy responded happily. "I'm just showing Pa'atay Gellon here the gardens. The Kaanig suggested it, ziros."

Sajak eyed the two teenagers warily and could sense what they were up to, but he merely nodded with twinkling eyes.

“I understand,” he said. “If His Majesty suggested it, then it must be all right. Enjoy your evening.”

“Thank you, Sajak.”

As the servant returned to the bake room, Jimmy gave Jaada a wink as he hastily led her out the main entrance and toward the well-maintained gardens of Adoniah.

“Jeiel has all sorts of gardens and groves here,” he told his companion excitedly. “Flower, herb, fruit…all sorts.”

“I can smell their fragrance,” Jaada said happily, lifting her head to enjoy the enticing smells of nature and enjoying the soft wind blowing through her hair as he led her behind the huge residence. The songs of many night birds could be heard all around them.

“I live here right now,” Jimmy told her. “For reasons I can’t share with you just yet. I did live at Travaar, until that day the Kaanig came and took me from the school. He had good reason. I just didn’t like the way he did it. Plus, he was in a hurry.”

As he spoke, they rounded the corner of the structure until they came in full view of the acres of gardens that lay behind the cambra’s home.

“It’s beautiful,” Jaada gushed, peering at the appealing scene through the encroaching darkness.

“Come on,” he said, taking her hand.

Leading her quickly down several of the adjoining walkways that led away from the building, he eventually led her down a few stone steps and stopped in a secluded area. A grassy knoll sloped to the flat center area that was square-shaped, with two benches placed opposite one another along the long hedgerows lining the walks. Facing her, he held both of her hands tremulously, leaning his head back a moment to glance up at the twilit blue sky that held a sprinkling of stars and two full moons, uncertain how to proceed.

Then before more words could be spoken, she was in his arms, his lips covering hers. With a moan of longing, she clung to him, as hungry for him as he was for her. This was all they had both wanted since she had arrived a few orons earlier, and they were barely able to contain their feelings for one another.

“I can’t bear the thought of you moving away from me,” he whispered. “I don’t know when I’ll be able to see you again.”

A strangled sob erupted from her lips at his words. “I know,” she managed, lost to him as he moved his lips and hands over her. “I wish I could stay with you.”

They were down on the ground then, rolling in the grass in the center of the square, a tangle of arms and legs as they consumed as much of each other as they could. They struggled to maintain their self-control in order to avoid doing something they knew they would both regret later.

“I love you, Jaada,” Jimmy finally admitted, still kissing her, aware of her stiffening beneath him at his words. Starting to cry, she tearfully admitted the same for him.

Forcing himself away to peer down at her in the growing twilight, he gently reached up to brush the stray hair from her wet face, enjoying the feel of her soft form lying beneath him.

"So what are we going to do?" he asked her softly, still breathing heavily.

"I don't know. Degma is so far away from here."

"I want to join with you, Jaada. Some day when we're older. Will you wait for me until I can find you?"

"Y-Yes," she told him, smiling happily through her tears at this admission. "I want to join with you, too."

"Well, that's something then," he told her, his lips curling in amusement. Gazing at her a moment longer, he then brought his lips to hers again, kissing her as if there was no tomorrow.

"We'd better go back," Jaada finally said, breaking away. "I'd hate to have Kaanig Altair find us like this. Or even the cambra."

Jimmy snorted. "Yeah, I know. That'd be embarrassing, wouldn't it?" Helping her up, he assisted her in straightening her clothes and hair as best as he could and then his own, brushing away grass and dried leaves from their clothing. After feeling more presentable, they soon returned to the dining hall, hand-in-hand.

* * * *

When Dammen saw them, he frowned at their guilty expressions but made no comment, aware of what they had been doing. He only wished he hadn't had to send them to Adoniah when he preferred to keep a closer eye on them, but he did not want to risk having Cassia run into her brother while at Travaar. That would have ruined all of his other plans, something he couldn't afford to have happen. Not yet.

"I'm afraid the Gellons must be going now," he told Jimmy, studying his flushed face with dismay. Reading the boy's thoughts, he was glad to learn that his behavior toward Jaada had been fairly respectable, considering his raging hormones when he was around her. "Perhaps we can arrange for you to spend an afternoon with Pa'atay Gellon before she and her family depart for Degma next vesta."

"I'd like that, Ziros," Jimmy said.

* * * *

As the Gellons made to leave, Jimmy still found himself reluctant to let go of Jaada's hand, as if afraid he might never see her again.

"I don't want you to go," he whispered to her again, almost urgent in his pleading. "Please, tell me again that you love me, Jaada."

"I do," she answered softly, as she followed her family to the rallid awaiting them outside. "I love you."

Jimmy leaned over and kissed her then, one last time, ignoring everyone who might be watching.

"I love you, too," he said. "Don't forget. You're gonna marry me, right?"

"Marry you?"

"Join with me?"

"Yes, I promise."

With that, he finally released her, watching halfheartedly as the love of his life entered the vehicle and was quickly whisked away from him.

* * * *

Dammen stood aside, watching the two thoughtfully, aware now of the deep affection they had for one another. Blinking at his own thoughts on the matter, he moved to put an arm about his ward's shoulders as they returned inside the palace, glad for once that he was able to read minds. Otherwise, he knew he would always be in the dark on important matters such as these.

"Do you love her, Jimmy?" he dared ask, feeling he had a right to a verbal acknowledgment.

"Yes, Majesty," he answered truthfully, without hesitation. "I…want to…join with her. When we're older, of course. I've already asked her, and she accepted."

Kaanig Altair nodded then, at the boy's answer and at his wisdom. And he knew now that he had to make certain that no further harm came to Jaada Gellon, or he knew that Jimmy Donaldson might never forgive him.

Later, once the boy had retired to Adoniah for the night, Dammen gave an immediate order to Jeiel for a constant, yet discreet guard to be put on the Gellons until he decided otherwise. If Jaada Gellon was to become part of his family in the future, then she and hers needed to be given every amount of consideration and protection that he could afford them.

As Jeiel hurried away to do his bidding, Kaanig Altair gave a weary sigh and made his way to his office. He dropped back into the large chair behind his massive desk, folded his arms, then stared thoughtfully at the huge pile of papers, digitexts, and folders resting there, wondering what life was truly like in the world outside of his. Frowning, he tossed back a final drink then made off toward Cassia Donaldson's suite of rooms, to check on her security there. As if he didn't have enough to worry about just then.

Chapter Thirteen

"Majesty?"

At the familiar voice, Dammen lifted his dark head from the cold, marble floor of the family chapel, an intricately-domed building located just outside of Travaar. Pushing himself back onto his haunches, from his spread-eagle position of worship, he whispered a few closing words to his Source, then put a hand to his knee and rose up to his full height. Sighing, he turned to face the cambra, who was patiently waiting for his sovereign to finish praying.

"Jeiel?" the Altair responded quietly, peering intently at his friend.

"They have departed, Majesty."

"Thank you. Be sure the guards are in place on Degma, as I ordered. I anticipate no problems, but I want them protected from here on out. Especially the girl. See that she is given top priority. That no harm comes to her."

"And Jimmy?"

"Send him to me. I have decided to send him to live on Ulstra until I am sure of Cassia's feelings for me and of her loyalty to the empire. I cannot have James around either of us anymore. It will be difficult keeping the two from running into each other. It will just be easier if I send Jimmy away for a time. Besides, I have plans for him as well."

"I understand," Jeiel replied. "I will bring him to you shortly."

"Bring him here, Jeiel. To the chapel. I think it would be a good place for me to speak to him about all of this."

* * * *

When Jimmy arrived a half an oron later, it was to find the Altair again on his face, as he had been when Jeiel had arrived earlier.

"Um, Dammen," Jimmy said, embarrassed at finding the Kaanig Altair in such a position on the floor. "Jeiel said you wanted to see me."

He waited then, not certain what to do. Barging into the Altair's private worship time didn't seem right somehow. Although Dammen knew Jimmy was there, it was some time before he finally set himself back on his haunches, with finality, and stood up.

"Please, sit with me," he answered at length, slowly turning to face the boy. Jimmy nodded, following him wordlessly to one of the six rows of wooden pews, three on either side of the chapel. Once seated, Dammen paused a moment longer as he considered his next words.

“I’m afraid I must move you again, Jimmy,” he told him bluntly, looking over at him. “To Ulstra this time.”

“But…why?” Jimmy asked, aghast at this news. “I like it on Azor.”

“I know. You liked it here on Konatha, too. But circumstances have forced me to play a different hand where you are concerned. If you remain on Azor, your safety may be jeopardized because of my enemies. If I move you now, there is less chance they would learn of you. They have already learned of Cassia, attacked her while at the aviary in Zaratan. Prior to that, two men were caught sneaking onto the grounds here to find her, so I feel it safer to keep you well apart for now.”

“What?” Jimmy came up sharply then, gripping the pew in front of him. “Did someone hurt her?”

“Yes, but not badly. And the man responsible has already been terminated. The two other men caught sneaking into Travaar just prior to that were caught before they could carry out whatever their intentions were. They have already been dealt with,” Dammen admitted, although he probably shouldn’t have. But it was the only way he could make the boy understand how justified he was in wanting to send him to Ulstra. “But don’t fret. Cassia is fine. I just don’t want you in harm’s way either. It would be difficult for me to watch out for both of you as I want to do. On Ulstra, there are people there who will give you their entire attention and keep you safe. With my busy schedule, and Jeiel’s, I just feel it is better for all concerned to move you to a safer location.”

“But, how long will I be there? Away from you and Jeiel?”

Dammen looked at him with a sad expression.

“I’m not certain, Jimmy. Just until I’m certain things are between me and your sister as I would have them be.”

Jimmy ducked his head then, a hopeless feeling washing over him. First, he lost his entire family, then the girl he loved, and now he was going to lose the two men he loved most in the universe. He began crying then, trying to hold back the tears but failed. This time, he made no effort to hide them.

“I understand,” he said at length, sniffing. “It will…be…as you say.”

“You won’t be alone, Jimmy. You know that our Source is always with you. And I will stay in personal contact with you as much as possible. And we have the *ga’lif*. Jeiel and I will try and check on you when we can. Is this acceptable to you?”

“It will have to be, Ziros.” Sighing, Jimmy dropped back into his pew, wiping his face with the back of his hand. “When…will I leave?”

“Immediately, I’m afraid. The sooner the better.”

Nodding, Jimmy slowly stood up, pausing to look around. “How come I’ve never been here before?” he asked curiously, gazing about at the quiet beauty of the holy place.

Dammen stood with a heavy heart, looking down at the man-boy who had found a place so irrevocably in his heart.

“I meant to bring you,” he said, laying a hand to Jimmy’s shoulder. “It is through the Source of all things that we have always ruled this galaxy. I usually pray in my quarters, but this is where the Altairs have always come to praise, worship, and fellowship with other believers. It belongs to my family.”

“Is that why you wanted me to meet you here? Because I am…family?”

“Yes, Jim. I consider you my brother, remember?”

Jimmy turned then and flung his arms about him.

“I *love* you, Dammen!” he blurted uncharacteristically, shocking the man with his unexpected declaration. “Please don’t forget about me!”

* * * *

The sovereign froze, the boy’s words piercing to the deepest recesses of his heart. He returned the embrace, sharing his own affection for him. His own lips quivered and, secretly, he wished he didn’t have to send him away at all.

Damn Menakam anyways! Why couldn’t his half-brother have just stuck to their agreement, then he wouldn’t have to resort to this extreme measure? He knew that Menakam was the one responsible for the attack on Cassia and already felt guilty at having trusted Men to begin with. But it was too late to change anything. He had to follow through with his plans.

“I will bring you back to Travaar as soon as I can,” Dammen promised, struggling with his own turbulent emotions. “When the time is right, and no sooner.

“When the time is right?”

“Yes. I promise. When the time is right. I will bring you…home.”

Jimmy stepped back to peer up at him. “Will you see to it that Cassia gets my cat? Maybe he'll help her not to feel so alone here. I...I can't bring Jaspar with me anyways.”

A lump formed in Dammen's throat at this. “I promise,” he said, nodding.

Jimmy arrived on Planet Ulstra two orons later.

Chapter Fourteen

"Toss me one, will you, James!"

Jimmy Donaldson turned from his place atop the wooden ladder, peering down at Manaham Zehemerata. Reaching up, he plucked a ripe fruit from the branches of the tree, quickly tossing it to the farmer.

"Thanks," the Ulstran said, rubbing it across his shirt until it was shiny, before biting into it, smiling even as the sweet juices ran down his closely-shaven chin. "Good crop this scalon."

Jimmy plucked another and examined it a moment. "Certainly is." He wiped it on his sleeve before taking a bite himself. "It's delicious."

"I'll send some home tonight for you and Grif," Manaham said.

"Thanks. That'd be great." Jimmy held the one he was eating between his teeth, then transferred the luscious red sarana fruit he was picking to the basket he was balancing on top of the ladder, carefully placing each one into it.

As Manaham finished his sarana, he stood watching the Zarcon, nodding with satisfaction at his movements. The boy had learned much in the few mentas he had been living on Ulstra, including the Ulstran dialect native to that region of the planet. The boy was incredibly bright, so it was no wonder the Altair had sent him there to learn as much as he could about farming.

"Well, that's the last one," Jimmy said, hoisting up the basket of fruit atop his shoulder and carefully making his way down the ladder with it. Manaham was quick to relieve him of his burden and took the basket over to the supply transport he had waiting in the lane a few steps away.

"You did a good job today, Jim," Manaham told him proudly. "Tomorrow I'll take you over to the Pareia homestead, and Quin can give you the run down on raising animals instead of crops. The Altair wants you well rounded in all aspects of farming and agriculture."

Jimmy wiped his brow with a rag and nodded. "I know," he said. "And mining."

"You'll be taken to the mines when Kaanig Altair feels you are ready. It seems you may be around long enough to become well trained in that area as well."

Jimmy shrugged sadly as he thought about the length of time he might be stuck on Ulstra. "It's all pretty interesting," he said. "It… helps me keep my mind off of…well, things."

"Come on then," the farmer said, placing a consoling arm about him as he led him to the supply vehicle. Although the Altair had not shared all the reasons of why Jimmy had been brought to Ulstra, Manaham knew that Jimmy was lonely for his own family. That much he was aware of, so he made it a point to distract Jimmy whenever possible. "Let's take this load down to storage until we can transfer it to market tomorrow. Jina's fixed us a great repast tonight, and I can't wait to sink my teeth into it. Grif said he'd stop by afterward and get you."

“I don’t understand why I can’t stay with you,” Jimmy whined. “It makes more sense, since I’m working here.”

“Grif Melder is a wise man, a village elder,” Manaham said as they climbed into the supply carrier. “Kaanig Altair wants you to learn from him as well, so having you live with him is the best way for you to do that, too. Grif is too old to be following you around all day to talk to you about other important issues. So he has you at night, while I get you during the day.”

Jimmy frowned. “He could have just told me that.”

Manaham shot him a grin, sometimes wondering about the Altair’s reasons for doing things as he did, too. Still, Dammen’s plans usually worked out in the end, so the Ulstran knew the boy had nothing to worry about just then. He was in good hands with Grif. Since Grif was a former imperial warrior, Manaham knew the elder had a great many things he could teach the boy. But why the young Zarcon was so important to the Kaanig Altair at all was a mystery even to him.

* * * *

Jaada was on her way home from her new school on Degma when they caught up with her.

“Hey, Gellon,” came the snooty, yet familiar voice of her classmate, Shelana Bejada. “Didn’t I tell you to stay away from my boyfriend?”

Everywhere Jaada went, it was the same thing. She attracted every good-looking boy each time she entered a new school, and each time she made new enemies among the female population.

“I’m sorry. What was that you said?” Jaada turned, pausing to view the attractive young woman moving toward her, as well as the small army of support friends she had brought along with her. They stood a short distance away, just in case Shelana needed their assistance.

“You heard me!”

Shelana hurried toward her, anger in her every step. When she was two feet - *crimina* – away, she halted in her tracks and reached out a hand to shove Jaada backwards.

Jaada, more experienced now in dealing with these jealous types, stumbled momentarily before straightening to stand her ground.

“Why would I want your boyfriend?” she asked. “I’ve already been selected by the most wonderful boy in the galaxy.”

Shelana was taken aback by this news, but not for long. “You lie,” she huffed, getting right up into Jaada’s face then. “You’re just saying that to cover your tracks. You’ve been wanting D’non ever since you got here.”

“He’s a friend, that’s all.”

“Well, I’m giving you fair warning. Stay away from him, or else.”

Jaada was growing amused now, enjoying the way Shelana's nostrils flared when she was upset. She glanced over at the other students and grinned, having been through all of this before. For some reason, she wasn't afraid this time, perhaps because she was so confident in Jimmy Donaldson's love for her that it no longer mattered what others thought about her.

"Or else…what?"

In response, Shelana drew back to strike Jaada, only to have her wrist suddenly caught from behind by a large, masculine hand. Shelana instantly turned, gaping wide-eyed at the huge imperial warrior standing over her, gripping her in a vise-like manner.

"You will refrain from this," he told her, his brusque manner making it clear he would not be argued with. "By order of the Altair."

When fear registered on Shelana's face, the man released her, much to her relief. She stepped back and rubbed her wrist, her glance shifting quickly to Jaada, who appeared as stunned as Shelana by the man's appearance. Looking up at the warrior, who stood watching her with wariness, she realized the futility of further baiting or threatening Jaada. Without a word to either of them, she scooted past the giant and flitted away like a frightened moth. Her friends waited for her, then rushed away behind her, all as shocked by what had happened as Shelana.

When they had gone, the satisfied warrior turned to stare mutely at Jaada. Then, with a half-bow of respect in her direction, he departed, leaving her standing in awe of what had just occurred. That Kaanig Altair had sent someone to protect her, a mere peon in the galaxy, was inconceivable. Still, recalling the attack against her on Konatha, at the school, it was clear Kaanig Altair wanted no similar episodes against her, regardless of where she was living.

With a feeling of gratitude and overwhelming security, knowing now that the Kaanig was looking out for her, Jaada turned with a smile and continued on her way, her steps lighter now than they had been in a long time. It was certainly good to have friends in high places, she thought, and she could hardly wait to get home and share with her family this good news.

* * * *

Jimmy Donaldson leaned over the wooden fence to peer at the ugliest beast he had ever laid eyes on. Disgusted, he wrinkled his lips as he considered how he was supposed to ever milk the stupid thing when it was so hard on the eyes he didn't even want to get near it.

"Hey, are you gonna stand there all day admiring it? I asked you to bring it in the barn so I can show you what to do."

Quin Y'han'na, foreman of the Pareia ranch, located just on the other side of the village from the Manahams, stood glaring at the teen, expecting no argument.

Jimmy jerked back and gave Quin a sheepish grin.

"Uh, sorry," he said in the Ulstran dialect he was becoming more fluent in with each passing solarity. "It's just…I've never seen an animal like that before."

Quin chuckled then. "Yep, he's pretty homely, ain't he? But these creatures give the best milk in the district."

Jimmy nodded and backed away from the fence, aware that he could not avoid the inevitable. With a sudden burst of speed, he bounded toward the fence, tucked himself into form and front-flipped himself into the pasture, landing in a pile of manure, several criminas in front of the ugly nanda beast. Amazed at the boy's talents, Quin watched in amazement, until Jimmy landed. Then he gave a loud snort.

"Guess you need to aim a little better next time," he said, a smile wide on his weathered face.

"Yuk," Jimmy grimaced, as he lifted his grimy boots and stepped away from the manure pile to wipe them off in some weeds. "Yeah, I do need better aim." With that, he caught the rope Quin tossed over the fence and ambled toward the huge beast, who stared at him with curiosity, quietly chewing his cud, much like a Zarconian cow.

It took Jimmy over half an oron to rope the beast and get it into the barn, and all the while Quin just laughed at his many failed attempts, reluctant to share his secret tips with him just yet. He was having too much fun watching the Zarcon trying to do it the hard way.

"Next time, son, how about just using the flanking stick. That'll get them beasts inside in no time."

Jimmy frowned at the older man. "Well, you could have told me that before."

Quin chortled louder this time. "I could have, but I wanted to see if you'd figure it out for yourself first." Laughing, Quin slapped Jimmy on the back as he led him toward the hundreds of beasts lined up for milking. Had he had the boy bring them all inside, they would have been outside all night.

* * * *

Later, Jimmy was quick to growl his dislike of nanda beasts to Grif, the village elder whom Dammen had requested he reside with until he called him back to Konatha.

"Are all farm animals like that in Valtor?" he asked the older man as he reclined on his small bunk, hands behind his head. "So ugly and…stubborn?"

Grif was sitting by a cozy fire, smoking a long, curled Rhenian pipe. "We have our varieties, just like on Zarak. Our Source loves variety, remember?"

The teenager considered this a moment, then turned over.

"Here, don't go to sleep just yet," Grif said. "Come over here and sit with me awhile. I want to speak with you."

"Oh, come on," Jimmy whined. "I'm tired. I've been chasing down coptas all day, and milking ugly nanda beasts, and chasing those little chicken-like lizards, whatever they're called."

"Do not make me ask twice, James."

When the old man used his formal name, Jimmy knew he dared not disobey. Grif gave daily reports to the Altair, so he knew better than to anger the man. Another lecture from Dammen was not

something he always wanted to hear. So, dragging himself upright, he sighed despondently and got up from his bed, moving to sit cross-legged on the braided rug in front of the fire.

"All right," he said, yawning. "I'm all ears."

"Next menta the Altair will be taking you to the mining fields. You will spend more time there until you become adequately familiar with the entire operation."

"Well, why's that?" Jimmy asked, not really interested. "I still need to learn more about farming and stuff."

"You may return here for that later, once you master the mines."

"What does it matter?"

"The mines of Ulstra are the most valuable in the galaxy," Grif explained, somewhat perturbed with his young charge. "They contain the ore needed for our weaponry and our ships. The Altair wants you to learn how it is mined, refined, and utilized. He wants you to learn every aspect of the mines so that when you are older, you will understand their importance and how they must be maintained and protected. Perhaps he will put you in charge of them, who knows? I only know that you are to learn everything, so do not argue with me on the matter."

Jimmy ducked his head and thought about this. "All right, Grif. I understand. It will be as you say."

Grif studied the blond-headed man-child, realizing the weight the young man was already carrying. Jimmy had confided much with him, which surprised him, but he knew he had to follow the Altair's directions to the hilt. He knew that only a fool would choose to disobey or change the Kaanig's orders. Apparently Jimmy Donaldson had already learned this and, although he didn't like what he was hearing, he was submissive and seemed willing to obey the Altair, which was a good thing.

Grif nodded agreeably. That Dammen had chosen well in wanting to train this particular Zarcon in various skills, knowing he would be an asset to Valtor in future, he was sure. The boy was intelligent, gifted, and a hard worker. That he was also to be a well-rounded imperial warrior would make him very valuable indeed.

Chapter Fifteen

Kaanig Altair arrived on Ulstra a few solarities before Jimmy was to be moved to the mines. When he came upon Jimmy, it was to see him hoisting bags of Ulstran grain onto a wagon flatbed. Jimmy's physique had broadened noticeably in the mentas he had been on Ulstra, he observed, and Dammen felt the term 'boy' could never again be associated with the Zarcon. Physically anyways. Jimmy Donaldson had grown into an incredible male specimen, with the biceps to prove it.

"Farming appears to have done you some good," he commented casually as he made his way toward him. "I hope it hasn't been all work though. You need some energy for the mines."

At the familiar voice of his guardian, Jimmy tossed a final bag onto the flatbed and turned, his expression clearly one of happiness at seeing him again.

"Dammen!"

Grinning, Jimmy hurried toward the Altair and flung his arms about him.

"Are they treating you well?" Dammen asked, laughing as he set him away to scrutinize him. "You don't seem to be suffering."

"It's only my heart that is suffering," Jimmy admitted. "I miss all you guys and…Jaada."

Dammen nodded his understanding, knowing how he felt. "I've missed you, too," he told him in all honesty. "But it's good to see you now. And I apologize for not coming sooner. But galactic affairs and…Cassia…have kept me busy."

At this, the boy's expression brightened even more. "How is she?" he said. "How is Cassia? I really miss her, you know."

Dammen's countenance fell momentarily as he moved away from him, not wanting to reveal whatever problems he was encountering at the moment.

"She is…well," he told him.

Jimmy, sensing that he was withholding information from him, stared silently at his rugged back as he moved toward the house.

"And what else? Surely, there is more you're not telling me, Dammen."

The shaggy dark head came up then, and the Kaanig gave a soft snort. "Seems I'm making some headway with your sister, Jim. Wearing her down a bit. That day she was attacked, she actually admitted to missing me. It's a good sign. Means she doesn't hate me as she did in the beginning."

"But, that's a good thing, isn't it? It's what you've wanted, right?"

"There is more that I need from her though, Jim."

“What? I mean, you want her to love you, right?”

“I need to be certain of her loyalty to me and…to the empire…before I can reunite you with her. She still doesn’t know everything about me. Not yet.”

Aghast at this, Jimmy’s blue eyes widened noticeably. “How could she not?”

Dammen sighed then and turned his full attention on him. “Perhaps because I haven’t told her yet,” he explained. “It just seemed easier for her to love me if she thought I was the same as everyone else, Jimmy. Ever since she came to Konatha, she has wanted to escape and go home to Zarak. If she knew who I really was, of what I am capable, she would do anything and everything to get away. And she would no doubt…hate me even more in the process.”

“Not if you’re honest with her!”

Jimmy couldn’t believe what he was hearing. The Altair was afraid that his sister would leave him if she learned everything about him? That was ludicrous. By his way of thinking, Dammen was the most awesome person he had ever met and believed Cassia would agree with him.

“I’m sorry, Jimmy. Things must be this way for a while longer.”

Jimmy shook his head in disbelief. “I’m sure you know what you’re doing, Dammen,” he said. “You may be underestimating my sister though. I only wish things were easier for both of you than they seem to be.” He sighed aloud and frowned. “I hope Jaada and I don’t have such problems when we finally get back together.”

“Don’t worry about Jaada,” Dammen said. “My men have been looking out for her. She is doing well on Degma. And I was thinking that, once you’ve trained a menta or so in the mines, that I can take you there for a visit.”

Jimmy’s ears perked up at this news. “I have to wait that long? Can’t I go now, before I start training?”

“No. I want to take you myself, but I won’t be available. You’ll just have to wait until I have the time. I’m sorry.”

The man-child dropped his head in disappointment.

“I understand. Your position keeps you so busy I don’t know how you stand it sometimes.”

Dammen patted his shoulder. “It is difficult being away from those I care about, Jimmy. Don’t think it isn’t. And not everything always works out as I'd like.”

“Then who am I to complain?” Jimmy said, lifting his gaze to his. “My pain and suffering cannot match what you must go through every solarity.”

Dammen considered him, admiring his wisdom and stoic acceptance of the reasons behind his having to wait to be reunited with those he loved.

“You are growing into a very mature person,” he observed, staring at him intently. “When Cassia and Jaada finally get to see you, I know they will not be disappointed in who you have become.”

“Thank you, Ziros. That means a lot coming from you.”

Dammen turned, glancing about, at the field to one side and at the large farmhouse in the distance.

“Is Manaham around? I need to speak with him before I leave.”

“He’s in the house talking to Grif.”

“Come along then. I want to update them on some of my plans for you, and I want you to be informed as well. That way, you won’t have any unanswered questions. I think you’re old enough now to hear more than I’ve been sharing with you.”

Jimmy smiled as he listened. Nodding, he tore off his work gloves and accompanied the Altair toward the farmhouse, an unusual feeling of satisfaction lurking just beneath his youthful demeanor. Any time he gained favor in the eyes of Kaanig Altair was a wonderful thing and made up for all the impatient waiting he was doing, as difficult as that was.

Chapter Sixteen

The gargantuan hauler towered above the two grizzled Ulstran miners like Jupiter over Mercury. Shadowed by one of its massive tires, the two men relaxed beneath its wings to watch Kaanig Altair and his small entourage accompanying their foreman across the wide dirt field, towards the main plant. Exchanging looks, one grimaced with distaste and spat into the dry sand beneath his feet.

"What do you make of that?" he said. "It's unusual for the Altair to come here in person."

"Dunno, Dar," his companion responded in similar Ulstran tongue, shrugging. "Yep. Been awhile since anyone from the top came around here."

"Maybe he's going to make some changes," Dar replied, crossing his brawny arms, "I only hope they're good changes." He continued watching as the small party vanished into the main office. "And what's with that Zarcon? Never seen his sort around here before."

"Dunno. We'll just have to wait and see. He is kinda young though, ain't he?"

"That's why I'm curious," Dar said. "And for him to be with the Kaanig seems really peculiar."

"Like I said. We'll just have to wait and see. I'm sure Fanta will let us know what's going on soon enough."

They didn't have to wait long. Within the oron, Jarrel Fanta, the plant foreman, reemerged from his office and began heading their way. Halfway there, he noticed the two men observing him and signaled them to join him. Waiting until the men came within hearing distance, Jarrel began sharing his news.

"The Altair has issued a command for us to train his protégé," he told them. "A Zarconian named Jimmy Donaldson. We are to comply without question and give this boy every consideration, with access to everything of the highest security clearance. The Kaanig wants the boy to learn the entire operation."

"Great," Dar growled. "Just what we need when we are already behind schedule."

"The Altair said not to worry about all that, that he would notify our customers and get an extension."

The two men exchanged looks of surprise, then shrugged.

"All right. But I hope this isn't some display of imperial corruption, his showing favoritism to this Zarcon."

"I wouldn't worry about that," Jarrel told Dar's companion. "The Altair expects this lad to work his way up. No favoritism there."

“All right then,” the miner snarled in reluctance. “We’ll teach him everything, but I hope we’ll get some recompense when we’re all done.”

Jarrel shot the man a nasty look. “I don’t know about that, but knowing the Altair, we’ll probably benefit in some way. Just be careful the boy doesn’t get hurt. I’ll be bringing him by in the morning, so be ready. He’s going to be here at least till the end of the scalon, learning the ropes around here. I want you two to look out for him since you've been here longer than anyone. He does know the Kathian dialect, but the Altair says the boy is fairly fluent in Ulstran already, so feel free to use it so he gets some practice.”

“Yeah yeah, we’ll get right on it.” Both miners nodded in a manner that relayed their put-out feelings, but they knew better than to argue the matter.

Jarrel stared at his two best men, pursing his lips with indecision. “See that you leave nothing out of his training. It’ll be our heads if you mess up with this boy. Understand?”

“Yes,” they both growled after a moment, looking at the ground with disinterest.

“Good. And don’t forget who we’re dealing with here. The Altair seems to think highly of this boy, so don’t louse things up or you can both start looking for another job.” Their heads shot up at this, their mouths dropping at this unexpected twist. Neither was willing to lose what each had worked so hard to gain over the past twenty scalons. “And if either of you is caught drinking around this boy, you’re both done here. Do I make myself clear?”

Gulping at this unexpected statement, the two men nodded mutely, bristling beneath their hard demeanors.

“Now get back to work. I’ve seen you lollygagging for the past oron. Don’t think I didn’t notice.”

“Yes, ziros,” both said simultaneously, their lips tightening at this reprimand before skulking back to the mining area. Although they hadn’t been the only workers hanging about, trying to learn what was happening with the Altair, they were the two singled out as an example to the other slackers. “We were just curious, is all.”

Jarrel Fanta stood with hands on hips, his feet planted widely as he watched them leave.

“Well, you know what’s up now, so get back to work and see if we can get caught up. You know as well as I how behind we are with our orders.”

* * * *

As Jarrel studied their angry backs, he soon turned at the familiar sound of the Kaanig’s famous space vessel putting to flight. Frowning at the task that lay before him, he ducked his head with indecision before returning to his office. No one would feel the wrath of the Altair more than him, he knew, if Jimmy Donaldson failed to achieve the incredible goals set before him. Shaking his graying head, he returned to where the boy awaited him, hoping that everything went as planned. He had no desire to encourage the disfavor of the Altair any more than he desired it from his own workers. Still, he had given his word that the orders would be carried out, and he intended to see it through, no matter what.

* * * *

"Come on, boy! Put your back into it!"

Jimmy Donaldson shoved the large steel, wheeled contraption with every ounce of strength he possessed, every muscle and sinew straining against the force vying against him.

"I'm…*trying!*" he snarled back, grimacing as he managed to move the heavy, mineral-laden cart only a few inches. With sweat dripping down his beet-red face, it was all he could do to keep it from moving back against him. Just as he was about to give up and release it to the fates, the two men on either side of him stepped forward to assist him in shoving the rickety contraption the rest of the way up the rails and into the darkened tunnel beyond. Releasing it with gratefulness, Jimmy moved back and straightened as his two mentors completed the strenuous task of transferring the mineral to the loading ramp. From there, the precious cargo would be placed into a turbo elevator and sent above ground to await refinement.

"How…many of…those…do you move…a solarity?" he managed between breaths, taking in great gulps of air as he tried to recover from his overexerted efforts. With the back of a hand, he swiped at the sweat droplets on his brow, then stumbled back to collapse on the ground, throwing both hands behind him, bracing himself as he sat there, his large chest rising and falling rapidly as he relaxed and tried getting his heart rate back to a normal pattern.

Dar and Pada paused to look at the boy and grinned.

"A hundred or more," they answered, showing not the slightest wind at all for their own efforts. "Been doing this for some twenty scalons," Dar continued. "Takes awhile to get used to it."

Pada stared down at the boy, already impressed with the boy's intelligence and abilities thus far. "It'll take awhile," he told him. "But you'll get it."

"Well…why doesn't…the Altair…make an easier way for this…job to…get done?"

The elder shrugged, exchanging looks with his gnarled coworker. "Dunno," he stated. "Probably doesn't know. Never seen him down here before."

"Oh." Jimmy stared quizzically at the two old miners, chewing on his lower lip as he considered the plight of the workers all these years. "Well then, has anyone ever mentioned it to him? About changing the way things are done around here?"

Again the two men shrugged. "Never seen much change in all my solarities," Dar said. "No sense complaining now." He slapped at the air and made a face. "Come on now. That was the last one you'll have to be doing today, so don't worry about it. Now we'll show you what happens up on top, when they begin the refining process."

"All…right," Jimmy said, slowly pushing himself to his feet and brushing the dirt off his pants. "I hope it's easier though than what we just did."

"I guarantee it," Pada assured him, showing off his crooked, stained teeth as he moved to place an arm about him. "Believe me, things will get a little easier from here on. The worst is over. Easy to learn, difficult to perform."

“You got that right,” Jimmy agreed, allowing the men to lead him back to the turbo lift that would take them the hundreds of feet - *criminas* - back up to the face of the planet. “If the next few mentas are as bad as the last three, then I think I’ll be inclined to quit.”

At this, the men turned to see if he was serious. But finding only humor in his expression, they slapped him on the back and laughed as they stepped into the unit that would soon take them to the fresh air they all craved.

Chapter Seventeen

Two mentas to the day that Dammen had brought him to Ulstra, Jimmy Donaldson came upon his two trainers, Dar and Pada, sitting in a dank corner of the cavern below, passing a bottle between them. They were unaware of his presence and, since they were already well into a besotted condition, were slow to react when they saw him. Jumping up at sight of him, they tried quickly to hide the bottle and pretend soberness, but it was too late.

"What are you doing?" Jimmy asked curiously, already aware of their clandestine activities.

"Wha--? Uh, um…noth..nothing," both murmured shamefacedly.

Jimmy beamed at them. "Hey, don't worry. I already know that half the population here likes to drink," he told them. "I wasn't born yesterday, you know."

Both men exchanged looks of relief, realizing that the boy was going to keep their little secret amongst them. They watched as Jimmy strolled over to crawl onto a large rock and position himself comfortably.

"Hey, don't let me stop you," he said, waving them on. "I'm not going to tell anybody."

The men blinked at this with some surprise. As they glanced at one another, Dar nodded. Pada then reached behind a boulder and slowly drew forth the few bottles they had hidden there and dared offer him one.

"Care to join us, lad?" he asked, waving the bottle at him.

"I don't know," Jimmy answered, eyeing it warily before slowly reaching out a curious hand to accept it. "I've never imbibed before."

With a disgusting belch, Dar ran a filthy hand across his mouth before carefully settling himself in the dark corner he favored.

"You gotta start somewhere," he managed sloppily, hoisting the bottle to his lips for a long swig of Ulstran ale.

"Are you allowed to drink on the job?"

Pada's rotten teeth became exposed as he grinned at him. "What the boss don't know, won't hurt him," he chortled. "Go ahead, have a sip. It'll put hair on your chest."

"Oh…okay." Jimmy tugged off the stopper and moved the bottle to his mouth, grimacing at the smell. He held it away to frown at it a moment, then shrugged. All the while the two men watched him, with looks more of humor and curiosity than meanness evident on their faces. Leaning back, Jimmy took a long swallow, bracing himself against the burning warmth that swarmed through his innards like heated acid. He coughed and spluttered only a moment before settling back to take another swig of the liquid, clearly enjoying the sensation. This time, he held it in like a man, his lips curling into a wide

smile of self-contentment. Laughing aloud at his maturity and handling of the experiment, the two men leaned forward to pat him on the back, clinking bottles with him in toast before raising their own bottles to their lips. Before they knew it, three orons had passed. But it wasn't until the foreman came looking for them that they realized what they had allowed to happen.

Jarrel Fanta scowled darkly at the drunken trio when he located them in the darkest part of the mine. Propped up against a larger boulder, the three were entangled as one, having fallen there from their previous seating arrangements. They were singing loudly and off-key, not one of them making any sense.

"*By all the stars!"* he blasted at them, stirring them from their drunken stupors to peer up at him. "What did I tell you two! Didn't I tell you *not* to drink around this boy! Didn't I? And now the Altair is here looking for him, and—*fang*, just look at the state he's in! Maka!"

"It's not…their fault…" Jimmy gushed in a drunken manner, a lopsided grin on his face as he gave his nearest comrade a pat on the back. "It was…m-my…decishun entirely…"

"Faith, how am I ever going to explain this to His Majesty?" Fanta said, a fearful tone to his voice as he wrung his hands in consternation. "Perhaps—"

"Perhaps you won't have to," came the cool tone of the Altair, who stood just behind the foreman, glaring at the scene before him. Fanta immediately turned and bowed himself away as the drunken trio hastily pulled themselves together at sight of their sovereign. Still, they were unable to keep the silly smirks from their faces as they exchanged looks and instantly burst into loud guffaws at their own behavior.

"Hi, Dammen," Jimmy gushed, giving him a mild wave. A moment later, he slowly pushed himself to his feet, swaying dizzily once upright. Turning to his coworkers, he saluted them and nodded happily. "Thanks, men. It's been…enlightening…" Then he turned a bit unsteadily and slowly made his way toward the Altair, ignoring the glowering look on his handsome face. "Don't be mad," he told him, daring to lay a familiar hand on his arm. "I had…a good time."

"It would appear so." Dammen stood with arms crossed, his icy gaze now rooted on the two miners who had dared initiate his young charge into a world he had tried so hard to shield him from. Uneasy, the foolish grins finally dropped from their countenance, and they carefully rose to their feet, taking care to show the Kaanig the reverence he was due. Keeping their eyes averted and their graying heads down, they waited for him to speak, both afraid of the punishment he would inflict upon them. They knew it would not be good.

"Ziros?" Fanta said, watching the Kaanig with remorse.

At length, Dammen relaxed his stance and stepped back. "Do nothing," he advised. "This was bound to happen sooner or later. If not here, then somewhere else. So do...nothing."

Fanta's eyes widened with surprise.

"Y-Yes, Majesty," he said, glancing at the two miners, noting their reaction to Dammen's unexpected words. Their heads shot up with obvious relief.

"Thank you, Ziros," Pada said gratefully, only a moment before his comrade echoed the same words.

“This *will* not happen again,” Dammen told them in an authoritative manner, his tone once more cold and unyielding.

“Aye, Majesty,” all three chimed. “Never.”

“See that it doesn’t.” With that, Dammen turned. He clamped a firm hand on Jimmy’s shoulder, then led him away and out of the mine.

* * * *

“What were you thinking?” Dammen asked his young charge, once above ground. “Is this what I sent you here for?” He gave the boy a smoldering look, his rage barely held in check. “Well?” he demanded when Jimmy remained silent. “Is it?”

“N-No,” the youth stammered, suddenly ashamed of his own behavior. Ducking his head with undisguised guilt, he dug a toe in the dirt as he waited for Dammen to continue with his reprimand.

“I think you’re done here,” Dammen said with a sigh of resignation. “I’ll have Fanta move you to the processing plant for awhile. Then I’ll return and give you a respite.”

Jimmy brightened and turned to look up at his friend. “A vacation?” he asked, grinning at the thought.

“Not exactly.”

“Jaada?”

“If you behave,” Dammen told him, frowning.

“*All right!*” Jimmy whirled away, slapping his leg gleefully. His unsteady movements made his companion reach out a quick hand to keep him from toppling over.

“Go to your quarters and sleep this off. That’s an order.”

“Yes, Ziros,” the boy murmured in subservience, all too familiar with the Altair’s tone of authority. He ducked his head then and put a hand to his lips, trying to hold back whatever was suddenly threatening to spew back up.

“Better yet, I’ll take you there myself.”

At Jimmy’s groan of displeasure, Dammen purposely grabbed him and practically dragged him to the barracks he shared with some of the other miners who commuted home every five solarities or so to see their families.

“In there,” Dammen said, shoving his charge into the nearest bath chamber. When Jimmy reappeared about ten micron later, he ignored his sovereign and stumbled his way to the end bunk in a corner of the room.

“The room won’t stop spinning,” he acknowledged, immediately plopping himself atop it and burying his face in the headlay, trying to ease his dizziness.

“It will pass. Just get some rest.”

Jimmy’s soft snoring was his only response as Dammen turned and exited the room, going off to relay more orders to the foreman. He was glad the barracks was currently unoccupied and that few had been witness to Jimmy’s embarrassing behavior.

* * * *

Jimmy awoke the next morning to the worst headache he had ever known. With a soft curse, he slowly righted himself and put a hand to his head, suddenly realizing why Dammen had been so upset with him. That he had been protecting him from this unnecessary suffering had been a blessing in disguise.

He had been unaware of when his comrades had returned to the barracks and gone to bed the previous night. He had slept straight through most of yesterday and at least two meals he could think of. His stomach was growling annoyingly as he carefully stood up and ambled to the bath chamber. Grimacing when the spray of hot mineral water hit him, he spent several micron leaning his hands against the wall as the welcoming warmth doused away his guilt and humiliation.

Feeling somewhat more normal, after dressing, he finally made his way to Fanta’s office to get his latest orders, hoping he would have time to eat something before he started training in the processing and refinement areas.

“Sorry,” he said as he stepped inside and closed the door. “I didn’t mean to cause you any trouble.”

The foreman looked up in surprise at his entrance. “Well, no harm done,” he answered. “So long as my men didn’t get fired. They were lucky this time.”

Jimmy nodded, shamefaced as he listened.

“Have you eaten?”

“No. Was just on my way but wanted to get my new instructions.”

Jarrel extended his hand. “Here then. Take this missive to that big brute down there. The one standing by that brown tank near the silos. He’s in charge of refining the ore and he’ll direct you from there.”

Jimmy hesitantly accepted the folded document and craned to peer out the window behind the foreman.

“Okay. I see him.”

“Give him this first, then tell him you’ll return around 1400 to begin your training. That should give you time to eat and get your act together.” He gave him a funny squint, eyeing his reddened eyes. “You still don’t look like you’ve fully recovered yet, so I’m only going to make you work a half day. The rest of the vesta will be the usual.”

Jimmy sighed inwardly, grateful for the reprieve. The man could have been a lot more harsh in his punishment but knew the Kaanig had prevented it.

“I understand, ziros,” he said, turning to leave. “I promise you will not see a repeat of yesterday’s episode.”

Jarrel grunted. “See that I don’t.”

Taking that as a dismissal, Jimmy soon found himself out the door and sitting in the huge pastime area, called a stel, located in the second building over. Glad to have a few moments to himself, he had been quick to heap up his plate with a variety of Ulstran delicacies, always hot and available to the thousands of miners, at all orons. The dining area was unoccupied, except for a small group of miners sitting in a corner who had been quick to notice his entrance.

Taking a seat some distance away, Jimmy deposited his tray of food on the table and pushed it away for a moment as he leaned forward to rub his hands over his eyes. The light was still bothering him, and he regretted every sip of ale he had sampled the day before. What an idiot he had been, he realized. No wonder Dammen had been so mad at him.

After a moment, he opened his eyes to draw back his tray, only to find four of the nine miners from the corner table standing over him, glaring down at him.

“What’s up with you, boy?” one demanded among grunts of approval, moving closer in an attempt to intimidate him. “What’s the Altair to you that you should bring him here and start makin’ trouble for us?”

Far more hungry than intimidated, Jimmy ignored the fury in the man’s tone and proceeded to eat, lifting an Ulstran utensil to spear some caldron eggs and put them into his mouth. Chewing with great satisfaction, he gave the four men a grin and continued to the next item on his plate, repeating his savoring performance.

“*Answer me, boy!”* the man bellowed, pounding his beefy fist on the table, startling Jimmy with its vehemence. He frowned down at his plate, the force of the threat having bounced his food all over the place.

“Perhaps when I’m through eating.”

The outraged look on all four faces was priceless as they stared at him and then knowingly exchanged looks with one another.

“*What?*” The leader of the group then reached a hand out to shove the entire tray onto the floor. “You’ll answer us now, *or else!*”

Jimmy took a deep breath and slowly raised a nonchalant napkin to his handsome young mouth. “Or else, what?” he answered calmly, meticulously wiping the napkin across his smooth lips as he eyed the four men with some disdain. He was so tired of getting provoked and threatened all the time.

But just as the lead man was about to show him, Jimmy made a pointed display of throwing down his napkin and leaping from the table, just as the man’s beefy fist shot out and nearly connected with his jaw.

“Ah, now I see,” Jimmy said lightly, quirking a brow at him as the rest of the group surrounded him. “Boy, nine-to-one is a little bit off, don’t you think?”

A deep snarl slowly erupted from the man's mouth as he inched toward him, intent on beating him to a pulp.

But Jimmy had been well trained and was soon back-flipping from between them and well over their heads, preventing the two goons behind him from grabbing his arms and holding him while the leader pummeled him with his fists.

"What the…?"

The men's mouths dropped in awe as they lifted their heads upward to watch Jimmy flinging himself effortlessly through the air, only to land with a soft thud several criminas behind them. They whipped around to look at him, just as Jimmy brought his bottom half up and kicked one of them in the mouth with both feet. Shocked at the speed with which he had moved, the man had had no time to even react. He lifted a hand to his injured mouth, then stared in consternation at the blood on his fingers.

In a matter of micron, Jimmy had swiftly darted about the entire group, bringing them all down with acrobatics, feet, and a number of well laid punches. The miners had never seen anything like this before and when they managed to stand, Jimmy punched them in the mouth again, dropping each one to the floor like a bunch of ten ton meteors. Dazed, the nine men now lay at his feet, staring in awe at this incredible wonder of a boy.

"Had enough?" he asked in stern amusement, dancing and bouncing past them like an agile circus performer.

At their reluctant nod, he pursed his lips and then moved to snatch up another food tray. Quickly filling his plate a second time and grabbing a bottle of water, he returned back to the men for one final comment.

"Had you asked me nicely, I would have told you anything you wanted to know," he said. "But you don't get a second chance. So don't bother me again or you'll get more of the same."

Taking his leave, he proceeded to ignore them and returned to his sleeping quarters to finish his meal in solitary. As he sat on his bunk mulling over what had just happened, he chuckled. He had been amazed himself at the skill he possessed when taking down the nine goons. They hadn't even had a chance to fight back, and that had been a very good thing indeed. Thoughts of his easy victory carried him through the rest of the solarity, but he made a mental note not to let it go to his head. Arrogance was not his style and so prayed for humility that solarity, as Dammen had taught him to do.

Chapter Eighteen

Jaada sighed with disheartenment and gave the shining metal ball a swift kick, not caring how far it went or in which direction, unaware that Shelana Bejada and her friends were snickering gleefully from the observation stands as they viewed her frustration.

Although the game of westa was universal, the odd rules the Degmans had devised was just inconceivable to someone who had played the game since she was a toddler. Having taken to sports like a fish to water, Jaada felt there was not a popular sport she knew more about than westa. Why the Degmans felt it their obligation to make things difficult for non-Degmans was totally beyond her. But perhaps that was how they had managed to bring home the Cillian Trophy every scalon. The Degmans played so dirty, having made up their own vile rules, it was easy for them to win every scalon, not caring at all how the rest of Valtor played, so long as no one called them on what they were doing illegally. Up until now, westa had been a nice way to spend an afternoon and get some exercise.

"What's the matter, Gellon? If the game's not to your liking, you can always go back to where you came from."

Recognizing the familiar sneer of her nemesis, Jaada stopped her silent pouting and paused to glare at Shelana and her giggling pack of hounds. It took all of her good breeding and self-control to keep back the retort that was festering on her tongue as she watched them. The episode with the H'San the vesta before apparently hadn't been enough to prevent Shelana from tormenting her further.

Instead of rising to the bait, Jaada turned to retrieve the tiny ball she spotted lying alongside the narrow field of grass, about 100 criminas away. Paralleling the two-inch white line dividing the field, she made a casual effort to walk the length of it. Let the she-beasts think what they wanted, she decided. Anyone who knew her was aware of her special talents. Until she learned the new rules of the game, she needed to be on the alert until she mastered the dirty rules for herself. She had no wish to get bruised and battered every time she ran the ball up and down the dusting field.

By the time she found the ball and turned around, it was to find everyone already off to the showers. It was the end of the school solarity and the start of the typical three-solarity weekend, and she was as eager for it to begin as everyone else. Still, she waited outside, taking her sweet old time stripping off her body gear and repacking her bag until she was certain Shelana and her pals had gone. The coach was a nice fellow but seemed to enjoy the way Shelana always taunted her, never stepping in to halt the uncalled-for behavior. So it didn't surprise her that he was nowhere about either, having escaped to his weekend as soon as he was able.

* * * *

When she felt the way clear, Jaada hoisted up her bag and finally made toward the locker rooms. As she skipped the few steps down the stair well, she hesitated. Quietly, she pushed open the door leading to the girls' locker area, listening for anyone inside. Satisfied everyone had gone, she continued inside and peered about. Sighing with relief, she made toward her locker, just off the shower room. Tossing her bag inside, she slipped from the rest of her clothes, snatched her towel from the open locker and headed for the shower. Grateful to be alone, she put aside her towel and gingerly stepped

beneath the spray of hot misting mineral water. She smoothed back her sleek black hair, with both hands, as the water soaked her down. She soaped and rinsed several times, sighing with pleasure as she enjoyed a few more sclair of the hot water washing over her, before turning off the spray.

She closed her eyes and slicked back the water from her hair, squeezing it to the ends, to remove most of the water. Fumbling a hand across the wall, she searched for the towel she had left hanging on a nearby hook. Unable to find it, she opened her eyes, surprised to find it missing. Hm. She shook her head in disbelief, then scanned the floor, to no avail. Frowning, she crossed her arms over her naked breasts and carefully reentered the locker room, trying not to slip as she made her way naked to her clothes. To her further dismay, those were no longer lying on the bench where she had left them either. She chided herself for not having locked them up before venturing to the shower room.

Dripping and cold, she yanked open her locker, shocked to discover nothing inside. All of her belongings were gone. Suddenly afraid, she pushed the door shut then tiptoed slowly through the locker room, hoping to find something to wear or to at least cover herself with.

Panic quickly set in when she realized that someone, probably Shelana, was playing a horrible trick on her. There she was naked and alone, with nothing to cover herself with. However was she going to get home?

Drawing an arm across her chest self-consciously and covering her nether region, she slunk past each aisle of the huge room, peering down them hopefully. Holding back tears at this embarrassing dilemma, she was unprepared for the loud shouts, guffaws, and laughter that assaulted her when she reached the last aisle. The entire westa team, male and female alike, were there waiting for her, springing out at her. Shocked beyond belief, Jaada shrieked in humiliation as some of the boys even dared cop a feel as she made to scamper away, slipping and sliding in her haste. Gasping when she lost her footing, falling down amidst a painful split, the laughter grew even louder. Her nakedness revealed to everyone as she sat spread out on the cold tiled floor, she fought back tears of humiliation, as she carefully recovered. She crouched over her bruised knee, only then realizing the sharp pain of a twisted ankle as well. It was then she lost it and started sobbing uncontrollably. Only then did the group cease their catcalls and disgusting noises, when they realized the damage they had done.

Jaada sat on the floor, her head bowed atop her injured knee, crying her heart out. Nothing she had suffered before even compared to the pain and humiliation of this seeming joke. And she could think of nothing she had done to deserve anyone treating her this way.

She was unaware of when the group of thirty or so departed, and only one had the sense to return her towel, shamefacedly dropping it beside her before scooting away. Jaada was left sobbing naked on the cold floor, and it was how the imperial guard found her a short while later.

* * * *

The H'San had only just relieved his comrade a few micron before, having been informed that all was well, when he suddenly spotted the group of teenagers dashing away from the locker area as if all the hounds of *fi'ara* were after them. They were observed tossing clothing and westa gear about, but there was no sign of Jaada as they raced off. At sight of them, both H'San hurried to the locker room to check on Jaada, one of them waiting outside while the other hesitantly entered the locker room.

“Pa’atay Gellon?” the warrior said softly, doing his best to keep his gaze averted as he picked up the towel and draped it haphazardly about Jaada when he came upon her huddled naked on the floor. “I am very sorry about this. I will gather your things and return in a moment.”

Jaada seemed not to have heard as she pulled the towel more closely about her, her forehead still resting on her knees. The H'San and his comrade returned not long thereafter, both having located most of her things strewn about the field and stair well.

“Are you hurt?” the previous H’San asked, cursing himself for not recognizing the signs earlier and preventing this from happening. Having been stationed some 200 criminas away since he had been ordered not to make Jaada feel as if she was being spied on or continually stalked, it was the best he could do at the time. Not once had he ever believed that all of Jaada's classmates would gang up on her all at the same time, and in such a way. He knew he was definitely in for a reprimand from the Altair after this happening. He was expected to report after every shift, and this was going to be the worst he had ever given his sovereign.

“M-my knee hurts,” Jaada sniffed brokenly. “And I think…my ankle is...”

“Get dressed, pa’atay,” the other interrupted. “We’ll be back in a moment to see to your injuries.”

“O-kay.”

* * * *

When the men returned, Jaada was still sitting on the floor but was more in control, and covered. Fortunately, it seemed that nothing of hers had been stolen, so she had one of the men stuff everything into her duffel bag. She knew she wouldn’t be returning to this locker room for the rest of the term and wanted to leave nothing behind.

The larger of the two men knelt and effortlessly lifted Jaada into brawny arms to sit her on a bench. Scowling at her bruised knee and swollen ankle, he knew the girl needed immediate medical attention.

“We must take you away from here, Pa’atay. We will notify your family of this occurrence once we get you the care you need.”

Fear washed over her then, her humiliation now numb in her brain as she tried to wash away the fact that so many people had seen her in the altogether. But she was so grateful that the Altair had men there to protect her, to help her, and she nearly sobbed with relief that they were there now. Still, her heart felt as bruised as the rest of her. As the giant lifted her again, she leaned against his solid chest gratefully, wishing she could crawl under a rock somewhere and hide. Sniffing sadly and trembling, she turned to bury her face in her hands as she curled against the warmth of his body.

* * * *

It was late when the H’Sans brought Jaada home, but her family was awake and waiting. Shocked by what had happened, they worriedly took her into their loving arms, thanking the warriors before promptly closing the door in their faces. Having known the warriors were there to keep an eye

their daughter, since Jaada had informed them the last time, they were both a bit upset that they had failed to keep her safe after all.

Astar Gellon carried his daughter to bed, followed by her mother who brought her some hot merida. Astar sat her down and kissed her head, taking great care not to cause her any additional pain. He knew her sprained ankle would keep her off her feet for at least two vestas.

"Perhaps moving to Degma was the wrong decision," he told her in concern. "I had hoped things might be different for you here."

Jaada shrugged noncommittally. "How were you to know what would happen? Even now I can't understand the jealousy and hatred towards me. These people hardly know anything about me."

Her father and mother exchanged looks. "It's because you are so lovely," her father told her. "The girls feel threatened, afraid you are going to steal all the boys away from them."

Jaada gave a glum look. "If they got to know me," she began, "then they would know that I am already spoken for."

Astar sighed and ran a hand through his dark hair, slightly salted with gray. "I don't know what to do about that, *h'naya.* We'll just have to wait and see what happens. The men told me they had reported the incident to the Altair. He is bound to take care of the problem."

"Yeah. Or make things worse for me. That's what happened before. I thought that after the last time. Now see what's happened."

"Well, you won't have to worry about any of that for a few vestas. You won't be returning to school until that ankle is better. I'll contact your teachers and get your assignments so you won't fall behind."

Her mother intervened then. "I think you should get some rest now, dear. The merida should help you relax a bit."

"All right. Mint, too, s'lma, and some pima fruit, please."

Her parents departed, closing the door behind them, but Jaada could hear their frantic whispering just outside. Later, too weary to care more about their discussion, she hurriedly downed her merida and settled herself in for the night, silently giving her thanks to the Almighty Source for His hand in helping her make it through the solarity.

Her last thoughts were not of the lousy day she had had but of Jimmy Donaldson's mesmerizing blue eyes. Faith, how she missed him.

Chapter Nineteen

A strange mood had fallen over the Degman school that Jaada had been attending. When she returned several weeks - *vestas* - later, it was to find that the coach of the westa team had been terminated from his position because of what he had allowed to happen. No one seemed to know how the Altair had found out about what had happened to Jaada, but Shelana Bejada was certain it was because of whatever ties Jaada had with him, because of the H'San presence.

As it was, imperial warriors were now positioned at various areas of the school on a daily basis, as a precautionary measure. Kaanig Altair wanted no more attacks against Jaada and was clearly making that known to the students at the Tendan school she was attending.

When Jaada arrived at the school her first solarity back, an imperial warrior was immediately at her side, escorting her safely to her primary class then waiting patiently outside the door until it ended. Then he escorted her to the next, repeating this procedure throughout the day, even when she attended to personal needs. He was there constantly to protect her everywhere she went.

Had this happened before, Jaada would have resented having a guard dogging her every footstep. But not any more. In fact, she was grateful for his comforting presence nearby. Each solarity the guards changed, but that didn't matter. What mattered was that the Altair cared enough to look out for her, and it made Jaada feel somewhat special and important. What her classmates thought didn't matter. The warriors' presence at school quickly halted any further taunting, teasing, or ridiculing that might have happened, after the westa team had seen her naked. That news had quickly spread throughout the school, and everyone was all set to pounce on Jaada as soon as she returned to school, only to find all of their plans thwarted by the Altair and his men.

The timing had been perfect. Having known the exact solarity and time of Jaada's return to school, Dammen's men knew that Jaada's safety was now of the utmost priority and made it a point to keep a closer eye on her than before.

Chapter Twenty

He stood just inside the door of what resembled a huge gymnasium, now decorated in vibrant hews of purple, blue, and gold. Paper streamers and dots of twinkling lights floated about the room as hundreds of people twirled and danced beneath them. A warm breeze joined them through various open doorways, creating a pleasant summer atmosphere. Since summers were long in this quadrant of the planet, it was a relief when temperatures dropped to more comfortable levels. Tonight was one of those nights, and everyone was clearly enjoying themselves.

Prior to being brought to Degma, Jimmy Donaldson had been briefed on what had been happening to Jaada Gellon since last he had seen her. That had been almost a scalon ago, and his whole being was primed and ready to see her again. As his blue eyes scanned the throngs of people dancing or milling about the immense room, amid the deafening music pounding from every corner, he finally spotted her, sitting just to the left of one of the many long tables laid out with delicacies and other scrumptious foods. This final school dance, much like a high school prom back on Earth, was what had drawn Jaada there. Despite her suffering, she had not wanted to miss out on something so special, even if meant she had to go alone, to sit as a wallflower. With imperial escorts standing just outside the doors, she knew they would not allow anything to interfere with this last school event.

She looked sad and lonely, Jimmy noted, as he began making his way toward her. Having eyes only for her, he was unaware of how he stood out as he deliberately walked through the crowd of dancers, how the eyes of everyone widened at sight of him in his elegant warrior's togs. His white-blond hair alone drew the attention of the dark-haired Degmans as they halted their movements and gaped at him in awe. As they observed him, the crowd parted almost as one as he purposely moved toward where Jaada Gellon was sitting.

She hadn't noticed him yet until she observed the strange stir in the crowd of dancers. Lifting her head to peer through the motley group, her mouth dropped at sight of Jimmy Donaldson, so gorgeous to behold and, if possible, even more muscular. He was breathtaking, and Jaada gasped at the sheer joy of seeing him again. Without thinking, she jumped to her feet and darted towards him, shocking her classmates as she barged through the groups of people standing in her way. When close enough, she threw herself into his waiting arms, clinging to him as if she never wanted to let him go.

"Jimmy," she murmured happily as his arms came about her, crushing her against him.

"I've missed you," he whispered, holding her a moment before gently setting her away to peer down into her beautiful black eyes. Then, ignoring the puzzled and jealous faces watching this intimate reunion, he claimed her lips with all the pent-up yearning in his heart, kissing her passionately until she was almost too dizzy to stand.

"Let's find some privacy," he said, putting a possessive arm about her and directing her away from the stunned onlookers.

"Enjoy the whore," one male classmate shouted after him. "We've all had her. She's got a great body."

At this, Jimmy halted in rage, thankful that Dammen had given him the lowdown on the situation.

"Be right back," he told Jaada, who was cringing in embarrassment. She stood safely aside as she watched Jimmy move with cold precision to the one who was casting aspersions at the girl he loved. He stopped directly in front of the jerk, glaring down at him. He stood at least a head taller than the westa player and was at least two breadths more muscular. "You got something to say?"

The fellow grinned and glanced around at his other team members, who were stepping forward to back him.

"We've all had her," he said, baiting him with deceit. "Nice and juicy, that one."

It was all Jimmy Donaldson needed to hear. Not even caring how many were supporting the fool, his fist came out with the force of an Ulstran mine hauler and plowed into the boy's handsome face, instantly dropping him to the floor. The fellow lay there dazed, wiping at the blood on his mouth.

"*You…!* You'll pay for—"

But he never even had a chance to get to his feet before the other team members grabbed Jimmy from behind. With two members holding his arms, the rest stood behind them as the first westa player rose to his feet and made ready to pound him into the ground. Unperturbed, Jimmy wasted no time in back-kicking his restrainers away and kicking the first fellow in the face, forcing him to fall back. At this point, Jimmy gave the group a taste of what he had given the miners on Ulstra and within micron, the entire bunch was lying bruised and bloodied on the gymnasium floor.

"Next time you say or do anything against the woman I love, you'd better think twice."

With that, Jimmy straightened his clothes, finger-fluffed his hair, and turned back to Jaada, who stood in awe of what she had just witnessed.

"I've never seen anything…like that," she said softly, her eyes wide as she stared up at him. "You were…amazing."

Jimmy's lips curled modestly. "I've been training all my life," he replied, taking her arm and leading her away from the scene. "Care for something to drink?"

"Do you mean we're going to stay here, after all that just happened?" Jaada glanced around at the damage. Most of the offenders were being helped to their feet by concerned dates and casting wary, frightened glances in their direction.

Jimmy gave her a no-nonsense stare. "You've done nothing wrong, Jaada. Why should you be forced to leave when you have just as much right to enjoy yourself here as anyone else?"

She peered around, considering this, only now noticing all the imperial warriors standing just inside the open doorways. Apparently they had been witness to the scene and were now there to prevent any further trouble.

"The men were told not to come in unless trouble started," Jimmy was quick to explain, when he noticed where her attention lay. "I can take care of myself pretty much."

Jaada smiled up at him. “Yes, I saw that. You were…magnificent.”

He kissed her then, lightly on the lips, then handed her a small glass of Degman fruit punch as he led her to the side of the room so things could normalize. After awhile, he asked her to dance and led her deliberately into the center of the crowd. Crushing her against him, they slow danced every dance for the remainder of the evening, regardless of the tempo. No one bothered them again, nor did anyone care to.

Jimmy Donaldson had established himself as a force to be reckoned with.

* * * *

It was late when Jimmy took Jaada home. The dance had ended an oron earlier, and Jimmy had wanted the pleasure of walking his woman home alone, without imperial escorts. Having been forewarned of this, the H’Sans obeyed, with strict instructions from their sovereign to go looking for them only if Jimmy didn’t return to the meeting place by one beohsa.

“I’ve been waiting to be alone with you all evening,” he admitted.

“Me, too.” Jaada grinned shyly as he squeezed her hand.

He stopped to peer down into her eyes, shining in the bright moonlight like two luminescent, onyx stones of great price.

“I wanted you to enjoy the prom,” he said. “You did, didn’t you?”

“Oh, yes,” she said with a giggle. “It’s something I’ll remember the rest of my life.”

“Hopefully, no one will bother you again,” he said. “They know now that you belong to me and that they’ll have to deal with me personally, if anyone dares to hurt you again.”

She hesitated, staring down at his booted feet. “The Altair told you what’s been going on, hasn’t he?”

“Yes. He wanted me to be aware of what I was walking into.”

She threw her arms about him, hugging him gratefully, possessively. “I’m glad. He has been such a big help to me here.”

“I’m glad he thought to protect you for me. Who knows what the situation might have been otherwise.” He squeezed her tightly. “I worry about you all the time.”

He set her away then and leaned down to kiss her again. “I wish you were mine already,” he said at length. “It’s torture being so far away from you.”

“I know,” she agreed, her hands resting on his chest. “How much longer must we wait?”

He shrugged, sighing aloud. “I dunno. I’m still training at the refining plant on Ulstra. Dammen told me I could have a break after awhile, which is why I’m here.”

“He’s teaching you a lot, isn’t he?”

“Yes,” he answered quietly. “He has plans for me. I just can't share them with you yet.” His expression changed then, and he took her by the shoulders to peer directly into her soul. “But regardless, you will wait for me, won’t you? You’ll still join with me, right?”

“Yes,” she whispered, promise heavy in her voice.

He drew her from the walk to the security of some tall bushes and yanked her into his arms, kissing her more hungrily than before. He could feel her easy submission beneath his lips, and he knew she desired as much from him as he wanted from her. He growled from somewhere deep in his throat as he pulled her closer against him, enjoying her soft form molding to his, and her sweet scent.

The kiss grew more heated as his hand slid tentatively to her chest. She made no resistance, wishing as he did that they could become one. She felt so good against him, so soft, that it was hard to break away. But both knew they had to. To go to the next level would infuriate the Altair, so there was nothing they could do now except…wait.

“I’m sorry, Jaada,” Jimmy said as he forced himself away. Breathing heavily, their bodies on fire, they separated, straightened their clothes, then made their way to Jaada’s house. “The time will come eventually.”

“I know. It’s just so hard waiting. I love you so much.”

“And I you. And you know,” he began, amusement in his tone, “those guys were right about you.”

Jaada’s head jerked around. “What do you mean?”

“You do have one hot body.”

She paused then, her expression serious as she looked up at him. “Even so, you’re the only one who’ll ever enjoy it,” she said, lifting his hand to her breast. “Only you.”

He couldn’t help it then. He just had to kiss her again. And again. And again. And unfortunately, this delayed his meeting with the imperials who were waiting for him at the rendezvous point.

* * * *

“It took you two orons to walk the young lady home, James?”

Jimmy lowered his head guiltily, convicted again by the Altair’s formal use of his name.

“Yes, Ziros,” he said. “I’m…sorry.”

Dammen studied the younger man, the slump of his shoulders, at the sadness evident in his overall demeanor.

“You didn’t….?”

Jimmy’s head shot up then. “Heck, no, Ziros! Of course not.”

“Your training is nearly complete on Ulstra, Jimmy. There is more I want you to learn, but if you feel you cannot live without this young lady, then we will discuss the situation at length another day. Is this agreeable?”

“Why, yes, Ziros,” Jimmy replied, unable to believe his ears.

Dammen relaxed back in his chair and stared pointedly at him. “You will have two vestas here with Jaada,” he said. “You can go anywhere you want, do anything you want. I will pay for anything you need. But…”

“But?” Jimmy repeated, a nervous inflection to his voice.

“You will be chaperoned at all times. No more of whatever went on tonight.”

“Oh, come on, Ziros—”

“Take it or leave it, Jimmy. That’s an order.”

Jimmy dropped his gaze to the floor, trying to control his anger. He didn’t think he had ever felt as angry at the Altair as he did at that moment.

“Aye aye, Ziros,” he breathed reluctantly, masking his ire. “It will be as you say. I just don’t understand.”

“You will in time,” Dammen said. “Let’s leave it at that.”

“Am I dismissed then?”

Dammen stared at him a moment as if reconsidering his decision. “You are.”

Then when the door had closed behind a sulking Jimmy Donaldson, only then did Jeiel Vernier enter the room, having waited in the next room until the matter had been formally discussed.

“How did things go?”

Dammen snorted, a half-smile curling his fine lips. “About what I expected,” he said. “Jimmy is very upset with me now, so let’s wait and see what happens next. If I know him as well as I think I do, then he should be quick to dodge my men in order to be alone with Jaada.”

“Defiance is new to him.”

“Very. But if he is willing to defy me in order to have this woman, then I’ll know he has come into his own.”

“It will be interesting to see what happens, Ziros.”

“Yes. Two vestas is a long time to be hounded by chaperones, with hormones raging all around.”

“Are you hoping she’ll be impregnated before he returns to Ulstra?”

Dammen gave this some serious thought. “I’m not hoping. I just think it’s inevitable. But perhaps it’ll get Jimmy to calm down a bit. I don’t want him to continue kicking everybody’s butt every time he gets insulted.”

“Yeah, but he is good at it.”

The Altair laughed then. “He is that. He has been well trained, and I am exceedingly proud of him. I just don’t want him to get carried away. He is still young and inexperienced.”

“I’ll have my men try and keep an eye on him, Ziros, but I’m making no promises. In fact, I guarantee they’ll be taking bets to see how long it takes Jimmy to sneak away from them.” Jeiel shot his friend a smirking look. “But please don’t hold this against them, Ziros. We both know how clever Jimmy is.”

“I’ll consider it, Jeiel, but I’m making no promises either.”

Exchanging looks, they both laughed and made toward the sharlok decanter. Both of them figured that Jimmy would shake off the guards in less than 24 orons.

Chapter Twenty-One

Jimmy and Jaada were sitting on a stone wall, overlooking the sea of Navada below, one of the millions of bodies of water spread across the galaxy. Two imperial guards sat in their vehicle some distance away, out of their hearing but keeping them in sight at all times. Both young people hated having even one of them following them around, but Jimmy was under orders to allow the chaperones.

"We need to lose these guys," Jimmy said in a low voice. "Even this close to you makes me feel far away."

"I know," Jaada agreed, squeezing his hand, the only physical contact they were allowed.

Jimmy's eyes swept the sea below, eyeing the vast white beach that ran along the shoreline for korons, both east and west. His eyes narrowed at something he spied in the distance, and a thought quickly formulated into an idea.

"Come on," he said, sliding off the wall, then helping her down. "Let's take a walk on the beach."

She smiled happily. "I like that idea."

He led her along the roadside, moving past the waiting imperial vehicle, barely glancing at the two H'San warriors inside it as they walked by. The couple shared a secret smile at thought of the imperials following them down the steep incline which led to the wide expanse of beach below.

"You can swim, right?"

"Of course," Jaada said, giving him a strange look. "You know I'm good at all sports. I just didn't bring anything suitable to wear."

Jimmy gave her a sidelong glance, keeping her protectively by his side, as they made their way down the ancient stone steps leading to the base of the bluff.

"You may not need to worry about that," he said.

"Why, what do you mean?"

"You'll see."

It was a long walk to the cave Jimmy had spotted from the wall now located high above them. The warriors were quick to exit their vehicle and follow them. They were at least a half a koron behind them, which gave Jimmy the distance they needed to sneak away from them. He gave the guards an occasional glance, just to make certain of the distance between them.

"You see that cave entrance," he said, trying not to point it out so the warriors wouldn't get wise.

"What of it?"

“I’m hoping that if we go inside we can follow it out to wherever it exits.”

Jaada understood then. “You think we can lose the guards?”

“If we move fast enough. Are you game?”

Jaada shot a glance back at the two men, still a good distance behind them. “Y-Yes. If you think it’s safe.”

Jimmy gave her a look that spoke volumes. “I can’t guarantee that, Jaada. Just trust me to try and find a way for us to finally be alone, without time constraints and chaperones.”

“All...All right.”

A few micron later found them carefully climbing over the large rocks near the entrance of the small cave. Jimmy knew the guards hadn’t spotted the orifice until both he and Jaada had disappeared through it. Then the two men shouted angrily and tore off after them. By the time they arrived, Jimmy and Jaada had moved deep inside the cave, the bottom of which was filled with water. There was no sign of them, and both men were furious because neither wanted to go looking for their charges in that small cave. One of them started inside but quickly turned back. He found he was too burly to squeeze through the hole he had found at the back of the cave. Neither could the other one, which made them even more upset.

“Contact the Altair. We’ve lost them.”

“*Maka!”*

It had taken only 16 orons to lose the chaperones and when Kaanig Altair received the news of what had happened, he could only shake his head and hope that nothing but good came of it.

“I’ll put a trace on the cave and see if a map is available so we can see where it exits,” Dammen told them. “Then one of you can move to that entrance and wait for them to emerge.”

“Aye, Ziros. We will await the information.”

* * * *

Inside the cave, pitch blackness greeted the two young people as they felt their way through the extended back of it. Both had gotten wet in the cold, knee-deep water upon first entering the cavern and located the hole in the wall. After squeezing through it, unaware of what lay behind it, they fell into more water, getting soaked completely. Jimmy was quick to locate Jaada and pull her against him when she rose sputtering from its clammy depths.

“It’s sc-scary and damp in here,” she told him, hanging onto him in terror.

“Not to mention dark.”

“That, too.”

“Well, we wanted privacy, and this is perfect.”

“Yes, but I can’t see anything.”

Jimmy took her hand in a reassuring manner. “Let’s go a little further and see if we can find an exit. If we see some light, we’ll know we’re near.”

“Um, okay.”

“If we find the exit, we can go through or swim out and make our way back to the beach. Then perhaps we can go off somewhere else so we can really be alone.”

“I hope you’re right.” Several micron later found the duo still moving cautiously through the cold water, sliding their feet carefully so they wouldn’t slip. Eventually, although it was difficult to see in the darkness, they came across a sand bank lining one of the walls. Crawling atop it, Jimmy then helped Jaada up next to him. The dirt there was dry, so they walked along the edge of the bank, noting its stability before finding themselves moving into another larger part of the cave.

“It’s still so dark, Jimmy. I’m really scared.”

“Hang on. I think that—”

But he paused when his foot knocked into something wooden at his feet. Bending down, he felt around, locating a small box.

“Hey, look what I found.” He took Jaada’s hand so she could feel it. “Let’s see if we can open it.”

Fumbling with it, he easily lifted the latch and cautiously stuck his hand inside, unable to believe his luck.

“Hey, cool. A couple of candles and what I believe may be a light stick.”

In moments, he had lit one of the candles, to Jaada’s sigh of relief. “Thank the Almighty Source,” she said. “I was starting to panic.”

They glanced around the small cavern, happy to find it dry and cozy. In one part there was a wooden crate, upon which they set the candle, propping it with a couple of small rocks they had found.

“There is another section,” Jimmy said, pointing. “Through there.” Still holding Jaada’s cold hand, he led her there, having lit the other candle to take with them. “There, do you see it?” he asked. “That small point of light. That has to be the other entrance to the cave. Wait here while I check it out.” Handing her the candle, he explored further, happy they didn’t have to go very far. He stepped outside, breathing in the fresh sea air and peering about. Spying no one around, he smiled to himself and returned inside. “The coast is clear,” he said. “I guess Dammen’s men gave up looking for us. For now anyways.”

He stood gazing at her in the candlelight. “You look really beautiful in this light,” he told her, “but we’d better conserve it for awhile.” Taking the candle, he blew it out and moved to set it on the crate beside the lit one.

“I’m soaking wet,” Jaada said, “and freezing cold.”

“Yes, but we’re alone, Jaada,” Jimmy said, eyeing her seductive curves in the remaining candlelight as the wet clothes molded against them. “Finally.”

He was beside her then. Pushing aside her crossed arms, he ran his hands up her arms to warm her. But he wasted no time. Pulling her against him, he claimed her lips. This time there was no hiding his desire for her as he drew her more closely against him. She moaned softly as he slowly undid her blouse.

“Tell me to stop, if you want to, Jaada. I will, if you want me to.”

In response, she took his hands and placed them on her breasts. “Make me yours, Jimmy,” she pleaded. “I love you.”

He hesitated, then stepped back to remove his own shirt and vest. Jaada gasped at sight of his incredible physique. Tight abs and belly expanded to a powerful chest and shoulders, and she almost swooned at sight of all the muscles he possessed.

“Jimmy,” she breathed, “you’re so…gorgeous.”

He merely smiled as he drew her hands against him, to feel him. “It’s only fair,” he said.

Capturing her lips again, he yanked her to him, crushing her against him as he wrapped his arms about her. A sigh of intense longing escaped her as she slid her hands from his waist, then up and over his magnificent back muscles.

At length, Jimmy sighed and thrust her away. “I’m…sorry,” he groaned, as if in pain. “I can’t…do… this.”

“What? Why not?”

“I can’t do this to him…or to you.”

“Who? What are you talking about?”

“Dammen.” He moved away and began pulling his damp clothes back on. Then he straightened to yank her blouse closed.

He scowled as he watched her button it and grimace at the cold, wet feel of it. He gave a dark scowl as he watched her, understanding her need and her confusion.

“I’m sorry, Jaada, but it has to be this way. I can’t disgrace the Altair by betraying his trust in me. He’s done so much for me. And,” he continued, moving to take her by the shoulders so he could look at her, “I respect you too much to do this to you. As difficult as it is to stop, I know it’ll be worth the wait. Once we are joined, we won’t have to hide or sneak away. I’m willing to wait awhile longer and hope you are, too.”

Jaada understood but knew what she wanted. “I’m willing right now,” she told him, “but I will wait. I don’t want to do this to him either. He cares about us, and he does deserve better from both of us.”

He gave her a quick kiss and lovingly caressed her smooth cheek. “I want you badly, Jaada, but I love you too much to take you in the dirt, in a dark, dank cave. When we are joined, things will be different.” He released her and moved to blow out the remaining candle and place it back in the wooden box, along with the light stick. “Come,” he said, taking her hand to lead her outside. “Let’s see what the guards are up to. They’ll be surprised, won’t they?”

“And furious.”

“Yeah. I can hardly wait to hear everyone yelling at us.”

Jaada paused, drawing his attention. “What’s the matter?” he asked.

“I truly want you,” she explained. “More than you’ll ever know.” Reaching up, she put a hand to his neck and drew him to her lips, groaning with a need she couldn’t explain.

“I love you, too, Jaada,” he said, after kissing her fiercely. “Never forget that I want you just as much. But we won’t die from wanting.”

“I know, Jimmy. It’s just so…hard.”

He chuckled and hugged her tightly. “Patience, my love.” He saw movement near the exit. “Looks like they’re waiting for us,” he said. “Rather impatiently, I would think.” Taking her hand, he carefully led her from the cave, shocking the guard with their bedraggled appearance. Even he could tell by the miserable looks on their faces that nothing had happened between them.

Chapter Twenty-Two

Kaanig Altair sat back in his huge chair with a satisfied smirk on his face. Jeiel Vernier stood aside with arms crossed, a similar grin on his face as well, as the two H'San gave their report. When the men departed, the two dynamic leaders exchanged looks of relief.

"It appears our young warrior has integrity of the highest caliber," Dammen said. "He's stronger than I gave him credit for."

"Or more loyal."

Dammen nodded. "That too. Jimmy has demonstrated that he can indeed be trusted."

Jeiel moved to the other side of the room, to peer at some movement outside the window.

"So what now?"

"I'll let you know, Jeiel. I have a few things to discuss with Jimmy first. He will be returning to Ulstra though, in a few days. But in what capacity, I haven't decided yet."

* * * *

"*There!* That's him."

The two middle-aged men craned their necks to peer out the eatery window to look at the fellow their sons had had such trouble with at the year-end dance.

"That…what the hell is he? A Zarcon?" The scarred face of one of the men crinkled as he looked the man-boy over. "Sure is ripped, ain't he?"

"That's him, s'lpa. The one who kicked me in the face." The westa player ground his finger against the window, almost foaming at the mouth with rage.

"Yeah, that's him," his friend affirmed, nodding. He was standing beside the table with arms crossed, leaning over to peer out the streaked glass.

The boys' fathers exchanged looks and made to rise. "Well, we'll make short work of him, don't worry. You boys just stay here and watch the skylights."

The boys chuckled.

"Okay, s'lpa."

They watched their fathers amble from the small eating establishment and slowly saunter across the street, following the Zarcon they had heard such tall tales about. As the men sized up the youth, neither could believe all they had heard of what he had done at the dance. Only the bruised and bloodied faces of their sons gave evidence that it had actually happened that night.

* * * *

Jimmy Donaldson was on his way to Jaada's house, and he could hardly wait to see her.

Having just left his meeting with the Altair, he was more excited than ever. Dammen had promoted him to a new level on Ulstra. He was now going to train as overseer of the entire mining operation, which meant that even Jarrel Fanta was below him in rank. It was Jeiel Vernier who would now train him as overseer, and this was an incredible honor, he knew. So wrapped up in his happy thoughts on the matter, he was unaware of the two burly, middle-aged Degmans approaching quietly from behind.

"*Hey! Boy!*"

As soon as Jimmy turned to see what was up, one of the men punched him in the face, dropping him to the ground with a painful thud. Before he even had a chance to rise, both men were grabbing him and dragging him behind some bushes on the side of a large warehouse. Although it was broad daylight, the event had happened so fast that no one had even noticed, except those watching from the eatery windows. The men made short work of Jimmy Donaldson, repeatedly punching and kicking him in the face, stomach, and back until he finally blacked out.

"There, you whoreson! That'll teach you to mess with our boys."

With that, the men left him lying unconscious on the gravel behind the warehouse before making their getaway. Full of themselves, they returned to the dining establishment and slapped their sons on the back with glee, bragging loudly of what they had done to Jimmy Donaldson. When they departed, only then did their concerned waitress dare inform her employer of what had transpired. He immediately informed the local authorities, so it wasn't long before Cambra Vernier and two accompanying warriors were entering their humble eating establishment to learn more of what they knew about Jimmy Donaldson. The description of the victim given to the authorities had caught Jeiel's notice right away, although no one was yet aware that Jimmy was even missing.

* * * *

The deep male voice came from a hollow tunnel, sounding far away.

"Jimmy, can you hear me?"

He tried to answer, struggled to shake off the weight holding him down. He was numb from the pain, and his eye was swollen shut. It was a great effort for him to regain full consciousness, although he could hear the familiar voice close to his ear. At length, he gasped, giving a hoarse, throaty reply.

"Y-Yes," he managed shakily, suddenly able to raise a hand to his bruised, aching face. He squinted open his good eye to peer up at Jeiel who was leaning over him in concern.

"How are you feeling?"

"Like an eighteen wheeler just rolled over me."

Jeiel snorted, not quite sure what that was but figured it was something large, heavy, and painful.

“Do you know who attacked you?”

The man-boy grimaced and tried to sit up, only to find his progress halted by Jeiel’s strong hand on his chest.

“Does it matter? I survived.”

“It matters to me...and to the Altair.”

Jimmy sighed with resignation and lay back down, palm-patting his swollen eye.

“I’m not certain. I think it was somebody related to the guys at the school. The ones I beat up at the prom.”

“Prom?”

“The dance.”

Jeiel nodded. “We have a description but weren’t sure of the motive until now.”

“*Jaada!”* Jimmy forced his way to a sitting position, ignoring the excruciating pain in his chest and stomach as he did so. “Is she all right?”

“So far.”

“Thank God!” He fell backward, glad she was safe. “How long must I stay here?”

“Until we say otherwise.”

“Does Jaada know?”

“I don’t know.”

“Damn. Why did this have to happen now?”

“It would have happened sooner or later. It was unfortunate you didn’t see it coming.”

“Too caught up in the moment, I guess. Dammen had just given me the news about my promotion.”

“I can see how that could have distracted you,” Jeiel said, smiling in understanding. He gave his charge a once over glance. “Paxis says you have no broken bones, just some cracked ribs, so it should just be a matter of solarities before you are out and about.”

“Oh,” Jimmy growled. “I’ll go crazy laying here.”

Jeiel decided to accommodate him and pulled forth a *v'd'mr* attached to the wall and drew it in front of him.

“Whenever you’re ready, you can go through the Ulstran policy and procedures manual relating to the mining operation there. It’s quite lengthy, but I understand you can read the Ulstran dialects well enough to read these. This will be a good start to your training as overseer.”

“Now I will be bored,” Jimmy said, “but I’ll do it, even if it puts me to sleep.”

“It may be your only chance because you’ll be quite busy once we return to Ulstra. So take advantage of the time you have.”

“Yes, Ziros. Thank you.”

Jeiel nodded and turned to leave. “I am certain Dammen will bring Jaada to see you soon, so do not fret. He did promise you two full vestas together, did he not?”

Jimmy brightened at this. “Yes.”

Jeiel smiled and nodded again, then departed.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The men from the eatery and their two sons were standing just outside of the Gellon house. It was surrounded by sentinel trees and shrubbery, much different than other homes in the small community. With a domed roof and smooth, rounded outside walls, with green and violet ivy trailing up and along them, the two-story house was also more luxurious than other Degman houses, which made the four males wonder just what Jaada's father might be involved in.

"That's her," one of the youths pointed out. Jaada was seen standing by a window, peering out at the white fluffy clouds hanging overhead, which were drifting gently across the deep blue of the sky. "That's the Zarcon's girlfriend, the one who beat all of us up. She's nothing but a piece of used goods."

One man grinned a snarl. "That so? Well, maybe we can make her pay in ways common only to females."

At this, the entire group chuckled at thought of having her all to themselves, without interference. They had been watching the house for nearly an oron, with no sign of any of her family members or H'Sans around. The boys had been quick to inform their fathers of the special treatment that Jaada was getting from the Altair, and this rankled their innards more than anything.

"S'lpa," one of the boys began, "why don't we sneak around that side of the house, and next time she appears at the window, let's just break in and grab her."

The two men considered this awhile, one scratching his whiskered chin as he thought about whether or not they could pull it off. None of them had ever stolen anyone away before, but even he figured the slut needed a lesson on Degman deportment.

At length, the man's eyes narrowed, and he glanced at his partner.

"Let's do it," the other man said. "We may never have a better chance."

"Yeah. I suppose." He peered overhead. "Damn these lengthy solarities. It'd be better if we took her at night."

"S'lpa, she may not be standing in front of the window then."

One final scratch on the chin, and the group was soon making their way across the grounds, covertly keeping themselves hidden behind shrubs and trees so they wouldn't be seen. Once on the side of the house, they paused to make sure no one was about. Then the two boys crawled across the lawn, sidled up as close to the house as possible, so they could lie in wait beneath the window they had seen Jaada peering out only moments before. The men waited, one dropping down to move to the other side of the window, so that they now stood on both sides.

They had formulated an easy, simple plan. Once Jaada appeared at the window again, the men would smash it and yank her through it, hoping she wouldn't get too cut up in the process. They had found a small black tarp laying atop a woodpile near the back of the house. They intended to drape it over the window ledge before pulling her over it, hoping they could keep her from making a racket that

would alert her other family members to what was happening. They figured they were probably home but were busy in other parts of the house. The men had already peeked into the room and saw only Jaada alone there, sitting on her bed reading a digitext. It was obvious she was waiting for someone or something, which was why she kept her occasional vigil by the window.

"Bet she's waiting for him," one of the men said with a grin, drawing nods from his comrades. "Only he ain't comin'." Soft laughter followed that remark, but he slashed a frantic, quieting hand to silence them. "Shh, quiet! We don't want her to know we're here. And don't do anything till I say."

They didn't have to wait long.

* * * *

Jaada sat nervously on the edge of her bed, trying to concentrate on the text she was holding, but with little success. Her thoughts were continually drawn back to Jimmy, and she wondered what was taking him so long. He had promised to be at her house within half an oron. It was long past that already. Whatever could be keeping him? she wondered, frowning with worry.

With a snort of impatience, she tossed the text aside for the umpteenth time and jumped up, stomping toward the window, truly hoping to see him coming this time.

She shoved aside the window adornments again, to look outside, her cheek pressed against the glass as she angled her face to get a better view of the front walk to her right. She was greatly startled when the glass suddenly shattered beneath her as something crashed against the window, shattering it. With a loud gasp, she instinctively moved back, thankful that her athletic skills had honed her reflexes to a heightened level of response and prevented her from being badly cut by the streams of glass flying everywhere. As it was, one piece had put a slight gash in her brow that dripped blood down the side of her face.

Gaping in disbelief, she was even more stunned when two pairs of hairy male hands intruded through the broken window and snatched her by the arms as soon as a black tarp had been tossed over the ledge. Stunned by this, she tried shaking herself free, but to no avail. The men easily lifted her up and over the ledge without further injury, with one clamping a greasy palm over her mouth.

"Keep her quiet," he was cautioned. "Here." The man handed someone else a long piece of cloth he had torn from his shirt. "Tie this around her mouth. That should help." It took two of them to do it because Jaada squirmed so much, yet they did manage it. Then, ignoring the blood on her face and her efforts to free herself, one of the others grabbed her legs as his comrade took her by the arms as they ran back to their waiting rallid. Once inside, they laid her across their laps in the back, as the other two hurried into the front of the vehicle and drove it away from the Gellon residence, unaware that Jaada's mother had heard the breaking glass and was hurrying to investigate the matter. Unfortunately, by the time she reached Jaada's room, the four men and her daughter were already gone.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The disparaging climate on Ulstra that year brought a disproportionate windfall across the arid mining fields of Taforra, the location of the largest refinement facility in the galaxy. The need for much water there often posed problems for the cities and smaller settlements surrounding it. Often fighting over water rights in order to survive in the arid climate, the inhabitants of the region were becoming a headache for Kaanig Altair who was often called in to settle territorial disputes over water rights, a problem common to many of the systems.

Unfortunately, the smaller districts on Ulstra were often dominated by the larger cities lying along the borders of Rithda. Frequent squabbles often brought the Altair across great distances to Ulstra to settle them. Although consistent drilling for water in the areas was as common as the disputes, the levels found there were not as high as he would have liked.

Due to the richness of the ore prevalent in the region, Dammen had little choice but to keep the area stabilized. Training Jimmy Donaldson to oversee the mining operations at Taforra was one of the ways he hoped to free himself from the incessant territorial fighting so he would then be able to see to other important galactic matters. Once Jimmy was settled in there, then he could update him on the disputes and train him to take over the citizenry problems as well. Then pray that all would go well. He knew that Jimmy could well be trusted now with important matters such as these.

Right now, just trying to find time to remain at Travaar was growing increasingly difficult. He was worried now that he may not have made the right decision where Cassia was concerned. It nagged at him that something may have gone wrong in his planning to have his half-brother, Menakam M'yata, kidnap her, and it was interfering with his normal, brilliant efficiency in the governing of his world. Wanting to mold Cassia into the woman he wanted and needed to rule beside him was why this had come about to begin with. He hoped that personal experience would help her understand and accept her position as Kaaniga of the galaxy. He believed that rescuing her from her terrible situation would help her come to trust him more.

"Maka," he swore the afternoon of the attack on Jimmy Donaldson, right after his viceroy – his *ba'astran*, Iddo Aemons, had notifed him of his life mate's preplanned kidnapping. "Now what?" He was sitting behind his desk aboard *Le'pra Zh'r*, having been readying himself to leave for Planet Vultron to rescue Cassia, when Jeiel Vernier contacted him.

Dammen had been solarities without sleep and was returning home to Konatha for some well-needed rest when Iddo's comtag had come through earlier. Usually traveling through the *ga'lif* to reach Ulstra, he was glad he had been aboard ship at the time. Initially, it had been necessary for Dammen to board his own ship in order to launch new water probes in the more desolate areas of Ulstra. He could have delegated the matter to those in charge of those areas, but he felt it would be quicker and more efficiently handled if he just did it himself.

"I am sorry, Majesty," Cambra Vernier replied quietly, through his *d'lab'r*. "But we did not foresee the taking of Jaada Gellon until it was too late. No sooner had I left Jimmy's bedside when I received an urgent comtag from Astar Gellon to report the situation. It appears she may have been taken by the same group that attacked Jimmy."

Dammen gave a frustrated sigh. “All this because Jimmy beat up a few of her classmates at the dance?”

“It would appear so, Ziros.”

“Find these men, Jeiel. I want them in custody as soon as possible. Find them and hold them until I return. I cannot deal with this situation just now. I’m too distracted worrying over Cassia's safety to handle this in a normal fashion.”

“I understand, Ziros,” the cambra said. “I have already contacted our men who will be waiting for you on Vultron, as I'm sure Iddo informed you.”

At mention of this, Dammen fell silent as he considered the two simultaeous kidnappings, one planned, the other not.

“Yes, Jeiel, he did. I am heading there now.”

“So,” Jeiel continued, his eyes narrowing as he considered this, “do you have further instructions for me then?”

“Yes,” came the response. “Keep Jimmy in that fanged bed until I say otherwise. I want you to find Jaada and bring her safely home. That’s your top priority, Jeiel. No harm must befall either of them again. And don’t harm the men who are guilty unless you find it necessary. I prefer to deal with them myself when I get back.”

“Aye, Ziros. Understood.” Jeiel nodded in obeisance, his own plans formulating in his brain. “It will be as you say.”

“Oh, and Jeiel….”

“Ziros?”

“Be careful out there.”

“I will, Ziros. Thank you.”

With that, the communication ended and the two friends moved to complete their separate missions, both concerned more about Jaada and Cassia’s safety than their own.

* * * *

Jaada was sitting tied up on a box crate in some warehouse, apparently owned by the one of the men who had stolen her away. Squirming, she was trying desperately to loosen the bonds on her wrists and ankles, groaning softly against the dirty rag they had stuffed into her mouth and secured there with another. The four watching her as they paced around only unsettled her further, their lascivious stares often causing her to lose hope of being rescued until after something terrible happened to her.

“You ain’t going nowhere,” one of the older men said, his crass Degman dialect betraying his lower societal upbringing. He smirked at her useless efforts to free herself. “At least until we’re done with you.”

“Yeah,” the other father smirked, leering at her with his rotting teeth. “Once the boys here have had a little taste, then we’ll let you go back to yer boyfriend, assuming he’ll still want you.” At this, they all laughed at some shared joke before one of the elders gave one of the younger men a shove in her direction.

“Go on, Zan’d. Now’s as good a time as any.”

Zan’d seemed anxious as he stared at Jaada and kept running a nervous hand across his mouth. He had shared a history class with her and never imagined being in such a situation with her. But his father was insisting he have his revenge against Jimmy Donaldson by violating his woman. Although she was extremely beautiful by Valtorian and even Degman standards, taking her by force wasn’t something he actually felt like doing. Still, with his father and friends urging him forward, he knew he had no choice but to complete the task they had set out to do.

“Come on, boy! You scared?” Zan’d’s father gave him another shove, amid the loud guffaws of the other three. “You ain’t still a virgin, are ya?”

Zan’d whipped his head around to glare at the husky oaf.

“Be quiet, s’lpa! I’m working myself up to it.”

“Here,” the other father interrupted. “Let me make it easier. Should have thought of this before.” In a flash, he was hoisting Jaada up by her wrists, bound behind her back, ignoring her pained whimpers. He moved to attach her then to a large grappling hook hanging overhead. He had quickly untied her hands, only to retie them over her head so he could hook her ropes tightly over the hook.

With Jaada now in that inviting position, the three other males gasped at sight of her breasts jutting tightly against her blouse, as she squirmed to try and free herself. Her fearful moans were ignored as they all leered at her, advancing toward her with lustful intent.

Unable to control his curiosity, Zan’d’s elder reached over and tore open her blouse.

“Fang, but you’re fine,” he groaned, looking her over. “We’re gonna have a good time with you.”

Crying now, Jaada screamed inwardly, virginal fear kicking in. After all the sacrificing she had done for Jimmy and now….this.

“All right now, fellas,” Zan’d’s father said, directing them away. “Let’s let Zan’d here have a moment alone with the vixen. She’s not going anywhere, so I think we can afford him a little privacy.” He put his hands to the back of his son’s shoulders to whisper gleefully in his ear. “Okay, son. This is it. Your moment of revenge. Go for it.”

Zan’d sheepishly made a slow move forward, glancing back to make sure the others were leaving. Once the warehouse door had closed behind them, he refocused his attention on Jaada. Clearly frightened, she was doing her best to free herself, frantically pulling down on the hook in an effort to tear through the ropes holding her there.

Licking his lips, Zan'd moved closer and was just about to remove her gag to kiss her when someone purposely and insistently bashed open the warehouse door behind him. Startled at sound of the heavy metal crashing into the wall, a stunned Zan’d jerked around to find a bevy of armed imperial

warriors rushing in toward him. A gasp of disbelief escaped him as he dropped his hands and started running. Only he was too slow for the highly trained H'San. Shoving him to the cement floor, they slammed his face into it, ignoring his loud shriek of pain as they yanked his arms behind him, securing his wrists, before dragging him back onto his feet.

Words could not describe the feeling of overwhelming relief that hit Jaada at site of the imperials coming to her rescue. As she watched a humiliated Zan'd being carted off by the two men who had downed him, she ignored her own embarrassment at site of Jeiel Vernier entering and briskly hurrying toward her.

"Are you all right?" he asked softly, ignoring her exposure as he reached up to untie her hands. Nodding, she gave a slight nod as she rubbed her sore wrists. As the cambra reached behind to remove her gag, she immediately snatched the frayed remnants of her favorite blouse together and ducked her head in shame.

"How…did you find me so...quickly?" she managed, still shaking. "I was afraid no one would."

Jeiel put a protective arm about her to lead her outside, snorting. "The idiots have big mouths and big reputations. It wasn't too difficult. All we did was track down their vehicles and found one of them parked outside."

Jaada couldn't help it then. She felt so violated. And she'd been so afraid that, still shaking, she helplessly collapsed against the cambra, sobbing. Burying her face against his massive chest, a hand covered her mouth as a wellspring of tears burst forth, soon dampening his shirt. Understanding, he stopped to pull her closer, allowing her the moment as he motioned his men away. When she was able to contain herself, she apologized and allowed him to lead her to an awaiting vehicle. But, instead of taking her home as she expected, their journey ended before the doors of a large medical facility several korons away.

"We need to have you checked out before I take you home," Jeiel said, directing her inside and to a large turbo unit. Once it arrived on the seventh floor, they stepped out, and Jeiel purposely led her to the end of the long hall. He rapped softly on one of the doors before opening it to allow her inside the room. "I will wait here," he told her, a slight grin on his face.

Hesitant, Jaada stepped softly into the room, only to pause in surprise at sight of Jimmy propped up in bed with a *v'd'mr* monitor in front of him. Her eyes widened at the bruises on his face. His bottom half was covered by some blankets, but his magnificent torso, also bruised and bandaged, was bare to her hungry gaze, making her forget all she had been through. At sight of her, Jimmy brightened and shoved the screen away, awaiting her with open arms.

"Jaada!"

"Oh, Jimmy," she said, hurrying over to throw her arms about him. She fumbled with her torn blouse as he crushed her against him, kissing her. But he was quick to sense something wrong and set her away.

"What is wrong?" he asked in concern, studying her more closely. "What has happened? Your eyes are all red. You've been crying."

Starting to cry again, Jaada ducked her head, unable to say anything. Drawing her into bed with him, Jimmy held her tightly against him, gently rubbing her back and occasionally kissing the top of her head.

"I was…taken," she began finally, before managing to pour out the entire tale for him to hear.

"So Jeiel brought you here to me?"

"Yes. He said I was supposed to be checked out before he could take me home. Instead, he brought me to you."

Jimmy smiled gratefully. "Great guy, Jeiel. I can see why Dammen keeps him around." He paused. "Those must have been the same men that beat me up."

"Because of what happened at the dance?"

"Yep. Sore losers, those fellas. But I doubt they'll be getting revenge on anyone else any time soon. Dammen will see to that, I'm sure."

Realizing her disheveled state, Jaada then sat up and drew her open shirt closed. "They almost did to me what you chose not to do, Jimmy. I was so scared. Had Jeiel not arrived when he did, I don't know what might have happened."

Jimmy's face became a dark frown of fury as he reached out a hand to the back of her neck and pulled her face to his.

"But he *did* rescue you in time, Jaada. Don't forget that. Nothing happened that was a result of anything you did. And even had something happened, it would not have mattered to me. I love you and still want you. I always will. You're so beautiful though," he choked suddenly, stiffening beside her. "I can't imagine you being with anyone else."

"You'll never have to worry about that happening," she promised. "There will never be anyone else for me. Only you." She stretched out, lying full length against him, her cheek carefully resting on his awesome chest as she caressed him. "I don't want to share you with anybody and will resist anyone who tries to take me away from you. I guarantee it."

Chapter Twenty-Five

Jaada awoke the next morning to the sound of Degman sprites, tiny birds of extraordinary and vibrant color, singing outside her window. Having been replaced with reinforced paning, the window would no longer invite such an incident as Astar's only daughter had suffered through, not if her father could help it. He had spent all of yesterday replacing the broken glass to his satisfaction, anything to keep his mind off the fate that might have befallen Jaada. When Cambra Vernier finally brought her home safe and sound late the night before, he had embraced her with more affection than ever he had displayed before, and it warmed Jaada's heart knowing how much her father cared for her.

"I am all right," she had told him when he finally released her to her mother's relieved arms. "The cambra rescued me, then took me to the medical center. The physicians there said I would be fine but that I should stay home and relax for a few solarities until I felt a little better."

"She's been through a great deal," Jeiel had informed her family, "but suffered no physical injuries, only that small cut on her forehead. She just needs a few solarities to calm herself. She had quite an experience, I'm afraid."

Jaada gave him a grateful look, happy that he had refrained from mentioning that he had taken her to see Jimmy before bringing her home. Before leaving, he gave her a knowing look and a pat on the arm as he walked past her and out the door.

"The culprits have been caught and will be punished," he said in parting. "Have no doubt on that."

"Thank you, Cambra," her father said, hurrying to see him out. "We are most appreciative of all your help."

When he had gone, Astar Gellon turned back to give Jaada an affectionate grin. "Perhaps some *tan'tmon* and a hot bath would be in order. Go on then and we'll be along in a while to bid you good night."

"All right," Jaada said, still holding the ends of her torn blouse together. How she wished she could have spent the night with Jimmy at the medical center, but Jeiel had insisted she return home to her worried family. Forced to agree with his reasons, she had complied with his wishes and allowed him to bring her home, after he had the medical team there check her over.

After a long, hot bath which helped ease her aching muscles, she lolled her head back in the tub, settling herself against the smooth porcelain, glad to have such luxury in her home. Most of the places they had lived in the galaxy only contained the mineral showers that were so popular among military families because they were a quick and convenient means of bathing. Having both a tub and a shower in their new home on Degma was indeed a welcome treat, particularly for the ladies of the house.

As she lay there soaking, the hot water content with smoothing ointments and bubbling lotions, her thoughts soon returned to her last moments with Jimmy. Faith, he was so sexy, even lying in a sick bed.

Sighing with longing, she gave herself a sudden shake, knowing her parents would be coming soon with her cup of hot *tan'tmon*, a favorite and popular Degman beverage that closely resembled Zarconian chocolate. She didn't want them to find her daydreaming in the tub, so she made haste then to rise up from the cooling water to dry off and dress. When they arrived not long thereafter, she reveled in their presence and obvious affection for her before crawling into bed.

And as she lay there thinking how wonderful it was to have such doting parents, she grew sad at thought of all that Jimmy Donaldson had lost over the scalons. She vowed that once they were legally joined, she would never allow him such pain ever again. No one should ever be that alone, she decided, and she turned over in her soft bed, silently thanking the Almighty for the wonderful men who had taken it upon themselves to raise Jimmy as their own.

*** * * ***

"Hold them until the Altair returns," Jeiel told the two burly guards as they shoved the four males into a large holding cell below Travaar. "He will deal with them himself."

"Aye, Cambra." One of the H'San slammed the doors shut authoritatively, automatically locking them. At the same instant, the two eldest prisoners, the angriest of the four, spun about to ram the doors with their weight, in an effort to break through.

"You're gonna regret this, you will! How dare you hold us like this."

Jeiel, who was just about to leave, exchanged frowns with his men, then moved to stare at the older men. "You violate the law and then have the audacity to say this to me?" His voice was low, with an icy edge to it that the men ignored.

"You'd never even been around our area till that boy showed up," came the angry retort from one of the fathers of the two boys in the cell with them. "After what he did to our sons, you're fanged lucky he ain't dead."

"What are you saying? Is this a confession?"

"So what if it is?" the man snorted, only to be elbow-punched by his partner at relaying this information. "Who is that fanged boy to you anyways?"

Jeiel's black eyes glittered furiously as he eyed the duo, then their two sons standing behind them. After a moment, he turned and began walking away. "That boy," he began over his shoulder. "His sister…"

"Yeah?" the man grunted curiously, sarcastically.

"His sister… is *Kaaniga* of Valtor."

Stunned by Jeiel's words, the men fell away from the door, gaping, aware now that they had committed an unpardonable crime and that their fate was sealed. That the Altair had taken a life mate was not yet common knowledge, but the men's ignorance of this was still no excuse for what they had done to Jimmy. They both knew it.

Groaning, the two older men gnashed their teeth and growled in rage, knowing now that the Altair would show them no leniency for the crimes they had committed. By assaulting Jimmy

Donaldson and kidnapping Jaada Gellon, they had unknowingly, yet deliberately, attacked the family of Kaanig Altair and anyone close to him. Speechless, they could only express their guilt and remorse loudly as they fell helplessly to their knees when they finally realized what they had done. With arms cradling their heads in dismay, their countenance fell as both men ducked their heads in shame before their sons, knowing there was no one who could help them now.

Chapter Twenty-Six

The group of miners stood near the door of the mine shaft, watching as Cambra Jeiel Vernier disembarked from his ship, with Jimmy Donaldson in tow. It was bad enough the Altair had brought Jimmy Donaldson to Taforra to begin with. Now, to have Cambra Vernier show up unexpectedly was just as unsettling to them.

"I don't know what's going on," one man said, recalling all too well how Jimmy Donaldson had beaten him up in the food court several mentas previously. "But I'm getting fanged tired of having all these superiors walking around here, interfering with our work."

"Yeah," another miner added. "It don't look good, does it? Having both of them here within mentas of each other."

"I'm still curious about that boy," another said, wiping a grimy sleeve across his mouth. "It don't make no sense. Why would they bring a Zarcon to this part of the galaxy?"

"I'll bet he's a spy," the first man said. "Can't be any other reason for it. He's probably been telling the Kaanig all about what we do here. An informant, he is."

The words had the desired effect as grunts of agreement rent the air about the nine men, although there really was no basis for the trouble now brewing. They had all been soundly whipped by Jimmy Donaldson and had been looking for any reason to get back at him since that solarity. Their pride had been stung, so revenge was their only real motive against the boy.

The leader of the group spat a nasty wad of snuff into the dirt, jerking his neck about to look at his coworkers.

"I say we take care of him before we all lose our jobs. That Zarc ain't nothin' but trouble, I'd say. Better to be rid of him now."

One of his comrades smacked him on the back to draw his attention. "How would we do that, Bern?" he asked. "Especially with the Cambra here and all. Do you want to get us all vaporized?"

"If that boy is reporting to him every solarity, then I'd say it's worth the risk, don't you? Who knows what lies he's been telling the sups."

"How do you know he is?"

Bern shot him a foul look. "Look it. If you don't want to be a part of this, then beat it. If so, then shut up till we get a plan together. We can't let Vernier know what we're up to. Or Farrel, for that matter. We need to make that Zarc disappear before he causes us any more trouble."

"So, what do you plan to do? Kill him?" another fellow piped up. "Little drastic, ain't it? We don't even know for sure if he's been blabbing."

Bern turned to face him, his jaw wired with rage. “Donaldson has the ear of both of ‘em,” he countered loudly. “Do you think he didn’t tell them about the food court incident? That’d be unlikely.”

“But...all we’ve done is drink on the job,” came a small protest from another bystander. “Surely they’ve known about that for awhile now. We haven’t done anything else that would warrant us committing murder.”

Bern glared at the man, ignoring the calm reasoning of his words. “I say we get rid of the boy before anything goes down,” he said. “Why take a chance at losing our jobs?”

“But, you don’t know if--”

“*Quiet, Antran!* Nobody cares what you think.”

The shorter man fell silent then, realizing that Bern already had his mind made up. Granted, Jimmy Donaldson had humiliated them all, but so what? They had started the altercation, and the odds had been in their favor. So why punish the boy for knocking some sense into them? If anything, they should have been more impressed with him than anything else.

“Let’s go, men,” Bern said, drawing them away. “We can talk amongst ourselves down in the shaft. I think I’ve got an idea already, and we don’t need anybody else listening in.”

As the group of burly, grizzled miners followed him inside, only Antran hesitated before going in. He didn’t like what Bern was planning already. Not one bit.

* * * *

“Ready, overseer?”

Jimmy Donaldson grinned. “Yes, Cambra,” he said. “I am.”

Jeiel nodded, putting a hand to his back. “Good, then let’s begin.”

He led Jimmy inside the huge office building opposite the quarries for the grand tour of the entire operation. Jarrel Fanta accompanied them so he could be kept abreast of all Jimmy was being told and to add any useful information needed. Two orons later, they entered the *stel* for afternoon repast.

“Any questions so far, Jimmy?” Jeiel asked as he sampled the food on his plate. “I know it’s a lot to take in, but I know you’ll get the hang of things after awhile. And Jarrel is always here to help you, too.”

Jimmy nodded. “Yeah,” he agreed, lifting a beverage to his lips.

“You do understand that Dammen and I will always be available to your questions, right?”

“I didn’t think you would leave me here all alone,” Jimmy replied. “But, like you said, Jarrel is here, too. So he can help me out, if necessary.”

“Glad to do it, Ziros,” Fanta said, still unable to believe that the youth was now his boss. He wasn’t angry about it, only disappointed that he hadn’t been promoted to the position that Jimmy had

been given. He had given over 25 scalons to the refining operation, never expecting Kaanig Altair to pull something of this magnitude. Still, he figured his sovereign must have had a good reason for having selected the boy for such a responsibility. "You can come to me any time, Jimmy. *Any* time."

As Jarrel sliced off a piece of the juicy grendel steak on his plate and put it in his mouth, his attention was suddenly drawn to the group of miners who had just entered the building and were noisily plodding past them. Since Jimmy was also facing the door, he was the first to observe them. He recognized the same nine men he had had *words* with not too long *ago.*

But only Jeiel seemed to notice the evil looks they gave Jimmy as they moved past them. His eyes widened in surprise as he glanced between them and Jimmy, who had now focused his attention on his plate. Jimmy seemed unconcerned by their presence, but a cold feeling rankled his own neck as he observed the miners. One he couldn't shake.

"Any problems with those men?" Jeiel asked, indicating the miners who were now sitting at tables in the far corner of the room.

At this, Jimmy raised his head to glance back at the miners. He shrugged, pretending ignorance of them.

"Nope. No problems." He bent his head to resume eating. "At least nothing I can't handle."

Jeiel frowned, having caught the gist of his words. Jimmy *had* had an altercation with the group but had taken care of them in his usual fashion. He grimaced as he realized the situation then turned a frown of dismay on Fanta. But Jarrel, too, shrugged in ignorance, unaware of what had happened between Jimmy and the miners.

Jeiel sighed softly as he focused on his own plate. He knew then he had to keep a closer eye on the group. Yet even as he tried to ignore them, he could still feel their eyes boring into him. He lifted a curious glance to them, already sensing they were up to no good.

"Jarrel," he said in a low voice. "I want files on each of those men."

The foreman shot a nervous glance at the group, only now becoming aware that they were the focus of the miners' attention.

"Ah, yes, Ziros," he said. "Right after repast."

"And Jimmy?" Jeiel said, his tone rigid.

"Yeah?"

"Have nothing more to do with those men. Give them a wide berth. Do you understand?"

Jimmy lifted startled blue eyes to his black gaze. "Um, okay. Whatever you say."

But Jeiel clamped a firm hand on his wrist, halting his eating efforts. "I'm serious, Jim," he said, his intent clear. "*Stay. Away. From. Them.*"

"O-Okay," Jimmy said, a slight tremor in his voice. "I understand. Yeesh."

Jeiel stared at him a moment then released him. He relaxed back in his seat, draping an arm across the empty seat

beside him.

"Now finish up. We've a lot more to do today."

"Yes, Cambra."

* * * *

Jimmy frowned down at his plate. Only then did he realize just how dangerous those men actually were. If Jeiel had concerns about them, then surely he never should have fought them to begin with. But what was he supposed to have done? Let them beat him to a pulp instead? They were the ones who had, in fact, started the argument.

Realizing for the first time that there again might be repercussions to his behavior, he felt an icy fear wash over him as he recalled the recent beating he had suffered on Degma, one that had nearly cost him the girl he loved.

The joy of the solarity soon went out of him.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

"*Damn it, Jeiel!* Have we created a monster? Did we teach him nothing except how to fight with his fists through all of his personal conflicts?"

Kaanig Altair railed at his top man, running an angry hand through his long black mane as he glared at Jeiel across the *miÆ*.

"I thought we had done a better job myself," the cambra answered quietly, his lips creased into a thin line. "Perhaps Jimmy is just a show off."

"Or maybe he really didn't have any options left."

Dammen bit his lip in indecision, not certain how to handle his young protégé's latest occurrence.

"Move him out of the barracks," he ordered. "As overseer, he needs his own space anyways, some privacy. Well away from the miners would be advisable."

"Perhaps building him a house on the outskirts of the plant would be a solution, Majesty. There we could post guards to keep him out of trouble. Also while inside the gates of the operation itself."

"Make it so, Jeiel. I don't want Jimmy getting himself into any further trouble. Pissing off the help wasn't something I expected to happen. If Jimmy has a fist fight with everyone who dislikes him, then we'll never get anything accomplished." Dammen stared at his friend a moment. "Other than that, how are things going with his training? Anything I should know about?"

"No, Ziros. Everything is right on schedule. Jimmy understands why he's there and seems greatly interested in learning everything I throw at him."

"Well, that's something anyways." Dammen relaxed somewhat, dropping his gaze. "All right then. Just get that house built and Jimmy moved in as quickly as possible. In the meantime, move him out of the barracks. He'll be targeted unless we move him now."

"Understood, Ziros. He can stay aboard *Kaljha'me*, with me."

"I'll wait for your report then, Jeiel." With that, the *miÆ* went blank.

Frowning as he considered the matter, it was a moment before Jeiel returned to the pile of personnel folders Fanta had given him. It seemed that most of the nine men Jimmy had tangled with were decent employees. But only one had a criminal record a koron long. It was this man that concerned Jeiel the most, so he wasted no time in posting a few guards about the work site before hurrying off to see to the construction of Jimmy's new home.

* * * *

Dar and Pada gazed up at the massive structure in awe.

"Imagine living in that place," Dar said with wishful attitude.

"Yeah," Pada replied. "It's almost as unbelievable as having Jimmy Donaldson as overseer now. He's so young. Not even twenty cycles yet."

"He must be special to the Kaanig, or he never would have built the boy his own house or given him such responsibility."

“I guess the Altair don’t want no more problems with the ore,” his companion said. “Remember that last batch that he shipped back from Azor. Contaminated, they said. I bet Jimmy’s here to make sure that doesn’t happen again.”

“You can bet on it,” Dar said. “That’s probably been the reasoning all along.”

“Well, he’s a fine lad. I’m sure he’s just what we’ve been needing around here. With the Altair and Cambra behind him, there’s no telling how much power that boy will yield.”

“You’re right there, Pada. Maka. Can you believe it took only three mentas to build that?” They turned their attention once more to the mansion, until the sound of Jimmy Donaldson’s familiar voice directed them away when he came running over to stand beside them.

Jimmy snorted as he peered up at the large structure. “It would seem so. I don’t know what I’m going to do with so much space though. You’ll have to come and visit me sometime. Maybe I’ll have you over for evening repast sometime. To thank you for all you’ve taught me.”

Surprised by this, both men turned new eyes on him. “We’d like that,” came the response, their eyes crinkling with pleasure.

“Soon,” Jimmy said. “I’ll arrange things and let you know.”

The men nodded agreeably, both considering the offer.

“Well, I guess you’d better get back to work,” Jimmy said, putting on his invisible overseer’s hat. “We’ve a lot of work to do. The Altair wants triple the amount of ore out by scalon’s end, to make up for all the worthless stuff that came out of the mines last scalon.”

Both men relaxed their crossed arms, their dark eyes widening in surprise at hearing this information.

“By all means,” Dar said, realizing that their assumption was correct as to why Jimmy was there. “We’ll get right on it. Sounds like a lot of overtime coming our way.”

“Yep,” Jimmy grinned, crossing his own arms as he stepped back to admire his new house. “You’ll be putting in some long orons for awhile, I’m afraid. But don’t worry,” he said. “If all goes well, there may be a nice bonus in it for you.”

Brightening at this, the men beamed at him, then hurried off to share the news with their fellow miners. They had only wandered by to check out the new house anyways.

* * * *

As Jimmy watched them amble away, he felt a surge of satisfaction flow through him. They were good men, and he had every intention of keeping his promise to have them over for repast sometime. Still, he knew he had to be careful. He didn’t want anyone thinking he was playing favorites. He had no intention of angering the rest of the help as he had before. That would definitely be the wrong thing to do at this point. Especially now, when things were going so well for him.

Smiling at his good fortune, he turned to enter his new abode, anxious to settle in. He was going to miss being with Jeiel on *Kaljha'me*, but having his own house was certainly exciting. With this and his new position at Taforra, he felt certain the Altair might finally let him join with Jaada, so it was the only thing on his mind just then. He dashed to his new office, sprinting over the threshold to access the *miÆ* so he could discuss it with him. As he anxiously waited for Dammen to answer his page, he prayed that Jaada would soon be his.

Chapter Twenty-Eight

Years of bricklaying, hoisting barrels full of ore, and shoving trams down in the mine made it easy for Bern and his cronies to knock out the imperial guards stationed outside the security gate of Jimmy Donaldson's new home. The guards didn't stand a chance of defending themselves when swarmed on all sides by men of equal or even greater strength. Not expecting an attack, the H'San never had a chance to even draw their weapons.

Bern was quick to lead his men into the walled yard. Some surrounded the house, securing the back entrance so Bern and two of his men could smash through the heavy front door. The door was solid and secured from inside, yet the brawny miners, with their combined weight against it, easily managed to break through. Once inside, they clambered up the wide staircase to where they figured Jimmy's bedchamber was.

Jimmy was jolted from a sound sleep by a loud cracking sound as his front door was bashed in. He was barely awake when the three miners came charging up the stairs and barged into his room unannounced. His reactions were slow, so there was little he could do to ward off the intruders. In the time it took for him to blink at the hulks violating his privacy, he was knocked unconscious, bound, then carried off into the night.

*** * * ***

Jimmy awoke to find himself alone in the dark, still bound, helpless to free himself. His skull felt like it had been hit by a steel mining rod, and he had a throbbing headache. He had been away from Earth a long time, so some things were now fuzzy in his brain about his past.

He lay moaning on his side, on a cold, muddy floor, having little doubt as to what had happened to him. What he hadn't counted on though was waking up in what appeared to be a mine shaft. He could smell the familiar dampness of the underground cavern as he lay there, the cool, humid air plugging his sinuses so bad they hurt. He wondered why the miners couldn't have been a bit more creative in their choice of a holding area.

"So," Bern said, suddenly standing over him to shine a light in his face. "You're awake. Too bad. It would have been a blessing had you remained unconscious." At the puzzlement in Jimmy's crinkled eyes, he smirked. "This is an old shaft, in case you were wondering, *Zy Overseer*. It was abandoned about thirty scalons ago, when they found groundwater seeping into it. By 1700 orons, you should be completely submerged. But I doubt anyone will find you until it's too late." He laughed then, at the fear that flashed across Jimmy's features at this revelation. "I'm afraid it's the end of the road for you. The end of your budding career." Finding that even more humorous, he guffawed loudly and departed, leaving Jimmy to die alone in the pitch blackness of the abandoned mine.

Chapter Twenty-Nine

It was as he had feared.

Jeiel Vernier stared in dismay at the destruction he encountered at Jimmy's new home. Having awakened early to check on him, Jeiel was glad he had arrived there when he had. Finding his own two men lying unconscious on the ground was not something he had expected to see. Once certain they were all right, he hurried inside the violated house, furious at finding the front door busted in and Jimmy missing.

Lifting his wrist, he gave an immediate order into his *d'lab'r*: "Locate the nine men we investigated and bring them to me. Outside the refinement area." *Maka*, he cursed silently. Had he taken action against the men sooner, he knew that Jimmy would still be warm in his bed and laughing at his concern. As it was, a deep feeling of dread swept over him at sight of Jimmy's empty, rumpled bed, at the signs of whatever struggle he had made upon being ousted from it. A heavy guilt at his failure to act sooner encompassed his heart as he raced back to sound the alarm. He wondered how Dammen would react when he learned that his young protégé was missing. It was something he certainly didn't want to consider just then.

* * * *

Freezing, foul-smelling water had been rising in the cavern for orons. Still groggy and disoriented, Jimmy did his best to get to his feet in an effort to keep his head above water. He propped himself haphazardly against the slimy wall behind him. He wondered what oron it was and figured he didn't have much time. The stinking water was already up to his knees.

If his feet weren't bound so tightly, he thought perhaps he could stumble around and try to find a way out. But it wasn't possible. Swearing an oath, he made a valiant effort to free his hands, twisting and jerking them against the strong tape binding them behind his back. He rubbed the tape against a rock jutting out from the wall, but it didn't seem sharp enough to make any difference. The water was rising so quickly, it kept the tape wet, slippery, and unmanageable.

Groaning in frustration, he put his head back against the wall and squeezed his eyes shut. He didn't know if anyone would ever find him and didn't know if anyone had even missed him yet. Faith, was he to die in the clammy depths of the disgusting liquid devouring him alive? The Stygian darkness of the shaft prevented him from seeing anything. Yet he could hear the water trickling in from various places, as if it was intent on seeking him out deliberately.

A memory flashed through his mind then, of the day he and Jaada had ducked into that cave along the beach. He wished now he had made love to her. At least he would have had that to remember before he drowned so horribly in this filthy water. Too angry to even cry over his circumstances, he dropped his head to his chest, praying his death would be swift and painless.

Sadly, all he could think of just then was of how much Jaada would miss him and of how much he truly loved her.

Chapter Thirty

Jaada peered out the window of the Kaanig's prized vessel, *Le'pra Zh'r*, her excitement mounting at thought of seeing Jimmy again. She had been as surprised as her parents when the Altair had contacted her father to invite her to visit Jimmy on Planet Ulstra.

"There's the refinement plant," Dammen said, directing her attention to the massive operation sprawled below them. He was standing beside her, sharing pleasantries. "We'll be landing shortly."

Jaada turned to grin up at him, her joy evident as she acknowledged his words. "He'll be so surprised to see me," she commented. "I can hardly wait."

Dammen chuckled, just as his *d'lab'r* beeped. "Excuse me," he said, moving away to answer the page. When he returned, his whole demeanor had noticeably changed, as if he was withholding some secret from her. "Strap in," he ordered brusquely, moving away. "We're about to land."

Jaada hurried to obey, snapping into her safety harness. She leaned her face against the port hole, peering down at the scenery below, hoping to catch sight of Jimmy. A moment later, she felt the easing of the thrusters and slow descent to the bumpy terrain beneath them, as the ship finally touched down. Straightening in her seat, she listened with anticipation as the descension mechanisms shut down, signaling the end of her journey. Unable to contain her excitement, she waited for the doors to open, ready to bound from her seat. Until the Kaanig stopped her.

"Not yet," he said. "Wait here until I return. I won't be long."

Jaada nodded and swallowed away her disappointment. She relaxed back in her seat as Kaanig Altair disembarked alone. Observing him from the port hole, she watched him exit the ship, strolling determinedly across the dusty landscape. She saw Cambra Vernier leave one of the buildings and move to greet him. By the serious expression on his face, she could tell something was wrong.

Her hands tightened on the armrests, her curiosity peaked, and she felt a twinge of fear as she eyed the two men. She so wanted to know what was happening. Tapping her foot impatiently, she waited for the Altair to come back aboard. She unsnapped her harness, just so she'd be ready when the time came to leave the ship.

"Come along," he said, when he finally reboarded the ship a few micron later. "It seems we have a problem."

"P-Problem?" she said, slowly rising to follow him outside. "What sort of problem?" When she came to stand beside them, she glanced nervously between him and the cambra.

The two leaders exchanged frowns, neither apparently wanting to be the one to tell her.

Dammen put a hand to her back and ushered her into the large building nearby. He directed her down a long, wide hallway, into a vacant office.

"Have a seat," he said, as he closed the door. He drew in his breath before facing her, his expression revealing that he wished things didn't have to be this way.

"It seems that Jimmy is...missing."

Jaada straightened in her chair, her eyes wide with concern. "What do you mean missing? As in gone? As in...not here?" she said, a tremor in her voice.

"I'm afraid so."

She couldn't believe her ears. After traveling all that distance to finally see him, only to learn... She stifled a sob,

and tears formed in her ebony eyes as she stared up at her sovereign.

“Do you...have any idea...where...he is?”

He sighed and shook his head. “Not yet, I’m afraid. Cambra Vernier is doing everything he can to locate him.”

“So what am I supposed to do?” she said, sadness oozing from her every pore. “I came all this way...”

“I know, Jaada, but please trust us to find him. I’m going to take you outside, but I’ll need to keep a guard on you so I don’t have to worry about you, too.”

Her face went blank as her gaze dropped to the floor. “I understand, Ziros. I’ll try not to get in the way.”

“I’m so sorry,” Dammen said with deep inflection. “But be assured. We *will* find him.”

At her nod, he moved to open the door. “Come with me.” With that, he led her back outside.

Jeiel was waiting for them and wasted no time. He led them across the wide expanse of dirt and gravel in the center yard of the facility, where several H’San were guarding a ragtag group of miners. Hundreds of other curious workers were hanging about on the outskirts, remaining close to the buildings. They were wise enough to stay a good distance away from the cambra and all the imperials. At sight of Kaanig Altair trailing him, their mouths dropped with dismay, so they moved to an even safer distance. Whatever was going on, they knew it wasn’t good. All mining operations had ceased at the cambra’s order, so there wasn’t much for them to do except wait anyways.

“Stay here,” Dammen told Jaada, as he motioned a man over to keep an eye on her. “Why don't you find a safe place to sit while we take care of this situation. I want you where I can see you. I don't want to have to worry about you, too. Otherwise, I'd leave you on my ship.”

“A-All right, Ziros.”

With sad eyes, Jaada glanced at the two leaders. Then she obediently followed the H’San across the field to a pile of cement blocks, shadowed by a small, tin-roofed storage shelter. She sat down, thankful the Altair had at least permitted her to observe what was going on. The heat was unbearable, since it was already mid-afternoon, so she was grateful for the shade. Even the ground was dry, with occasional gusts of wind blowing the dirt about into mini tornados.

Meanwhile, Jeiel was glaring at the burly miner in front of him when the Kaanig joined him. Although he didn’t interfere with the interrogation, Dammen merely stood aside, with arms crossed, and listened. Stone-faced, he gave no evidence that he was intently reading each man's thoughts.

“So you have no idea where Jimmy Donaldson could be?” Jeiel was asking the man before him. The man was bald and had a pinched, red face, and a bulbous nose. He was squinting up at Jeiel in the bright sunshine, his nose crinkled, but only shrugged at the question, pretending ignorance. “And what about you?” Jeiel asked the man standing beside him. “Same question.”

The responses were the same for him and even the next three men. When the cambra came to stand before Bern, his lips curled slightly as he studied the larger man. Slovenly and unkempt, as if he’d been up all night, the miner stood almost as tall and as broad as he did. Yet there was a meanness in his expression that only came as a result of spending scalons in prison, at the outer realm of Tango.

“And what about you?” Jeiel asked him. “What have you to say on the matter?”

The man spat at his feet. “I don’t know what yer talking about,” came the reply.

But one nod from Jeiel soon brought two of his warriors forward, to stand behind Bern. Grabbing him in a vise-like grip, they pushed him forward, away from the group, and shoved him to his knees. They held him there with his head down, twisting his arms out behind him in a painful manner to easily keep him in place, despite his efforts to resist.

“So,” Jeiel continued, strolling back and forth past Bern’s kneeling figure, “tell me again that you don’t know what I’m talking about.”

“I don’t know *anything!*” Bern ground out between clenched teeth. “Yer makin’ a mistake!”

Another slight nod from Jeiel soon brought the other eight men to their knees as well. Each was surrounded by two or more warriors who kept them at bay.

“Someone had better speak up soon or, believe me, you *will* regret it.”

But the men remained silent, not one yet willing to tell what had happened to Jimmy Donaldson.

“Hold them like that until I say otherwise,” Jeiel finally told his men. Shaking his head at the men's stubbornness, he motioned Dammen away, halting several criminas from them.

“Shady lot, aren’t they?” Dammen said, smirking as he looked back at them.

“Not all of them,” Jeiel said. He directed his attention to the slovenly miner. “Bern is the ring leader, and I think he’s the one responsible. He and a few others have done some time, but Bern is the worst. I don’t know what threat he believed Jimmy was to him, but I’m sure it has something to do with our presence here. That only tells me that he’s been doing things he shouldn’t be doing.”

“Maybe he’s the one responsible for that bad shipment of ore we received last scalon. The one we sent back.”

“Most likely.”

“We need to hurry this up, Jeiel. Jimmy’s life could be at stake.”

“I know.” Frowning at the men still on their knees, with their arms twisted uncomfortably behind their backs, Jeiel shook his head. “I’m sorry for not taking action sooner, Ziros. Had I done so, this might not have happened.”

“Well, there’s not much you can do about it. Right now, we need to find Jimmy.”

“Aye.”

Pursing his lips, Jeiel turned and made his way back to the group, with Dammen following.

“Secure the others,” Jeiel told his men. Then he motioned the two forward who were holding Bern. “Majesty,” he began, stepping aside to wave Dammen forward. “He’s all yours.”

“Release him and stand aside,” Dammen ordered as he moved to stand before Bern, who thought he might be getting a reprieve. Coughing and spluttering, he rose slowly to his feet, swaying a bit as he faced his sovereign lord.

“Thanks,” he said. “I told you I--”

But the Altair never gave him a chance to finish. With one upraised hand, he released a flaming blast of power that annihilated him on the spot. At this, the other miners screeched their displeasure and horror and fought even harder to free themselves from the grips of Jeiel’s men. Dammen glared at the group, ignoring the smell of crackling, burning flesh permeating the air.

“Him,” Dammen said, indicating a second man. “Bring him forward.”

“*No! No!”* the man screamed, trying to shake off the powerful hands holding him. When the H’Sans released him, he, too, was quickly exterminated, despite his attempts to flee.

A third was soon brought forward, crying as he tried to free himself. But before Dammen could raise a hand at him, another miner suddenly called out, halting him.

“*Please,”* the man pleaded, with tears of terror streaming down his face. “I’ll talk. Please don’t hurt him. Let him go. *Please.”*

“And you are...”

“Antran M’Gano, Ziros.”

Dammen moved in front of him, glaring down at him. “Let him up.”

When the warriors released him, the shorter man took a moment to regain his footing.

“So...talk.”

“I didn’t want anything to do with it, Ziros. I’m so sorry. The boy didn’t deserve what Bern did to him.”

“What exactly *did* he do?” Dammen asked calmly, a tic of rage in his cheek as he listened.

“He planned everything. *Everything.* He...took the boy and...”

“*I’m waiting.”* His tone clearly indicated a short fuse now.

Antran ducked his head then, as fear and regret washed over him. “He’s in the old abandoned mine shaft, Majesty. But you’d best hurry. The water’s rising.”

Dammen’s heart failed him then, at these words. Of all places to have taken the boy. “Hold these men till I return,” Dammen told the imperials, an icy rage gripping him. “Maintain these positions.”

With that, he and Jeiel hastened toward *Le’pra Zh’r*. Dammen waved at the man guarding Jaada.

“Get her aboard *now!*” he ordered. “And keep her in the ship’s lounge until further notice!”

*** * * ***

Jaada was disappointed but understood the urgency in Dammen’s tone and the need for her to remain out of the way. So, she settled herself in front of a public *v’d’mr* unit, the most Dammen could offer her while aboard his ship. She proceeded to occupy her time with current galactic events, anything to take her mind off what was happening.

Chapter Thirty-One

The frigid water was rising steadily in the black chamber. Jimmy did his best to maintain his footing but found it difficult as the pressure of the water pushed against him. It was already up to his neck and so cold, it made him shiver uncontrollably. As the liquid reached his chin moments later, he knew his time was short and that, despite his years of training, he was now as helpless as a newborn babe.

As he bounced up and down, buoyant in the slimy water, his bare feet kept sliding as it rushed about him. With his hands still secured, there was little he could do to grab hold of something. He pushed upward with his toes whenever he was able. Whatever he could do to keep his nose above water was to his advantage, but he was growing tired. Having been roused from his warm bed and plunged into this situation was the last thing he had ever expected. Exhausted at lack of sleep and at his frantic efforts to stay above water, he knew it would only be a matter of time before the opaque depths of it claimed him. Even now, as he thought about what else he could do to free himself, the water was rising, up past his mouth to cover his nose. He continually snorted it out, until it became impossible.

It didn't take long for the water to overtake him completely, but he used every ounce of strength he had left to repeatedly push himself up, out of the cold brine. Gasping for air each time he managed to emerge to a higher level, he sucked in a grateful breath of air before being sucked beneath it again and again.

He had gone under for the seventh time before losing consciousness. Too dizzy and weak at having taken so many repeated breaths, he finally succumbed to the chilling darkness. His last thought was of his sister who would now be alone in Valtor and of Jaada Gellon, the girl he loved beyond reason.

He believed he was too far gone, even when he felt the large hand on his shoulder, dragging him forth from his watery grave.

* * * *

A powerful warmth suffused Jimmy as he felt two large hands flatten against his wet chest. Awaking moments later, sputtering and coughing the disgusting water from his lungs, he felt himself being carefully rolled over onto his side so he could expel the foul liquid into the dirt beneath him. A blanket was quickly tossed over his soaked form, and his trembling hands reached over to snatch it closer about him.

As he continued spluttering and heaving forth the great amount of water from within him, he finally opened his eyes, realizing that he *was* still alive after all.

"Thank the Almighty," Dammen said, kneeling beside him. "We thought we'd lost you."

Jimmy squinted against the sunlight in his face as he looked over at the man beside him.

"You...found me?" he gasped in a shaky voice, still trembling uncontrollably. His teeth were chattering because of his body's hypothermic reaction to the glacially-cold water.

"Just barely," Dammen replied, putting a warm hand to his shoulder for a comforting squeeze.

"I'm so...c-cold," Jimmy rasped.

Dammen turned immediately to those behind him. "*More blankets!"* he snapped. "And prepare hot merida as soon as we're aboard."

Jimmy heard the affirmative response from Jeiel's voice, although he was still unable to sit up to see whoever else was there.

When the blankets were brought and wrapped snugly about him, he soon began to relax as the incessant chills dissipated.

"We'll get you aboard my ship and take you back to the plant, Jimmy. You need to get warmed up and put on some dry clothes. You'll need to rest awhile. You've had quite an ordeal."

"Th-Thank you, Ziros...Jeiel..." Fatigued, Jimmy was unable to prevent his heavy eyelids from closing as he uttered the words.

Without hesitation, Dammen then hoisted Jimmy into strong arms and carried him back to *Le'pra Zh'r*, unable to recall when he had last held him against his heart, as he had when Jimmy was still a child. As he considered how close he had been to losing him again, he felt a lump forming in his throat at his feelings for him. Few people held such a place in his heart as did this boy. Once aboard the ship, he was quick to lay him on a padded bunk in the quarters awaiting him.

"I know you've been up all night, James, but a hot mineral shower will do you good. But I don't want you leaving this ship until I tell you to," he said. "After you get warmed up, drink the merida Jeiel's getting you. Then get some sleep. We'll have a nice, hot meal for you later. You can put on some fresh clothes then."

"All-all right," Jimmy whispered. "And th-thank you for...saving me."

"I promised your father I would take care of you, did I not?"

Smiling, Jimmy opened his eyes to pierce him with that familiar blue gaze, his expression unfathomable. Moments later he found enough energy to sit up on his own. Pushing aside his blankets, he began stripping away the sopping wet clothes from his body. He discarded them in a pile on the floor.

"I'm glad you did," he replied. "You're my hero, Dammen. Always have been."

Warmed by his comment, Dammen grinned and reached out a hand to his shoulder. "Can you handle this alone, or would you like me to stay?"

"I think I can manage," Jimmy replied, slowly pushing his way off the bunk to trundle naked into the bath chamber. Dammen watched until Jimmy closed the door behind him. A wave of relief washed over him as he sadly considered how his life would be without Jimmy Donaldson in it. Once outside the room, only then did the mighty Altair lift a hand to wipe away the tears brimming in his own black eyes.

Chapter Thirty-Two

The nightmare wouldn't go away. Ever since his parents died, it had popped up repeatedly. Their loss was as raw now as it had been then. But Jimmy refused to share his pain with anyone. Now, the bad dreams were infused with memories of the drowning episode. As he relived the pain of his parents' deaths, he also relived his beating as a boy, then while on Degma, and then on Ulstra, as he struggled to breathe. But all he felt was the clammy grip of death as the frigid water overcame him and filled his nose, lungs, ears, and mouth. The terror he felt made his heart thud rapidly within him, and he awoke, gasping for one sweet breath of fresh air into his lungs.

He cried out in fear and quickly sat up, sweat suffusing him. Tossing aside his covers, he moved to the edge of his bunk. Leaning on his knees, he ran trembling hands through his golden locks as he tried to regain his sanity. Swallowing, he felt the cold chill sweeping over him as he sat there. Until he realized where he was and that he was not only awake but safe once more.

"Thank you, God," he whispered, closing his eyes and straightening to calm himself. When his heart rate regained some normalcy, he stood and made for the mineral shower. He needed to freshen up a second time, just to remove the sweat.

When he arrived for evening repast several orons later, he was startled to find Jaada waiting for him in the Kaanig's personal dining chamber.

"*Jimmy!"* she gasped, dashing toward him to fling her arms about him with relief. "I thought you'd never wake up."

He blinked in surprise. "What...are you doing here?" he asked, perplexed, thoughts of his near-death experience making him forget everything else at present.

She drew away, a shocked, hurt expression on her face. "Aren't you happy to see me?"

"I...am," he said. "I just didn't expect to see you...here."

She stepped away. "But aren't you glad I am?"

He smiled then and raised a hand to caress her cheek. "Yes," he breathed. "I am." Moving closer, he put his hand to the back of her neck and pulled her close. Angling his head, he slowly lowered his mouth to hers for a deep, heartfelt kiss, which she eagerly returned. When he finally drew away, it was to the sound of footsteps behind him as Dammen and Jeiel entered the room.

"Feeling better?" Dammen asked as he moved to take his seat at the head of the table prepared for them.

"Much," Jimmy answered, turning to look at him. Clasping Jaada's hand, he led her over to join him and the cambra, who had taken a seat beside Dammen.

"You certainly look better than you did a while ago," Jeiel said. "Not as wet anyways."

"Yeah. Certainly not that." Jimmy seated Jaada across from Jeiel, then took a seat beside her. "Thanks again for rescuing me. If it wasn't for you..." He gave an embarrassed frown, unable to finish.

Jaada shot him a look that spoke volumes. "They told me you were missing, Jimmy. What happened that you needed rescuing?" She glanced at the cambra with uncertainty. "Please tell me."

Jimmy pursed his lips, not wanting to explain anything. But he knew Dammen was expecting it. So, taking a deep breath, he proceeded to share with her the events that had led up to his abduction and attempt on his life. As he figured, Jaada didn't take the news very well. Her eyes widened, and she put a concerned hand on his arm.

"I would have died if Dammen and Jeiel hadn't gotten to me in time," he said, flashing them another grateful look. "I thought for sure no one would ever find me."

Tears erupted on Jaada's face as she looked at the two men beside them. "Thank you," she said. "If Jimmy had died, I don't know what I'd have done either."

At this, Dammen frowned, although he did understand how she felt. "Let's not go there, shall we," he said. "We *did* find him. We *did* rescue him. And now he is here, safe with us again. No more need be said on the matter."

"All right," Jaada said, understanding. "I won't mention it again, Ziros."

* * * *

But even as the matter was laid to rest, Jaada couldn't help but worry over the man she wanted to join with. As the three males began eating the sumptuous meal prepared them by the mess crew, it was all she could do to focus on her own plate. That she might lose Jimmy for good had never once occurred to her until now. It bothered her a great deal. However would she survive without him in her life, she wondered, were something terrible to happen to him again? The pain of losing him would be just too much to bear. As she considered this, her stomach knotted in fear, and tears again flooded her eyes. She kept her head down so no one would notice her crying again. But she had no idea that Kaanig Altair was reading her every thought and watching her with concern.

All she knew was that she loved Jimmy Donaldson and wanted to spend the rest of her life with him. She would do anything to keep him safe with her forever. Anything.

* * * *

Jimmy was still in recovery mode. Although he wanted time alone with Jaada, he just wasn't up to it. After evening repast, he made sincere apologies to his benefactor and mentor, bade Jaada's forgiveness, then retreated to his room. Falling back into bed, he lay there, an arm across his face, as he tried to forget the events of the past 24 orons. Any other solarity he would have eagerly jumped at the chance to be alone with Jaada. Tonight was a different story. His near-death experience had left scars he never would have believed, and he desperately wanted to feel as he had prior to the attempt on his life.

Chapter Thirty-Three

Jaada swept the tears from her face as she watched Jimmy hurry from the dining area. He had never dismissed her so completely before, and she had no idea what was happening between them. She had been so excited at thought of seeing him again, only to have him treat her like...this.

"Don't worry," said Kaanig Altair, eyeing her quietly. "He's still out of sorts because of what has happened. He is more aware of his mortality now, and I think it frightens him. Until he comes to grips with his feelings, it may be a little while before things return to normal."

Jaada lowered her head and nodded, though not fully understanding how Jimmy's feelings for her could have changed so abruptly.

"I'm sorry," Dammen said, rising from his seat to lay a hand on her shoulder. "Had I known of this beforehand, I would have delayed your reunion with him. But for now, I just ask that you please be patient. Jimmy will come around soon enough."

"But...what should I do in the meantime?" she asked, sadness evident in her tone. "I can't spend all my time here on the *v'd'mr.*"

Dammen exchanged looks with Jeiel, who had also risen from his place at the table and was listening intently.

"I will have Jeiel take both of you to Azor, to stay at Adoniah, until Jimmy recovers. You will have time alone with him there to rectify things." He paused as she considered this. "Is this to your liking? Or would you prefer to return to Degma?"

Her head shot up. "Oh, Azor, please," she said, her heart in her expression.

Dammen nodded. "I will notify your parents and explain the situation. Don't worry."

"Thank you, Majesty," she answered, brightening somewhat. "I would appreciate that."

When she left to return to her own designated quarters, Dammen directed Jeiel aside, into his office, for private conference.

"I want everyone involved in this incident sent to the Outer Realm," he told him. "Including those *bas'jits* being held at Travaar."

"For how long?" the cambra asked, having expected this.

"Twenty scalons for the fathers of the two boys who attacked Jimmy. Five for each of the boys. I'll reconsider dropping the boys' time to two, if their behavior warrants leniency at that time." He paused as he considered the men of Taforra. "As for the miners, twenty scalons as well. But give the informant only ten scalons, for his assistance. I want no leniency with these men. Had we not found Jimmy when we did, you and I both know he'd be dead now. As it is, he has obviously suffered some psychological damage that will take awhile to heal, if at all."

Dammen scowled, glaring at his desk as he considered his rage over the incident. “Considering my feelings, I would rather terminate all of them,” he said, “but because none of them succeeded, I am staying my hand. And,” he said, rising, “*that* is the only reason. Hopefully, none of them will be stupid enough to try something like this ever again. Next time they may not be so lucky.”

“Understood, Ziros. I’ll contact my men and give them the lowdown. They’ll know what to do.”

Dammen nodded. “Let’s call it a night then, Jeiel. And thanks again for your help...and your loyalty.”

Jeiel gave a half-smile of acknowledgment and saluted him, a hand to his shoulder as he bowed respectfully before his sovereign.

“My pleasure, Ziros.”

“Oh, and don’t forget to have Iddo notify the media. I want the entire galaxy to know what happens to those who hurt my family. And be sure to mention Bern and his men as well.”

When he had gone, Dammen sighed and settled back in his chair, frowning at the closed door. Then he rose to pour himself a glass of sharlok, hoping the drink would lift the heaviness from his own heart.

It was bad enough his worry over Cassia, thanks to his own stupidity. Now to have to worry over Jimmy’s safety only added to his concerns, along with other galactic considerations. Scowling, he tossed back the first glass of sharlok. He quickly refilled his glass, wondering how many it would take for him to drink himself into a forgetful stupor. But then, after thinking about it, he suddenly slammed the glass down, sloshing the expensive liquid onto the table, and headed for his prayer chamber.

Chapter Thirty-Four

It had been three solarities since the Altair had brought Jimmy and Jaada to Azor, leaving them in Jeiel's care. Since arriving at Adoniah, Jaada had seen little of her beloved. So it was with a heavy heart that she had chosen to take a stroll in the garden where Jimmy had kissed her. The day she and her family had been invited to Travaar for dinner with the Kaanig. The day Jimmy had asked her to join with him. She remembered it as if it was yesterday.

Pausing along the walk, Jaada breathed in the fresh air as she peered up at the two moons shining overhead. It was so beautiful there. So romantic. If only...but she quenched her longing, knowing there was no point in dreaming of something now that might never happen. Sighing, she smoothed out her dress, just for something to do, before continuing her walk.

It was the sound of someone diving into the large swimming pool behind Adoniah that caught her attention. The pool was well hidden behind the foliage and trees of the garden, so she followed the sound of splashing water. Soon she was stepping through some bushes to peek out at whoever was swimming there. Her heart stopped at sight of Jimmy crawling naked from the pool to stand by the edge. He moved a good distance away, then made a running, powerful leap, diving into the pool. Piercing the surface of the water with ease, he then swam across it and back again, apparently as skilled at swimming as he seemed to be at everything else.

Jaada's breath caught at sight of him when, after a few more laps, he stepped from the pool again, his long hair dripping about his broad shoulders. He appeared as a young demigod in the glistening moonlight, at least to Jaada, as she stood watching him from the sidelines.

Standing in the shadows, she ogled his naked body, sleek and muscular, as he strode across the cemented area. His arms were raised as he squeezed back the water from his hair, accentuating his powerful physique. Every bulge, every rippling ounce of flesh taunted Jaada as she gazed breathlessly at his youthful beauty. She licked her lips, her heart quickening as she imagined touching that fine form.

Her unbidden sigh drew his attention.

"Who's there?" Jimmy said, whipping his head around. Pausing, he dropped his arms and turned toward the sound.

Knowing it was pointless to remain silent, Jaada slowly stepped into the moonlight.

"It's just...me."

"Jaada?"

"Y-Yes."

He moved toward her, his gorgeous body clearly visible to her. She felt the heat rising to her face as her eyes slid from the top of him, all the way to the bottom.

“What are you doing? Spying on me?” he asked, although she heard the amusement in his voice. He seemed oblivious to his nakedness and made no effort to cover himself.

“I...y-yes,” she admitted with some reluctance, dropping her gaze.

He walked over to her. “See anything you like?”

“Yes.” And she knew her soft words gave him pleasure because he moved even closer. He reached out to knuckle her chin, forcing her gaze to his.

“What, Jaada?”

“*All*...of you,” she stated, hoping her blush wasn’t too obvious. “Every...*part* of you.”

He gazed at her a long time, making her wish she hadn’t been so direct and honest. But how could she not, when he was standing there like that?

“You know. I learned something. When I thought I was dying and would never see you again.”

“What?” she asked, her breath catching as he stared at her in the moonlight with those extraordinary blue eyes. She could feel the heat suffusing her lower body as he gazed at her, and she trembled.

“I learned that sometimes you have to act, not to wait. Because opportunities may be fleeting and may never come your way again.”

“What...do you mean?”

“Only this.”

He snatched her to him then, crushing her against his wet body as his lips claimed hers. A soft moan escaped her as she relinquished herself to his strength, enjoying the feel of him against her. She made no protest as he pulled her into the shadows and gently urged her to the ground, the grass wet and cold with evening dew against her back.

She knew she would allow him his way. It was what she had desired for so long. There was no way she was going to prevent it from happening. She was hot for him, and she could sense that he liked that. His kisses were hungry and frantic. And there was something different this time. Where before there had been a sense of restraint on Jimmy’s part, Jaada could now sense an uninhibited desperation. It was as though he felt this might be their only chance to act on what they had both wanted for so long. She knew Jimmy would not let this opportunity pass them by a second time.

“There’s no going back now, Jaada. I want this as much as you do.”

“Y-Yes,” she murmured against his burning lips, igniting a flame that consumed them for orons afterward.

*** * * ***

“Maximize his training, Jeiel. No holds barred.”

“Everything, Majesty?”

“Yes, everything. Every secret we’ve held back on. I want Jimmy’s training completed. He must never be caught helpless again. Forget the fact that he’s still young. He’s been through more in sixteen years than most men go through in a lifetime.”

“I agree,” Jeiel said, his focus on the *miÆ* monitor. “I’ll get on it as soon as possible. I’ll need to see which of my men is available right now to help out.”

“And how are things with Jimmy and Jaada? Any good news?”

Jeiel shrugged, pursing his lips in thought. “I’m not sure yet. The last I knew, neither were speaking nor were they even being seen together. Jaada seems to spend a lot of time walking in the garden. I did, however, get Jimmy to overcome his fear of water. I ordered him to go swimming.”

Dammen nodded. “I told him the same thing. So, did he hesitate about getting in the pool?”

“I’m not certain, Ziros. I caught him coming in late last night though. He was wet and...naked.”

“Naked?”

Jeiel snorted. “Yes. Jimmy said he didn’t have anything appropriate to swim in, so he decided on nature’s way.”

Dammen’s lips curled at this. “I see. Well, so long as he overcomes his fear of the water, that’s the important thing. But didn’t he at least have a towel?”

“Said he forgot, Ziros.”

Dammen gave a snort of amusement, then chuckled aloud. “I don’t know, Jeiel. That sounds a bit strange, doesn’t it?”

Jeiel grinned, too. “Yeah, it does to me, too, Ziros. Especially since I saw Jaada come in about ten micron after Jimmy. She was dressed, yet her hair was soaking wet and dripping down her back.”

The Kaanig’s ears perked up at this. “Well, then. It seems *something* is going on. Only neither want us to know about it just yet.”

“Yay, Ziros. I’ve come to the same conclusion.”

“Well, keep an eye on them. When it seems they are getting their act together, let me know. But I don’t want you to bring it up. Let Jimmy tell us when he’s ready.”

“I understand,” Jeiel said.

“Good. I’ll be in touch.”

Jeiel nodded as the screen went blank. He tapped his fingers on the desk as he considered his orders. Then, raising a wrist to speak into his *d’lab’r*, he contacted his man at base command.

“Kamaya Dinar,” he said into it. “Dammen has ordered me to maximize Jimmy Donaldson’s training. Do you have any of your experts available to help with this?”

“Let me see, Cambra. One moment.”

Jeiel continued tapping his fingers until the man responded.

“Ah, yes, Ziros. It appears there are three right now who can assist with the boy’s training. This vesta anyways.”

“Good. I’ll be bringing Jimmy there to you early tomorrow morning. Have the men waiting.”

“Yes, Cambra. I’ll see to it immediately. Anything we need to have ready?”

“Standard weaponry for now, as a refresher,” Jeiel replied. “Then next vesta, every laser we use, every body shield, every type of ammo...everything, including a ship.”

“By your command, Ziros.”

“Vernier out.”

Satisfied all was in readiness, Jeiel went in search of Jimmy, to tell him about the training. He entered the bake room and asked his people there if they had seen him.

“Why, no, master,” Sajak replied. He and two other servants were sitting at the table, peeling some vegetables for evening repast when he poked his head in.

“Thanks,” Jeiel said. Frowning, he searched the downstairs rooms of the mansion, believing Jimmy might be in the library on the *v'd'mr*. But after a thorough search, he discovered nothing to give evidence that Jimmy had ever been there. He proceeded outdoors to scan the grounds, walking past the pool and into the garden. But he came across neither Jimmy nor Jaada. His curiosity peaked, he reentered Adoniah and headed upstairs, hoping his next guess incorrect.

When he reached the landing, he heard muffled voices and giggling coming from Jaada’s bedchamber. He paused, anger suddenly gripping him as he realized where the two were. He only hoped his thoughts were unfounded and that the two were merely visiting or playing cards or something.

He paused outside the door, listening. But he heard nothing this time, so he hesitantly knocked.

“Jaada,” he said. “It’s Cambra Vernier. Please open the door.”

Sudden scrambling noises came from within, and it was with a look of disappointment that Jeiel greeted Jaada when she opened the door, with nothing except a sheet wrapped about her. He could tell by the guilty flush on her face and the rumpled bed that something *had* been going on.

“C-Cambra,” she said, her tone embarrassed and a bit fearful.

One sweep of the darkened room with his deep chocolate eyes, and Jeiel knew his guess correct.

“Please tell Jimmy I wish to see him. I have new orders.”

“Um, all right, Cambra,” Jaada said, tightening her nervous hold on the sheet. “I will.”

Jeiel left, pausing just outside the closed door to listen to more frantic whispering. Jimmy had apparently not wanted him to know what was going on. Sighing with resignation, he returned to his office, deciding to remain obedient to the Altair’s wish that he wait until Jimmy came forward on his own, to share what was going on between him and Jaada. Hopefully, it wouldn’t take long since it seemed that the two young people were already back into a relationship more intimate than ever before.

Troubled by his discovery, Jeiel returned to the *miÆ* to relay this important information with the Altair, hoping he wouldn’t be as disappointed as he had been.

Chapter Thirty-Five

The sky of Degma was overcast when Jaada Gellon stepped off Jeiel's ship, *Kaljha'me, to* greet her parents, who stood waiting for her by the front gate of the military base there. She sensed their happiness at seeing her after so long, but it did nothing to improve her depressed mood. Forced to leave Adoniah because of Jimmy's busy training schedule, the Altair felt it better if she returned home for now. There was little he could offer her while Jimmy was away.

"The best thing would be for you to return home," Dammen had told her. "Jimmy will be so tired when he comes home at night, he'll have little on his mind except sleep, I can assure you. Don't be angry, just expect little contact with him for several mentas, while he trains."

Jaada was angry, but what could she do about it? After finally becoming Jimmy's in every way except for the official *f'shsta*, she had hoped soon to legally join with him, not be sent back home to live with her parents. But school was back in session now, so she had no choice but to finish her final two mentas at Tendan, without Jimmy, as she had done before. But at least she had her memories of what it had been like to have Jimmy finally make love to her. Loving him as she did, it would be even more difficult now without him nearby. She had hoped he would attend her graduation, but she doubted that would even be possible, considering the complexities of his training schedule.

"Are you all right?" Astar Gellon asked his daughter, noting her sad mien and the dark circles under her eyes. "Haven't you been sleeping well?"

Jaada gave her father a sheepish grin. "I just miss Jimmy, is all. The Altair has him busy training again, so he won't be around for several mentas."

"Oh, is that all," her father laughed, putting a hand to her neck as he walked her to their rallid. "Well, it's something all the imperial warriors must go through. So if you're intent on joining with this young man, then I suggest you get used to it."

Once inside their vehicle, Jaada's mother turned to peer at her sitting in the back seat.

"I've been wanting to ask you, Jaada. Have you decided what you want to do after graduation? Or are you going to mope around the house all summer?"

Jaada gave her a surprised look. "Actually, s'lma, I hadn't even thought about it."

"Jimmy," her father chortled, grinning at his mate as he maneuvered their rallid away from the parking area. "Can't get him out of her head."

"Jaada," her mother said, her tone serious and business-like. "You can't let this...Jimmy Donaldson...dictate how you will spend the rest of your life. Goodness, you're only 17. You must pursue your education, travel, perhaps get a fulfilling job until he decides to make you his life mate. He obviously isn't letting *you* hold him back from what *he* wants to do."

"Oh, 'ma," Jaada said. "I doubt Jimmy had any real choice in the matter. I was there when Cambra Vernier came to tell him of his new orders. So even he had no choice."

"Well," Astar continued, "considering who this boy is, I expect the Altair will keep him under his thumbnail for the rest of his days."

Jaada gave a loud sigh of resignation, knowing his words were true. Jimmy was held accountable to the Altair for everything he did.

"I took the liberty of getting some information for you," Pasana Gellon said. "On schools within the galaxy."

Jaada frowned and stared at the floor. “Thanks, 'ma. I suppose I can at least see what they have to offer.”

“You were interested in teaching at one time, if I recall, Jaada.” Her father peered back at her, his smile broad as he remembered her dreams of long ago. “And robotics and physical dynamics?”

“Yes, s’lpa,” she said.

“Then why don’t you check into one of those as possible majors. Perhaps you can become a teacher. Or get into science or sports or something. You’ve always been so athletic.”

“I’ll think about it,” she promised, her mind still reverting back to Jimmy. *Faith, how could she ever concentrate on school work with him in her thoughts all the time?* Even thinking about him set her pulses racing and her body flaming. She groaned inwardly, wondering how she would be able to bear Jimmy’s absence now, after all they had shared.

* * * *

“*Jeiel!* It’s me again,” came the Altair’s caustic page over his *d’lab’r*, which blasted the audio through the *miÆ*.

“Ziros?”

“Meet me on the landing strip near Travaar. Menakam has shipped Cassia back to Zarak. We need to find her and bring her back.”

“Is she all right?”

“No, which is why we need to find her. I discovered it is *my* child she carries, not Men’s.”

“I’ll be there shortly, Ziros. Let me notify my men regarding Jimmy’s training.”

“*Hurry!* We’ve no time to waste!”

The *miÆ* went blank, leaving Jeiel staring at it in frustration. Maka, every time he turned around, there was some emergency. Frowning, he pushed himself away from the console and stood up. He lifted his *d’lab’r* to share the situation with Kamaya Dinar. For four to six mentas Jimmy would be alone during his training, so his man needed to be aware of what was expected of them both.

Thirty micron later found him aboard the Kaanig’s prized vessel, on his way to Zarak. Neither he nor Dammen had had time to bid farewell to Jimmy Donaldson. So it was with a heavy heart that Jeiel was forced to leave Jimmy in the hands of a complete stranger. He only hoped no problems arose while he was gone because he’d be helpless to deal with them from Zarak, which was light years - *skuayl'a* - away from Valtor.

* * * *

“Here, s’lpa,” Jaada said, shoving a catalog in front of him. “This one. I like this one.”

Astar Gellon took a gander, then pulled forth some eye drops to correct his aging vision, so he could read the information properly.

“Gedefon?” he said aloud. “But that’s in the Gehazi system.”

“Yes, 'pa,” Jaada said. “But it has a great education department and a great sports arena. I thought I could study teaching and sports, all at the same place.”

Astar turned to consider her carefully. “Are you sure you want to go so far away?” he said, giving her a quizzical stare. “You won’t be able to come home for special days or anything. It would cost a fortune to transport you back and forth.”

“I...know, 'pa,” she said. “But none of the schools here offer the best of both worlds. I...I’d really like to check this one out.”

Astar sighed. “Well, if your heart is set on it, then go ahead and apply. We’ll manage it somehow.”

“Oh, thanks, s’lpa,” she said, snatching up the catalog and bouncing away.

Pasana Gellon had overhead their discussion and entered Astar’s den when their daughter had gone.

“Gehazi is light years away from us,” she said, her tone filled with worry. “However will we be able to afford to send her there? Or protect her, for that matter?”

Astar turned to his wife. “Perhaps it's best we send her there. She might be safer there than here. Considering all the problems she’s had, I think it an exceptional choice on her part.”

Pasana moved across the room to sit in a puffy Rhenian armchair. “You would say that. But to not see her for four or five scalons is a bit much, don’t you think? Because you’re right. We’ll never see her again until she graduates and finds her way home.”

Astar grinned at her and then checked to be certain they were alone. Turning, he moved his desk chair closer to where she was sitting.

“Don’t worry,” he said. “Everything’s already been taken care of. Kaanig Altair told me a while ago that he would pay for any school of Jaada’s choice. Anywhere in the galaxy. This won’t cost us anything. I just didn’t want Jaada to know. She might get mad when she learns the Altair is footing the bill for her schooling. So, wherever she wants to go, I’m willing to let her.”

Fear crossed Pasana’s face as she stared at her husband. “Goodness,” she murmured. “Can this really be happening to us? All because of Jimmy Donaldson’s interest in our daughter?”

Astar chuckled aloud. “It would seem so, dear. That our daughter will soon be part of the Altair’s immediate family seems clear to me. So why not accept the perks that go along with it?”

Pasana fell back into her chair in disbelief. “I just don’t believe it. Who would have thought this would ever happen to us? To our lovely daughter?”

“Well I, for one, am not going to refuse a gift such as we’ve been offered by someone like Kaanig Altair. It’s obvious he wants the best for our child as much as we do.”

Pasana grew emotional at this. Swallowing, she made a lousy attempt to hold back the few tears threatening to spill from her eyes. “Oh, Astar,” she said, sniffing as she reached alongside the chair for the tissue box. “How fortunate we are. How grateful. Not only to the Altair but to our Source for allowing us such blessings.”

She was openly crying now, and Astar could only chuckle and take her in his arms. He, too, shared her happiness and wondered how long Kaanig Altair would continue to bestow upon his family the blessings of a lifetime.

Chapter Thirty-Six

It was the worst summer Jaada had ever spent. With Jimmy nowhere around, her solarities had dragged from one boring solarity into another. But she had been forewarned by the Altair that she would hear nothing from Jimmy in all that time, so she couldn't really fault him for not contacting her.

But now it was too late. It had been three mentas since her graduation from Tendan, and she was about to embark on the longest, most exciting journey she'd ever been on. Never had she been to the Gehazi solar system, one of the seven in Valtor. Still, she was sad at thought of leaving her family, although they were supporting her every step of the way. It hadn't taken her long to receive an acceptance notification from Gedefon University via *v'd'mr,* that seemed to have welcomed her with open arms. The people there said she qualified for a discounted exchange program between systems which she knew would make her parents very happy.

But what they weren't happy about just then was the fact that Kaanig Altair was not presently in the galaxy. They had counted on him to conduct her safely to Gehazi. But with him gone, and Cambra Vernier, her parents had no choice but to hire a private company to transport her to school.

"Well, we'll just have to make due with the economy transport service from Del'Qu'A," Pasana Gellon said during their last meal together. "It's the best we can do on such short notice. We hadn't realized that the one time we needed the Altair would be the exact time he would be *skuayl'a* from home."

Jaada reached a hand over to cover her mother's. "I'm sure it will be fine, 'ma," she assured her, squeezing her hand. "I won't be riding in the lap of luxury, but at least this particular service has a good reputation for safety, efficiency, affordability, and dependability. I checked into all that before I mentioned it to you."

"I confirmed it," her father said absently, keeping one ear to the weather scanner on his *v'd'mr* for that particular area of the galaxy. "Hm, sounds like you should have smooth sailing all the way to Gehazi."

"Well, that's good," Pasana said, breathing a sigh of relief. "As if we don't have enough to worry about."

"Oh, 'ma," Jaada said. "I'm sure everything will be fine. Please, don't worry so much."

"I heard they get lots of meteor showers in Gehazi," her brother, Jedido, said offhandedly. "Bet you'll get to see 'em all the time."

Jaada laughed good-naturedly, leaning over to ruffle her brother's hair. "I hope so," she said. "What good would my trip be without a few extra showers to brighten my solarities?"

"You're going to forget all about us," Timson replied, frowning at her. "By the time you return, we'll be all grown up and joined."

"Oh, Tim. I doubt it will be that long. You'll still be able to access me on the *v'd'mr*."

“Yeah,” he pouted, angrily stabbing his vegetables with a sharp eating utensil. “But it won’t be the same as if you were here. Who’s going to help me with my homework now? Or play catch with me?”

“Now, Tim,” their father said. “We’ve been through all that. Your mother and I aren’t going anywhere. Whatever you did with your sister you can do with us now.”

He glowered even more angrily as he rested an elbow on the table, chin in hand. “It still won’t be the same,” he argued, his expression glum.

Jaada fell silent and looked at her two younger brothers, feeling a twinge of sadness at having to leave them like this. But, still. It had to happen at some point. Granted, she hadn’t expected to go so far away from home. But at least she’d be away from the Degmans who had made her life so miserable and difficult. Hopefully, she wouldn’t have the same problems in a different system, in a new school. A university of the caliber of Gedefon was bound to have a choice selection of new friends for her to meet. None of the cliquey groups there, she hoped, such as existed at Tendan, where everyone had grown up together.

“I’ll try and contact you every solarity,” she promised, “so you won’t miss me so much.”

“What if you get sick?” Timson continued. “Or hurt? What if....?”

“Oh, come on, guys,” Jaada said, laughing at their unfounded fears. “Things will be different in Gehazi. You’ll see. The H'San just informed me that they are still under orders to protect me and will be accompanying me there. So what could possibly go wrong?”

* * * *

Jaada sat buckled in the narrow seat aboard the small transport vessel her parents had arranged to take her to Gedefon, with tears streaming down her face. She hadn’t really wanted to go. Not really. But what else was she to have done? Sit around waiting for Jimmy to come rescue her from her boredom? Or get some pointless job around the small town of Tendan, working with more people who would make her life even more miserable than it already was? No, that wasn’t for her. So rather than fall into those ruts, she had decided to get as far away from everyone as possible. But now, as she sat watching her family from the small port hole beside her, she wondered if she had made the right decision. Four scalons *was* a really long time to be away from everyone she loved.

Across from her sat the two H’San that Dammen had initially ordered accompany her to Planet Degma, once she returned from Ulstra. They were then ordered to guard her every move from that point on, until the Altair returned from Zarak and gave them new orders. At least the Kaanig had done that much before he had gone beyond contact range.

She felt the rumbling of the engines beneath her as the craft came to life and began lifting off from the air strip. Unlike the vessels she was used to, those belonging to Kaanig Altair, this ship was much smaller and carried only a few passengers at a time. Today, it was just her and her two bodyguards, who were squeezed uncomfortably into the narrow seats across from her. But she knew that once the ship put to flight, they would be the first to unbuckle their seat belts and free themselves from the restraints.

She managed a tight smile as she waved goodbye to her family through the small port hole. Her last memory of them was of her two brothers waving frantically as they smiled and bounced up and down on their feet as they watched her disappear from sight. Only when they were out of sight did she wipe the tears away. Relaxing back in her seat, she closed her eyes, wishing the nightmare would dissipate as soon as she reopened them. *Please, God, let these scalons pass swiftly for us.*

"Are you all right, pa'atay?" one of the guards asked. When she nodded, so did he, satisfied that all was going accordingly.

"H-How long before we reach the Gehazi system?" she asked.

"Once the facilitation device kicks in, it should only be about four solarities."

She groaned. "That long?"

"I'm afraid so, pa'atay. But considering the distance, it really is quite miraculous that we can travel that far in such a short period of time, with only a few refueling stops."

She nodded in agreement. "Yes. But I'm going to go stir-crazy aboard this tiny ship. The sleeping compartments and refreshment units seem barely big enough for me, much less for you."

The guard snorted a laugh, but made no comment. Instead, he carefully made his way to the front of the ship and stepped into the navigation and control center of the vessel, to talk to the pilot. He reappeared not long afterward, only this time he took an empty seat closer to the back of the ship, propping his feet up on the arm of the seat opposite him. All knew they would need to stretch and walk around at some point, so both men made it a point to get comfortable for the long flight ahead. Taking her cue from them, Jaada unstrapped her own belt and shoved her seat back, intent on taking a nap. At least there was some music being piped into the passenger area, and she had brought some digitexts along to keep her busy. There was a small recreational and gaming area in the back, with some tables, but apparently v'd'mrs were only available in the cockpit area, for pilot use only. Jaada sighed. Four solarities still seemed like an eternity.

* * * *

She must have dozed. When she awoke, the guard sitting across from her immediately rose to get her some refreshment. He moved to the front of the ship and returned a few micron later, carrying a tray of fruit, cheese, and water. He handed the tray to her, then took his seat.

"Always thought they had attendants on these flights," he commented unnecessarily.

"Thank you," she said, grateful for his assistance. Looking up, she pressed a button overhead. A small table instantly lowered from the ceiling, stopping at armrest level. She placed the tray on it and started nibbling, trying not to think about how homesick she already felt. When she had gone to Ulstra, she had known she would be with Jimmy and then return to her family. But now, she wasn't certain when she would see anyone she cared about. At least the imperials with her were familiar. Perhaps they would help her in maintaining her sanity while at Gedefon. Although they would be relieved in two mentas by two more H'San, she knew that just having anyone from home around her was better than nothing.

She turned to peer out the port hole, amazed at the amount of sky and water below. It was growing dark and no land was visible, which was scary. Then as she considered the water spread like a

carpet beneath her, it suddenly occurred to her that something was wrong. She glanced over at her escorts, both of whom were comfortably dozing, then back to the view outside.

"Um," she began, turning to the man on her right, "I think something is wrong, Seryon T'ri'ta. Um, shouldn't we be in orbit by now? Why are we flying over water?"

At the urgency in her tone, both men's eyes popped open. The seryon sat up, coming alert quickly. He peered out his own port hole, and she saw his eyes widen in dismay at this discovery. Both men rose then to check into the matter.

"I'll wait here," the man behind her said, as the seryon hurried to the control area for answers.

But he never came back.

Biting her lip with worry, Jaada peered up at the man standing guard beside her. "Why hasn't he returned yet?" she asked.

"I'm...not sure, pa'atay. I hate leaving you alone to check."

"I think you'd better. How else are you going to find out?"

"Come with me," the man said. "I don't want you alone back here."

"All...right." Setting her tray aside and sending the table back to its source, she rose and moved along with him to the main cabin. With one arm around her, he drew her close as they made their way to the front. He then set her safely away from him, to stand just outside the door. She saw him pull forth and ready his weapon before cautiously sticking his head through the door. And that was his mistake.

The man suddenly straightened and turned around, a look of shock on his face as he fell prostrate at her feet, his body slumping against the seating as he collapsed. Jaada gasped at sight of the flaming hole in his forehead. Trembling in fear, she managed to contain her growing anxiety and step over him. But she never had a chance to go far. An arm suddenly snaked through the door of the cabin. A strong hand caught her arm and dragged her inside.

She resisted and stumbled backwards, giving a squeal of terror at the sight presented her.

On the floor lay the seryon, as dead, she feared, as the other warrior. And gripping her with an evil leer on his face was a man she had hoped never to see again. Di'N Sanada, her former teacher, the coach of the westa team at Tendan.

"Please," she entreated him. "Don't hurt me."

He snickered at the fear in her tone. "What does it matter if I do?" he said, tightening his hold on her. "After what you've done, you're lucky you're still breathing at all."

"What...do you mean?"

"You little *ta'qu*! If it wasn't for you, I'd still have a job."

"What?" she asked, completely confused.

“The Altair had me fired me because of that little incident in the locker room, remember!”

“But, I didn’t do it. Why are you blaming me?”

“You cost me a great job! And then to make matters worse, my life mate left me because of it. Because I couldn’t keep her in the lap of luxury anymore. She took the house, my two boys...*everything!”*

“I’m...so...sorry!”

“Well, little pa’atay righteous. It’s a little too late for that. You’ve walked right into my hands this time, and there ain’t nothin’ the Altair can do about it. Both his mighty warriors are dead, as you shall soon be.”

“*Please. Don’t* do this!”

“The ship’s going to crash, Pa’atay Gellon. *All hands lost! Got it?”* He pushed her back into the passenger compartment, dragging her over top the dead imperial. Shoving her into a seat, he held her there until he had her secured with the rope he pulled from his pant loops.

“Wh-Who’s flying the ship now?” she wanted to know, as she squirmed and struggled to free herself.

“It’s on autopilot. But that’ll end real soon, once I’ve got you strapped in tight.”

“Please....”

“Enough of your pleases. I’m sick of hearing your name every time somebody asks me what happened and how am I doing?”

“But...”

“Shut up! Your life is over, as of now!” He tore off a piece of his shirt and crammed it into her mouth. Then he made sure her hands and feet were secured tightly before he returned to the cockpit to deactivate the autopilot. “Been nice knowing ya, *ta'qu.* But I’m outta here!” With that, he slipped on a canopy chute, thrust open the side door of the vessel, and bailed out.

Chapter Thirty-Seven

It was the start of a new scalon. As far as Kaanig Altair was concerned, it was going to be a good one.

Despite his half-brother's betrayal and failed attempts to oust Dammen from power while he was on Zarak, everything else seemed to be falling into place.

He was happier than he had ever been in his entire life. Menakam had been sent to the Outer Realm, and Cassia and his son, Arian, were finally safe with him at Travaar. How all of that had come about was a story in itself. As it was, the love he felt for them both was greater than anything he could ever have hoped for or imagined.

And then there was Jimmy. A young man after his own heart. A man who was finally coming into his own.

All he needed to do now was to reunite Jimmy with his sister and then with Jaada Gellon. He wanted to get them legally joined and settled on Ulstra, near the refinement plant. For now. Eventually he planned to build them a nice home wherever they wanted.

As he considered what the future held for all of them, he was in his office, digging through his desk drawers for the new monologger he remembered tossing into one of them. As he did, a knock came at his door.

"Come," he said, eventually finding what he was looking for. He slammed the drawer shut and tossed the logger atop his desk as he glanced up at one of his H'San standing in the doorway. "Yes, what is it?"

"We have received peculiar news, Ziros."

"Peculiar? In what way?"

"A missive came through a few solarities ago, Ziros. From Astar Gellon. We didn't think much of it, so decided not to share it with you, knowing how busy you've been the past few mentas. But then, this morning, we received a peculiar message across the *v'd'mr* that was also a bit...odd."

"How so?" Dammen asked, his every sense on alert now, at the strangeness of this news. "Explain."

"Well," the man began, uncertain how to begin. "Astar Gellon contacted us, saying something about not having heard from his daughter since Senta, when she left for school in the Gehazi system?"

"Gehazi? When did this happen?"

The man shrugged. "I'm sorry, Majesty. We do not know the details. But we believe things happened while you were still on Zarak."

“Go on,” Dammen said, feeling the hair on the back of his neck rising.

“Earlier today we received a message from...”

“Yes yes,” snapped the Altair. “Who was it from?”

“From what we could make out, Ziros. It came from...D’Jon’Ni Whitelaw.”

“The valiant of D’joha’Rha?”

“Yes, Majesty.”

“What did he want?”

“He said something about a crash in the ocean of Loranno involving what seems to be a private transport vessel. He wanted you to know that he investigated the matter and believes you may want to check his findings.”

“Why is that? What has this to do with me, if it was a private...”

“Ziros,” the man interrupted. “They found the bodies of two of our men. The two that were ordered to protect Astar Gellon’s daughter.”

At this, Dammen’s mouth dropped as a glacial coldness washed over him. He rose quickly and glared at the man in disbelief.

“You’re certain you heard correctly?”

“Yes, Ziros. We ran the message through three times and verified Whitelaw’s voice patterns. It was him, Ziros. He requests you come to D’joha Rha.”

Dammen went stone still, his thoughts in turmoil as he considered the ramifications of what this information could mean for Jimmy Donaldson’s future.

“Um, thank you, Ch’N,” he said. “You’re dismissed.”

“Ziros,” the man began, “forgive us please for withholding Astar’s earlier message. At the time, we didn’t believe it was all that serious. And with you out of the galax--”

“Don’t worry about it,” Dammen said. “But next time, tell me anyways. Had you told me immediately, we might have been able to prevent whatever seems to have gone wrong.”

“Aye, Majesty. I am sorry.”

When the door had closed behind him, Dammen fell back into his chair to contemplate the matter. All the joy he had felt that day had quickly dissipated with this distressing news. After a moment, he lifted his *d’lab'r* to summon Jeiel. Then, while he waited for him to arrive, he contacted Astar Gellon, wanting an update on the entire situation.

Source help him, but this could be the worst thing to ever happen to Jimmy Donaldson, if what he believed might be true actually was.

* * * *

"She promised her brother she would contact him every day," Astar Gellon was telling Dammen, when Jeiel arrived. The cambra came in to pause beside the desk, listening to the exchange. "But we've heard nothing since Senta, when she left to go to school."

"How come I was never told of Jaada's plans before this?" Dammen asked, puzzled.

"Um, begging your pardon, Ziros. But you were out of the galaxy at the time. We were unable to contact you. As it was, we had to hire a private transport ship to get Jaada to Gedefon before the session started. We just figured we could work out the tuition with you when you returned."

"I'll take care of it," Dammen continued, frowning. "So Jaada left over four mentas ago, and you've heard nothing from her at all."

"No, Ziros," Astar sighed, his tone worried and sad.

"Well, I will investigate the matter and get back to you. Had you contacted me sooner, perhaps we would already have some answers. You did say you contacted the administrators at the university and that they confirmed that Jaada never arrived?"

"Yes," Astar said, trying to contain himself as he considered what this might imply.

"Sit tight," the Kaanig told him. "I'll get back to you as soon as I know something. Altair out."

The *v'd'mr* went blank, and the worry over Jaada Gellon became evident on both men's faces.

"So what now?" Jeiel said in a low voice.

"I don't even want to consider what has happened, Jeiel. But whatever you do, tell Jimmy nothing. If we discover that our worst fears have come to pass, I will have to deal with it. Not you."

"Understood, Ziros." Jeiel closed his eyes, a feeling of dread already washing over him as he, too, considered the fact that Jaada Gellon may, in fact, already be dead.

Dammen lifted his *d'lab'r* yet again.

"Ch'N, notify Whitelaw that I'm on my way. Then contact Kaaniga Altair and inform her that I've been called away on an emergency and that I'm not certain when I'll return." He lowered his arm and peered over at the cambra.

"Accompany me to D'joha Rha, Jeiel. I think I'll need my best man at my side for this one."

Jeiel nodded, half bowing. "I am yours to command, Ziros."

Dammen's expression was grim as he moved past him, extending a hand to give his arm a consoling pat.

"Come on. Let's get this over with."

Chapter Thirty-Eight

"Whitelaw," Kaanig Altair greeted, upon stepping through the *ga'lif* and into the private den of the famous explorer.

"Majesty," said D'Jon'Ni," bowing respectfully to his sovereign. "Cambra."

"Ziros," Jeiel returned.

"So, what do you have for me?" Dammen said, accompanying the Valiant through his personal residence, with Jeiel on his heels.

"I was making my usual rounds," D'Jon'Ni said, as he led the two leaders down the steps from his terrace, then through the busy streets of D'joha Rha, the famous legendary city located over 200 korons below the ocean of Loranno, to a large building two blocks away. "I normally go topside at night, but for some reason I decided to go up a bit earlier. If I hadn't, I never would have witnessed the transport vessel crashing. I was shocked, to say the least."

"How close were you to this?" Dammen asked, waiting as Whitelaw scanned his dicshen pass card to unlock the massive doors, then shoved them open.

"Close enough to see everything," he continued, leading them inside what appeared to be an empty warehouse. "Far enough away to be able to watch safely."

"So, tell me," Dammen directed. "What did you see?"

"I was just up looking around, as I usually do at night. I check for poachers, garbage, that sort of thing. But this. This was something else entirely."

"So? Tell me."

"I saw a ship. It was flying below the clouds. Normally a transport vessel would be in orbit, so I knew something was wrong. I watched it fly overhead. Then I saw a man jump out of it, with a canopy chute – a *nes'ter*. But he didn't have enough altitude to open it. He landed in the water but ended up drowning because he had no flotation device of any kind. No raft. Nothing. I'm assuming he panicked in the heat of the moment and just forgot to bring anything with him. I thought he was alone, but then I saw something odd." Whitelaw continued walking them through the building, out a side door, then along another street, a back alley. He led them a few more blocks until they arrived at an even larger warehouse, where he led them inside.

"The vessel began shuddering and sputtering, as if there was no one at the controls. I watched it a few micron as it lost altitude. Then suddenly I saw this girl, tied to a chair. Although it was getting dark, I could see her outlined against the light of the vessel inside it. She fell out the open door, but somehow the chair got caught. The wind was whipping her about and slamming her against the side of the ship, upside down, until somehow she got loose from the chair and fell into the water. From what I could tell, she had been trying to free herself."

A cold chill washed over both Dammen and Jeiel at this, and they exchanged looks of dismay.

"So, what happened to the girl?" Dammen asked as they paused inside the door of the warehouse, mentally bracing himself for bad news.

"It took me a few micron to grab my gear and go after her," Whitelaw said. "I saw the girl land in the water only sclair before the vessel crashed into the ocean. It broke apart, so there was debris everywhere. I actually almost got hit by some of the flying metal, and I was afraid the girl would be dead when I finally got to her."

Dammen grabbed his arm in a panic and forced D'Jon'Ni to look him in the eye.

"Was she?"

D'Jon'Ni smiled. "I was able to rescue her, Ziros. She was hanging onto some floating debris, but she had swallowed a lot of water and was barely conscious."

"So she is all right then?" Jeiel said.

"Yes," he told both men. "Although I can't say the same for the two imperials I found in the water. Both had been blasted by a plasma gun before the vessel even crashed. I can only assume that the man I saw bailing out had something to do with their deaths."

Dammen and Jeiel sighed with noticeable relief, at mention of Jaada still being alive.

"Take us to the girl," Dammen said.

"She's with my housekeeper," Whitelaw stated. "May I first show you the wreckage and the bodies of the three men? I thought you might want to identify them."

"All right," the Altair said, trying to contain his impatience.

D'Jon'Ni led the men into a very cold area of the warehouse. "I'm sorry, but we had to keep freezing temperatures here until you came to identify the bodies." He hurried to remove the coverings placed over them.

Dammen frowned angrily at sight of the two men he had ordered to watch over Jaada.

"Yes," he confirmed. "These are mine."

"This one here is the man who jumped from the craft, Ziros. Can you identify him? Because of her injuries, I did not want to question Jaada and upset her more. I thought you might have some answers."

Dammen puzzled over the face of the former westa coach, then shook his head. He stepped back so Jeiel could look at him.

"He doesn't look familiar. How about you, Jeiel? Have you seen him before?"

Jeiel also frowned, shaking his dark head. "No, Ziros. I don't know him."

“Strange.” The men stepped back so Whitelaw could replace the coverings. “I’ll incinerate these remains, unless you want to take them back to Konatha with you, Majesty.”

“Just our men,” Dammen said. “They have families who may want to give them a proper burial. But make sure to send some DNA samples to our lab on Konatha so we can confirm the identity of that pilot.”

“Follow me,” the Valiant continued, nodding and leading the men into a warmer, more spacious storage area. Piled everywhere were pieces of the transport vessel. “The name of the owner of this ship is Del’Qu’A. I thought perhaps you could identify the pilot by contacting the company.”

“Yes,” Dammen said. “We’ll do that later.” He moved closer, picking up pieces of the debris, broken glass, and metal stacked into organized piles. “And what did you discover here?”

“A typical crash, Ziros. The only thing strange was the chair the girl was in. She had been tied to it. We found it with the rope still attached. Apparently the chair had been bolted to the floor but had come loose. Probably because of the shaking of the ship when it descended. We figured it had slid across the floor to the open door. Had the girl fallen directly into the ocean, she would have drowned even before I had gotten to her. The Source must have saved her by having that rope catch on the door panel. Eventually, it had loosened enough for the girl to free fall into the water.”

“May we see her now?” Dammen asked, his heart still heavy at thought of her near-death experience.

“Of course, Ziros.”

Whitelaw led the two men back to his house, taking them to a spare bedchamber in the back. At sight of Jaada Gellon sitting in a chair reading, both Dammen and Jeiel gave a happy, grateful sigh of relief.

“*Jaada!*” Dammen cried, overcome with joy at seeing her alive. “Thank the Source you are all right!”

“Majesty!” she returned, jumping to her feet at sight of him. “You found me.” Smiling, she hurried to embrace him until he was willing to release her. When he did, she grinned at Jeiel. “Hello, Cambra.”

“Jaada,” he responded warmly. “It is a pleasure to see you alive and unharmed.”

“Is Jimmy here, too?” she asked anxiously.

“No,” Jeiel said. “He does not know of this incident.”

“Oh,” she said, sounding disappointed. “Well, perhaps that’s a good thing.”

“You’ll be returning with us, Jaada. So if you’ve anything to pack up, get it ready. We’ll return for you in a moment.”

“All right, Majesty,” she said, relieved that someone had finally come for her.

“A word, if you please,” the Altair told Whitelaw. He directed him and Jeiel into an outer room.

“Ziros?”

“Explain why it took you so long to contact me about this?” Dammen said. “The transport vessel crashed in Senta, correct? That was over four mentas ago.”

“Yes, I know, Ziros. And I am sorry. But it took us over a menta to get all of the wreckage and the bodies to D’joha Rha. We had no idea that two of the men were yours until we examined the clothes the men were wearing.”

“And Jaada? You couldn’t have notified me, to ask if we knew of any young girls missing?”

“Actually, Ziros. She was badly injured, and I wasn’t certain she was going to make it. She had been slammed into the transport many times. She had bruises all over her face, head, and body, burns from the rope, that sort of thing. She was unconscious for three solarities, once we brought her here. We had no idea who she was until we found her luggage in Loranno.”

“So you waited for her to get better before contacting me?”

“That and so we could investigate the crash, Ziros. When I finally did send a message, I was told you were out of the galaxy. Later I heard you were on Ulstra. I was never able to get hold of you directly, Ziros. I felt this was something I needed to discuss personally with you and not share with just anyone.”

Dammen considered this a moment. “I see. Well, thank you, D’Jon’Ni. I suppose at the time it seemed the right thing to do.”

“Yes, Ziros,” the man said, giving a half-bow of respect and nodding as he took a step back.

“I am glad it was you who rescued Jaada and not someone else.”

“Um, who exactly is she?” D’Jon’Ni dared ask. “She gave us her name and told us where she had been going when the transport crashed. But that was about it. You seem to know her well.”

“Yes,” Dammen said, exchanging looks with Jeiel who remained quietly aside.

“She is going to be joining soon with my ward, Jimmy Donaldson. His sister is the Zarcon that I joined with, whom I made Kaaniga of Valtor.”

Whitelaw’s expression said it all. “Ziros! If I had known I would have done more to get hold of you. I had no idea she was almost a part of your family.”

“It doesn’t matter,” Dammen said. “You rescued her and helped her recover. What more could I ask from you?”

Whitelaw bit his lip and shrugged in uncertainty.

“I am glad this story had a happy ending for Jaada,” Dammen said. “Thank you for that.”

“Ziros.”

“Jeiel. Let’s go home.”

“By your command, Majesty.”

Relieved beyond measure, Jeiel and Dammen went to get Jaada and take her home.

Chapter Thirty-Nine

"Where the heck is everybody?" Jimmy Donaldson said in a loud voice, hoping someone at base command on Azor would answer him. "Somebody tell me, *please*."

Kamaya Dinar overheard his charge shouting and turned to wait for him. Jimmy was still in his training gear, apparently not wanting to remove it just yet since today was the last official day of his training.

"They have been called away on an emergency," he told Jimmy. "Is there something I can do for you?"

Jimmy felt foolish as he halted before his superior. "Um, sorry. I just thought Dammen or Jeiel would be here on my last solarity is all. Where did they go? What has happened?"

"I'm afraid that that is not for me to say," Kamaya said. "But I am sure they will be back soon. Had they not been called away, I am certain they both would have been here for you."

Jimmy, sulking, nodded and plodded away. He thrust himself into a wheeled chair near the window and peered out at the immense field, covered with battle ships for as far as the eye could see. Resting on an elbow, cheek in hand, he glowered at the sight, fuming over the fact that the two most important men in his life hadn't been there to share in his graduation. Now a full-fledged imperial warrior - *a H'San* - it bugged him that nobody seemed to care that he had sacrificed so much for so long.

He must have fallen asleep because when he next opened his eyes, the sun was setting, creating a bright orange-pink hue along the horizon. He sat up and glanced around. Kamaya Dinar had been relieved by another man, someone he didn't know, so he ignored him. Rising, he made toward the *ga'lif,* intent on returning to Adoniah. He was famished and knew that a hot meal was what he needed just then.

When he exited the *ga'lif* at Adoniah, he stripped and entered the bath chamber for a shower. Twenty micron later, he was dressed and standing in the foyer on his way to the bake room when Jeiel suddenly appeared and descended the stair case, having just arrived through the *ga'lif* himself. At sight of the cambra, Jimmy brightened.

"You're back!"

"Yes," said the cambra, moving to pat him on the shoulder.

"What happened? Why did you leave?"

"I believe Dammen will have to explain that to you. We've only just returned."

"So where is he?"

"He's at Travaar, with Jaada."

Jimmy perked up at this news. “Jaada! Why is she here? Was she supposed to be at my graduation, too?”

Jeiel dropped his gaze at this, shaking his head. Raising his eyes back to his, he put a hand to his arm by way of apology.

“I’m sorry, Jimmy. With all that was going on, it completely slipped our minds about that. I’m so sorry.”

“You forgot?” Jimmy couldn’t believe his ears. Jeiel and Dammen never seemed to forget anything. “How...could you...forget? I’ve been training for mentas. By your command and under your guidance.”

Jeiel sighed, disgusted. “I know,” he said. “But what happened was incredibly important. But you’ll have to wait for Dammen to share the details. Meanwhile, I’m going to get something to eat. Care to join me?”

“I was just on my way, Ziros. I’ve only just arrived from the air base myself. I waited for you guys. For orons.”

Jeiel frowned at this. “I’m sorry, Jimmy. It’s the last thing I had ever wanted to forget. I know how important today was for you.”

“Well, Dammen’s story just better hold some water, or else.”

“Or else what?”

“I dunno. But the story better be damned good, that’s all.”

Jeiel snorted in amusement, then led the new warrior into the dining hall.

“Let’s have a drink by way of celebration, James,” he said, using his formal name.

“I don’t really care to, considering what happened the last time I imbibed.”

“I’m not telling you to get drunk. Just one drink. Something good this time. *T’lia Sh’kur.”*

“Well, all right. But only one, that’s all.”

Jeiel nodded, grinning, glad to learn that Jimmy had no intention of ever getting drunk again. If the boy had learned anything at the mines on Ulstra, it was that he hated drinking.

* * * *

Morning came too soon for Jimmy. It seemed he had barely dropped into bed when Kaanig Altair was paging him to join him in his office for a private conference.

Groaning, Jimmy rolled from the bed Jeiel often used during battle, then made his way into the bath chamber. Fifteen micron later he was seated in Dammen’s office, waiting for him to share with him what had happened the solarity before. He was certain it had something to do with him, but he didn’t know what.

“I’m sorry to call you in here so early, Jim,” Dammen said, “but I’ll be pretty busy the rest of the solarity. Yesterday’s events threw me a curve ball, so now I have to rearrange my schedule in order to get caught up.” He looked over at him, seated anxiously in the chair, as he considered what to tell the boy. “Some mentas ago, Jaada decided to attend a university in the Gehazi system.”

“What?” Jimmy sat up straighter, all ears now. “Why so far away?”

“We haven’t asked Jaada too many questions yet. But hear me out, will you?” Dammen frowned at the interruption, then continued, “While I was on Zarak, a lot of decisions were made that should have been run by me first. But with my own personal problems interfering, there was no way I could be contacted. Because of this, the Gellons decided to hire a private transport ship to take Jaada to the new school so she wouldn’t miss orientation.

“Four mentas later the Gellons contacted me to inform me that Jaada never arrived at the school, which was confirmed by the people there.”

Jimmy couldn’t help it then. “What happened to her?” he demanded, growing worried.

Dammen put up a staying hand. “Just wait. I’m getting to that.” He frowned again, but understood Jimmy’s concern for Jaada’s safety. “I received a message yesterday from D’Jon’Ni Whitelaw, the last Valiant of D’joha Rha. Have you heard of him?”

“Who hasn’t?” Jimmy said.

“Well, Whitelaw informed me of a transport ship that had crashed into the ocean of Loranno. It was the one Jaada was on.”

“Ziros!” Jimmy exploded then, jumping to his feet. “She is all right, isn’t she? Jeiel said she was here.”

“Yes, she is alive, don’t worry,” Dammen said. “But she is still recovering from the crash. Whitelaw saw the crash and managed to rescue her in time. But she got pretty banged up and isn’t quite back to normal yet.”

“What do you mean?”

“She has a fear now that wasn’t there before. Considering what she went through, I believe her psyche was damaged to some extent. I’m only telling you this so you aren’t angry or abrupt with her. It wasn’t her fault, what happened. But what I haven’t told you is that the men guarding her that day were murdered by the man piloting that ship. All three were recovered from the ocean, but only Jaada survived.”

“Who was the pilot?” Jimmy asked, sitting back down.

“That’s just it. We don’t know. I intend to question Jaada later and see if she knows.

“Meanwhile, I want you to refrain from doing your own questioning. Just be there for her. Support her. But don’t yell at her for going off to school a system away. I’m certain she felt it was the right thing to do at the time. Do you understand?”

“Yeah, Ziros. I’ll be good, don’t worry.”

“The man tried to murder her, too, Jimmy. He had her tied to her seat so she couldn’t escape the ship when it went down.”

“What?” Jimmy’s mouth dropped. “Who would have done that?”

“We’ll find out, don’t worry.” Dammen rose from the desk and walked around it to lay a hand on his shoulder. “And I want to apologize for missing your final training day. But I had to find Jaada, to see if she was still alive. I felt that was more important at the time.”

Jimmy was numb. With both hands clamped on the arms of the chair, he stared at the desk top as if in a daze. “I understand, Ziros. Th-Thank you.”

“Right now Jaada is in the garden. Perhaps you could join her for a walk. Feel free to be alone with her, Jimmy. She’ll be your life mate soon enough, once I arrange everything. You’ll need a selection mark of your own, which I am having my craftsmen design. When that's done, you'll have a mark that you can pass down through the generations, as all Valtorians do. Is this acceptable to you?

“Y-Yes, Ziros,” Jimmy said, lifting his gaze to his. A moment later, a smile appeared as he considered Dammen’s words. “Thank you.”

“Off with you then. I know she’s anxious to see you.

When Jimmy had gone, Dammen accessed his *v’d’mr*, to check into the owner of Del’Qu’A Transport, to get a listing of all the employees.

* * * *

Jimmy found Jaada sitting on the ledge of a small fountain that was spraying water from its center, so that is showered down on all sides and into the circle of water below it. She was wearing a short violet top, black leggings and boots, and was leaning over, running her hand through the water.

He felt nervous of a sudden. Clearing his throat, he straightened his clothes before moving closer to face her.

“Jaada,” he said softly. “You look...beautiful.”

At sound of Jimmy’s voice, she turned abruptly and smiled. “Thank you,” she said, pulling back her hand to shake the water off it.

They gazed at each other a moment before he finally stepped forward to take her by the arm and draw her to her feet. Then he embraced her, crushing her against his hard form.

“It’s been so long, Jaada,” he moaned, burying his face against her neck. “You’ll never know how much I’ve missed you.” Drawing away, he scrutinized her face intently. “Dammen told me what happened. I am so glad that you are okay.”

“Me, too.”

“Have your feelings changed for me at all?”

“N-No,” she admitted, lifting a hand to his cheek. “I still want you. More than ever.”

Happy to hear this, he pulled her close and kissed her, his passion for her evident. Her own response was more than he could have hoped for. Molding her body to his, she pressed against him, moaning at the contact.

“I love you, Jimmy. That’s never going to change.”

With a groan, he drew her even more tightly against him. He kissed her again, hard, his longing for her almost more than he could bear.

“I want you,” he murmured against her lips. “I’ll always want you. And need you. And love you.”

Jimmy forced himself away to peer into her face.

“The Altair says we can be joined soon. Once he has a seal designed for me.”

“Really?” she said, her eyes shining with joy at this news.

“Yes. Does this please you?”

“Oh, yes,” she breathed, smoothing a hand up his chest. “I’ve waited so long.”

He chortled. “Yes, I know. Me, too. But as much as I want you, I think we should wait until we are officially and legally joined before we do...you know what...again.”

She pouted. “But, why?”

“I want our first night as man and wife to be special. Can you understand that?”

She shyly ducked her head. “Y-Yes.”

“It won’t be long. I promise.”

“All right.”

With that, he took her hand and strolled with her through the garden, both dreaming of their future together.

Chapter Forty

"The weston coach?" Dammen said with dismay, staring at the report in his hand. "I should have had sense enough to have him investigated after that incident with Jaada at the school. *Maka!* This is all *my* fault."

Jeiel remained silent as he watched his sovereign piece together what had happened to Jaada and the transport ship. That somehow the Altair was to blame for everything had never once occurred to them.

Dammen turned, his frustration evident. "Have my assistant send condolences and five years wages to your men's families," he said. "It's the least I can do for their loss."

"Yes, Ziros," Jeiel said, bowing. "I will see to it."

"You may go now, Jeiel. And thank you." As he spoke, Dammen set aside the report to fold his hands behind his back. He moved to the window, to peer up at the sky. He remained there long after the cambra had departed.

* * * *

Jimmy and Jaada spent an oron in the garden, talking and walking hand-in-hand, stealing kisses whenever the mood struck them. When they came upon the outlook wall, they leaned as one against it, peering down at the city below. After a moment, Jimmy turned to place his back against the wall, catching her hands to draw her close.

"Once we are joined," he began. "I am not sure where we will live. I am not sure if Dammen wants me to return to the mining facility after all that happened there. Would you...mind living there with me...if that is what the Kaanig wants us to do?"

Jaada blinked at this, never actually having given the matter any thought. "Um, I'm not sure," she responded. "I only know that I want to be with you. Wherever that may be."

"What about in the future? If we have children? Will you want them to grow up on a dry, dusty plain, with no gardens or grass for them to play in? And nothing to do really, for fun or entertainment?"

Jaada moved away from him, lifting her elbows to rest atop the wall, as she peered over it. She gave a soft snort, twirling a lock of her hair as she considered this.

"Surely the Altair will not expect us to remain there forever, in those conditions."

"But I am a warrior now, Jaada. A *H'San.* I must go wherever Kaanig Altair sends me."

She ducked her head then, considering this pensively. "I hadn't...thought about that," she said in all honesty, her tone betraying the fear Dammen had warned Jimmy about.

Silence fell between them. Jimmy turned to look back down at Zaratan, remembering what Dammen had told him about her psyche. Perhaps he shouldn't have brought up the matter. But he had to know how she felt. If they were to join, to be life mates, then he wanted her in on the decision-making and choices they had to make for their lives.

"Well," he said after awhile, "we still have time to think about all of this. I just thought I should mention it now, before we do join. I want no secrets or surprises between us. I love you too much to argue with you over something we should have discussed before the joining. As we are doing now."

She glanced over at him then, wrapping her arm about his broad shoulders and leaning against his muscular arm.

"I feel the same way and really am glad you mentioned all these things. I hadn't really thought about any of this, what with everything going on. All I've thought about is you and of how much I love you and want to be with you. I get so worried sometimes, especially after what happened on Ulstra."

He smiled and turned into her arms. He moved a hand to the back of her neck and drew her to him, his lips capturing hers in a kiss more passionate than any they had shared while in the garden. Jaada sighed with contentment, bringing her own arms about him in a possessive way, wanting him to know just how much he belonged to her.

Jimmy gave a grunt in response to her actions and again brought her fully against him, nearly lifting her off her toes as he gripped her buttocks. He kissed her more possessively, with yearning. But as their embrace became more passionate, he again forced himself away, struggling to keep his own lust under control.

"I promised myself," he whispered hotly, against her ear, "to withhold our pleasure until we finally join. We cannot...do...this now."

She stepped back, nodding her own regret at this decision, aching yet understanding. "It is all right," she said. "As much as I want you, I will wait. Having already tasted, I know how much more wonderful things will be if we keep ourselves in check. I know how special that day will be for both of us if we contain ourselves now. Besides, our Source is probably displeased with us already, at what we have done. So yes, I agree. Let's wait."

Breathless with desire for her, Jimmy smiled and reluctantly released her completely, wanting to put a good two crimina between them.

"I hope it is soon though, Jaada. This is so hard for me, I cannot tell you." He turned away with a growl of frustration, listening to her soft laughter as she observed him straightening his togs.

Still laughing, she grinned at him as they turned and walked back to the palace.

Chapter Forty-One

Jimmy was aghast.

"You're kidding, right?" He stared at his sovereign in disbelief and dismay. "You want to split us up now?"

"Why not?" Dammen said, sitting behind his large desk and peering up at the man standing before him with slackened jaw. "You are more than ready for the responsibility. And Jaada will be much better off completing the education she intended prior to her...mishap."

"But Dammen," Jimmy argued. "I still want to marry her. To have her with me. Not light years across the galaxy."

"I understand," Dammen continued. "But I think this is best. For both of you."

"But..."

"*Enough!*" Dammen said, his tone firmly set against any rebuttal of his decision. "You will return to Ulstra to supervise the mining facility there, and Jaada will begin her studies at Gedefon, in the Gehazi system, as *she* planned. Only this time, one of my ships will escort her there and not some fanged transport vessel."

"But, what about..."

"James," the Altair said, sighing in exasperation at the impatience of youth, "this is not meant as a punishment. I merely want the two of you to make certain you are sure of your feelings for one another and to give you both the chance to experience more in life. To join with Jaada before she has had a chance to do anything more with hers, to follow her own dreams, might be detrimental to your future relationship. If after she completes her studies the two of you decide you still want to join, then I will honor that decision."

"But, you promised..."

"I know. I did," Dammen admitted sullenly. He pushed back his chair and stood up to come around beside him then, putting a hand to his back. "And I'm sorry. But, because of what has happened, what you two have suffered, I want to be certain you are doing the right thing between you. To tie Jaada down at some dull mining facility when she could be doing so many other wonderful and useful things with her life just seems a bit cruel. I want both of you to be well-educated, well-rounded, and aware of how things really stand between you."

"I love her," Jimmy said. "How more real is that?"

"There are many kinds of love," Dammen told him. "I want to be sure that yours will endure for a lifetime. Things could well change in the next five scalons, for both of you. Your feelings may change, your aspirations. Do you understand what I am saying? And you must remember that joining in Valtor is permanent and forever, not just some passing fancy. You must be certain that Jaada is the one

you want to spend the rest of your life with, and vice versa." He removed his hand and stepped away. "I know your love is sincere, James. But I want to make certain that Jaada feels as strongly for you as you do for her. As I mentioned, her psyche was damaged and needs time to heal. She needs to be away from any distractions that may prevent that."

Jimmy frowned silently at the shining surface of the polished, wooden desk before him, his lip trembling. "I...understand, Ziros," he said at length. Then sighing, he added softly, "It will be as you say." Having spent most of his teenage life in the Kaanig's care, he knew better than to argue further and knew that Dammen always had his best interests at heart. But again, separation from Jaada was going to be so...damned...hard.

Chapter Forty-Two

"Well well, what have we here?" came an unfamiliar male voice behind Jaada, in the Gefana language, the one most dominant in the Gehazi star system.

She whirled around in surprise, nearly dropping the pile of digiscan texts she had just purchased. She blinked at the rugged fellow in surprise. Tall - much taller than Jimmy - and broad of stature, he wasn't as lean as Jimmy either. But, by Gedefon standards, he was quite striking in appearance, with dark hair and skin, a typical Gedefon wrinkle in his brow and a dimple in his chin. Dressed completely in black, from his tunic to his boots, Jaada couldn't help but widen her eyes as she looked up at him. He was handsome in his own way, and already she noticed how other female attention was focused on his muscular form. When a thick digiscan text suddenly slid from her pile, he was quick to lean forward to catch it before it hit the floor.

"Th-Thank you," she managed, as he placed it neatly atop the others.

"I would have hated to have a new text damaged," he replied. He glanced at the title, a half-smile forming on his thick lips. "And especially one on weston dynamics." He grinned at her then, raking curious eyes up and down her, as if secretly undressing her. "So," he continued. "What is your name, my lovely?"

"Um, Ja...ada." Putting a secure hand atop her pile to prevent further spills, she swallowed nervously and made to escape, only to have him block her.

"I would like to get to know you better...Jaada. Would you care to have afternoon repast with me?"

Jaada cringed, having hoped he wouldn't go in that direction. "I...I really need to get settled in. I have so much to do," she said, making a second attempt to get past him.

"Oh, come now. Surely you have to eat. And I know for a fact you've been in that line awhile. You must be hungry."

Caught off guard, Jaada had no response. She truly did want to get back to her dorm room and get things organized.

"Come on," he urged, putting a way too familiar hand to her back. "Just for a bit. I promise I won't keep you overlong. I've got things to do, too. But I can't let someone as beautiful as you just walk out of my life."

She shrugged, feeling the weight of the heavy texts more than ever.

"Perhaps we'll be in a class together," she said.

He gazed at her a moment, then smirked. "Perhaps. But I'd just as soon get to know you now."

Jaada sighed inwardly, believing she didn't have a choice in the matter, figuring that the sooner she gave in, the sooner she could be away from him. He was good-looking, yes, but it was still Jimmy who invaded her thoughts and dreams.

"All...right," she said, giving in. "But just for a little while. I really do have a lot of things I need to get done today."

"There's my girl," he responded, smirking with satisfaction. Taking her arm, he hurriedly led her away, making no effort to carry her load, although both his hands were free. His own pack was carelessly slung over his shoulder.

"And your name is?" she asked him, giving him a sidelong glance, feeling disgusted with herself for even allowing this to happen. Fear was already gripping her at his possessive attitude toward her. And what was all this 'my girl' stuff? His girl indeed, she snorted silently, trying to free her arm from his grip.

"B'noni S'd'mor. That's me," he said proudly as he steered her down the crowded corridor of the main student congregational building, toward the huge cafeteria where wonderful smells tempted their approaching olfactories. "Maybe you've heard of me. Gehazi degamon champion two scalons running!" Then, "Wait here," he said, directing her to a small corner table, then trundling off without even bothering to ask her what she wanted. Seething inwardly, she dropped her pile of texts onto an extra chair, then plopped back into one of the *Sh'lstr*-made seats to pout.

Maka! Why did she have to meet this guy? Everything was going so well. If she had any sense at all, she should just take off while his back was turned.

Jaada spied B'noni in line by the fish station and grimaced. She wasn't too fond of fish and would rather have preferred some melway fruit and greens. She frowned and peered around the huge eatery. She hadn't had a chance to frequent it before and was a bit curious. When she suddenly spotted the two H'San warriors, one at each entrance, she sighed with relief and relaxed a bit. Thank the Source for them, she thought, nodding at one and smiling her relief at seeing him there. She knew the men were there to keep an eye on her, as usual. But she wasn't about to tell B'noni anything about them and only hoped she would not need their services in future. It was just nice knowing they were there, just in case.

When B'noni returned, he had a tray with a platter of disgusting fish tails, spiky petana roots, and some drinks. Grimacing at his choices, she ducked her head so he wouldn't see how angry she was. When she got her feelings back under control, she glanced up to find him loading her plate with his hands. Shoving it toward her, he took the rest and sat down. She wondered how he had a chance to breathe, the way he started shoving the food into his mouth yet talking nonstop at the same time. She made a feeble attempt at politeness, listening quietly as she swallowed back the nausea she felt as she bit into a fish tail. It was all she could do not to shudder at the foul taste and wondered how they had become such a staple in the Gehazi diet. Even a plate of vegetable-laden mesantine would have been better than this fare.

"Hey, aren't you gonna eat?" her companion said.

She lifted her shoulder and shook her head noncommittally. "I, uh, I guess I'm not all that hungry," she admitted, smidgeoning her tone with kindness.

“Oh, cool. Then do you mind if I finish your share?” he asked, and she wondered all the time if that was what he had in mind from the beginning. The thought struck her that he might be more selfish and self-centered than she had first realized, knowing all along that she probably wouldn’t eat any of what he had picked out for her. That he might be a man of evil motives was a frightening thought just then.

“Um, I really need to go,” she said, watching him leaning over his plate to spit out the annoying spikes from the roots he was eating.

“No no,” he said, reaching out a greasy hand to twine his fingers with hers. “I want to get to know you better.”

“Um, no,” she said. “It’s really not the time.”

His whole demeanor changed then. He glared at her and slammed his fist down on the table. Shocked, Jaada snapped back in her seat, fear gripping her as never before.

“You will do as I say, Jaada,” he spat. “I will walk you back to your room when I am done eating. And not before.”

At this, Jaada glanced over to the H’Sans, shocked to discover them gone. Perhaps it was time for their relief, but of all the fanged times for that to happen. When she needed them most.

She trembled as B’noni continued eating and piercing her with his gaze. It was clear he was not going to let her out of his sight. Near to tears, she dropped her gaze, snatched her hands away, then clasped them together in her lap. Wait. There was nothing to do but wait.

When B’noni was finished, he must have realized he had gone too far.

“I’ll take you back now,” he said as he stood to toss his tray into a waste receptacle. Running a hand across his mouth, he watched her a moment as if considering his words. “Well, grab your fanged digitexts and let’s go!” he said, a bit too loudly. Embarrassed, Jaada glanced around to see who had heard, then stood to hurriedly pile her texts into her arms. B’noni wasted no time after that, grabbing her arm and leading her away.

It was all Jaada could do not to cry.

* * * *

She couldn’t believe the jerk had tried to kiss her. She had tried diverting him from where she actually was staying, but it was no use. The digitexts were weighing her down, and she was getting so tired. She had been up since dawn, trying to get her scheduling done, her things unpacked, her school supplies and digitexts purchased. The imperial cruiser she had arrived in had taken several solarities to reach Gedefon, and that alone was taxing, especially after what she had already been through. By the time she arrived at the university, all she had wanted to do was sleep a good long while, to prepare herself for orientation. But that had been early the previous solarity. The ship had barely arrived on time for her to select and register for her courses, thanks to an unexpected magnetic storm they had encountered upon entering the system. Granted, all had been arranged by the Altair, but some things she was expected to do for herself.

Running into such an overbearing admirer was just too much for her just then. When B'noni walked her back to the dorm, she tried leaving him at the main entrance. But in his typical insistent way, he had forced his company upon her and accompanied her all the way to the third floor. Then, as if a goodbye wasn't good enough, he tried kissing her, as if she had given him that right. Maka! She barely knew him. And what she did already know had already turned her off from him completely. Faith, how she missed Jimmy Donaldson.

Chapter Forty-Three

It was Jaada's first solarity at the Gedefon sports complex, where many of her classes were held, and where sporting events were widespread and popular.

Her first lecture was late in the morning, so she decided on a swim before class.

She left the girl's locker room and dropped her towel on the closest bleacher before heading toward the gigantic pool. The room easily accommodated hundreds of people who often came to the swim meets or other water sports entertainment offered there. Dressed in a skimpy, one-piece Kendran bathing outfit, it was black-and-purple and accentuated all of her curves. As she strolled toward the diving board, she felt the eyes of all the males in the room, who she had observed sitting in a group on the other side of the pool. What she hadn't noticed, however, was B'noni S'd'mor sitting among them. Surrounded by his peers and females pressing against his muscular form, B'noni hadn't seen Jaada until she stepped onto the diving board. At sight of her, he shoved away all the admiring hands and stood up.

"That's my girl!" he shouted to no one in particular, pride in his voice. "Wow, is she beautiful or what!"

At the shout, Jaada froze. Lifting her head in his direction, she spotted B'noni standing with his hands on his hips, watching her like a hungry Zarconian lion. She hesitated, gaping.

Her heart stood still at this unwanted attention. Should she continue on? Or leave the pool area altogether? Faith, was he never going to leave her alone?

"Jaada!" he called, moving towards her.

Fear pounded through her, unraveling her nerves and panicking her. She took a step back on the diving board. As he drew closer, she finally caught herself, took a deep breath, then dashed across the board, diving into the water. It was several micron before she surfaced, being more than halfway across the pool already.

With her head barely out of the water, Jaada turned to peer back at him, pleased to see him standing by the diving board, just watching her. Then, a moment later, he was in the water and coming towards her. His strength gave him an advantage as he swam. Terrified this time, Jaada gasped and began swimming toward the nearest ladder.

But she wasn't fast enough, feeling him grabbing her ankle just as she made to pull herself from the pool. She gasped as he yanked her back into the water.

"Jaada!" B'noni was grinning at her, oblivious to her feelings. "Where are you going?"

"To class!" she spat, trying to shake his hand away.

"Heck, you just got here," he said. "Surely you have more time to spend with me before attendance is taken."

“Get off me!” She shoved him away with her other foot flat against his chest.

“But Jaada,” he cajoled, laughing. He released her, only to grab her arm and pull her closer. She lost her grip on the handrail and instantly found herself up against him. His breath smelled like rancid fish tails, repulsing her, so she turned her head to avoid the kiss he was so intent on giving her. “You know you want me. All the girls do.”

She struggled against him, but her movements only seemed to increase his hold on her. He shoved her back against the side of the pool, heedless of her cries when she banged her head, and began nuzzling her neck. His hand came up to paw at her breasts as he grabbed the outer rim of the wall to secure himself against her. His arousal was clear as he pressed against her, and she was helpless to free herself.

“Stop,” she murmured as he sought out her mouth. Her head flailed back and forth in her efforts to avoid him, but he then brought both his hands to the outer rim of the pool, securing her against the wall with his body. “No...” A weak squeal erupted from her as memories of her earlier abduction came crashing all around her, drawing tears to her eyes. The pool was deep where they were, and B’noni, heedless of anyone watching, continued to hold her against her will as he pulsed against her quivering form, truly believing she was enjoying what he was doing to her.

Suddenly, Jaada heard a loud yelp of pain as he was forcefully extracted from her. His hands instantly released her, to ease his shrieking hair roots, as one of the Altair’s imperials rescued her once again.

Gaping, Jaada looked up to see one of the H’San easily lifting B’noni from the water, with one hand. He was holding him by the hair, with B'noni's toes barely touching the ground. The warrior was taller and more brawny than the student, so there was little B’noni could do to free himself.

The H’San glanced down at her, his entire mien one of controlled rage at what he had witnessed. “Are you all right, pa’atay?”

She swallowed nervously, still shaking. “I am...now. Th-Thank you.”

The H’San nodded before shoving B’noni into the custody of his comrade, who stood waiting nearby. She watched as the man then went to the bleachers to retrieve her towel. Her rescuer tossed it over his shoulder then leaned down, took both of her hands, and easily pulled her from the pool. He brought the towel about her shoulders as she smiled up at him with extreme gratefulness.

“Thank you,” she repeated, sniffing.

“Take him away,” the man told his companion, who easily kept B’noni from escaping. “A few orons in the brig may settle his hormones to a more mature level.” Chuckling, the man dragged B’noni off, amid the shocked whispers of his peers who had observed everything. Surely there was more to this story than what their friend had told them.

“You are all right now, Pa’atay Gellon. Hurry now, or you will be late for your class.”

Jaada nodded and wrapped the towel tighter about her dripping form. She carefully made her way back to the locker room, thanking her Source for saving her from yet another close call.

* * * *

Jimmy's adorable face, tanned and healthy, came smiling at Jaada across the *v'd'mr* two vestas later. Grinning, his whole demeanor brightened her solarity.

"Jaada!" Jimmy exclaimed. "It's so good to see you. I miss you so much!"

Jaada almost started crying. "I miss you, too."

"What's wrong?"

"What...do you mean?" Jaada said.

He shrugged. "I dunno. You just seem different. Not as happy, I guess you could say."

Her lower lip trembled at his perception. "Things are fine," she told him, not wanting to share yet about B'noni, who was quickly becoming a major thorn in her side.

Jimmy gave her a somber stare. "I don't believe you," he said.

"Jimmy, look," she began, averting her gaze and fiddling with something he couldn't see on the desk. "I'm really tired. I was up writing a paper all last night, and I have a big exam in the morning. Now's really not the time for all of this."

Struck by her uncommon rudeness toward him, Jimmy's eyes widened. "Well," he said. "Things are fine here at the plant. We're getting a lot of good product out the door, and the men are starting to appreciate having me around. I...just wanted you to know."

"That's good," Jaada said, her tone flat.

Jimmy sighed, stunned by her uncharacteristic behavior. "Well then. I guess I'll talk to you later. Just know that I love you. Signing off."

He paused as if hoping she would say something more, but she didn't. So with that, the screen went blank. And only then did Jaada allow herself the tears that had been threatening ever since his handsome face had appeared on her monitor. Burying her head in her arms atop the desk, she cried herself dry, wishing she could have told Jimmy what was really happening. But since he seemed so happy, she didn't want to share her depression or homesickness. Missing him was harder than she ever thought it would be. But she didn't want him dashing to her rescue the moment he heard about B'noni. She knew the H'San were ever vigilant, yet even they couldn't be everywhere, at all times. She wanted to get through her time at Gedefon without any problems, other than those normally associated with higher education.

She had been so excited about school until B'noni had interfered. And here she had thought all such problems were behind her once leaving Degma. Now, she walked around in fear every solarity, afraid of seeing him again, especially after the punishment the H'Sans had imposed on him. So worried about running into him again, it distracted her from her school work.

Sighing, she rose from the desk, readied for bed, then fell into it, eager for sleep to overtake her. One...two...three mentas...she mentally counted, hoping for the holidays to arrive soon so she could have a few solarities of peace while the natives went home to their families. Since she was so far away

from hers, she didn’t have that option and mentally planned all she would do while classes were suspended. Fortunately, the H’Sans would be there with her, so she wouldn’t be completely alone. Just sad...and homesick.

Chapter Forty-Four

The dormitory drones came through the hallways three times every solarity, checking to make sure the students residing there were behaving themselves and following Gedefon rules. Metal, rounded, with three antennae and three legs, the drones buzzed through the air with a dull, pulsing sound that radiated throughout the vicinity. Anyone caught violating the rules was severely reprimanded and fined, so the students learned quickly how to do what they wanted, without getting caught.

It was solarity one of the holiday break for *Kla'afan*, the 150th anniversary celebration of when the Gehazi system had become an official part of the Valtorian Empire. It had been a positive merger that had improved and prospered each of the twelve planets it contained. Prior to the Altairian conquest, Gehazi had been in chaos and was faltering due to poor leadership at the highest level. But that all changed once Kaanig Altair, Dammen's great-great-grandfather had taken control. Similar instances had happened throughout other systems in the galaxy.

Only a handful of students remained behind in each of the nine dormitories on the Gedefon campus, their circumstances being similar to Jaada's. Like Jaada, most planned to catch up on their reading or take advantage of the peace and quiet afforded them to finally get some well-needed rest. Despite the consistent routines of the drones each solarity, many were still able to host wild parties or do other prohibited things, so long as lookouts kept a wary eye out for the drones when they came through. Fortunately, they were as regular as clockwork, so it was easy to pull off things that violated nearly every dorm rule, even when many students were gone for the holiday.

Jaada had no interest in celebrating something that didn't concern her. Her life had been chaotic at times, her roots confused because of her father's constant transfers throughout the empire. She preferred to focus on that which did concern her, and right now that meant her school work.

It was already nearly eight beohsa, well after evening repast. Yet, Jaada could hear the vibrations of loud music blasting down the corridor from a room at the far end of the building.

Intent on finishing a term paper early, she had decided to take full advantage of all the time allowed her since the school would be shut down for at least four vestas. Deep in concentration as she entered data into her *v'd'mr*, the device that helped locate and scan in information from all corners of the galaxy, compiling her research, she was unaware at first of someone knocking at her door.

"You there," came a female voice, the pounding harder. "I know you're in there. Open up."

Jaada snapped to attention, jerking her head upright as she pulled herself away from the *v'd'mr* and dropped her writing tool.

"Oh, um...just a sclair," she said, marking her page as she rose to open the door.

"B'yana," greeted the girl standing in the corridor. "I'm Zhala. I hope you don't mind, but I saw your light on. I thought that since we're obviously both alone for *Kla'afon* that we could spend some time together. When we're not busy with our school work," she added blithely, peering past Jaada, at the pile of work on her desk.

Jaada bit her lower lip, considering the idea. “Well, I don’t see why not,” she said. “I’m actually pretty ahead of myself and just thought it’d be good to get a head start on some things.”

Zhala grinned at her, her scaled forehead creasing even more. “I think we could be great friends,” she said, glancing about the room with curiosity. “I see we are both interested in the same things.”

Jaada stepped back to allow her in, noting where her attention lay. Zhala walked across the room to consider the large, framed picture on the wall, of one of the most popular musical groups in the galaxy.

“You are a fan of the Stellar group?” Jaada asked, her own interest piqued as she watched her. “I used to live on Kenra when my father was stationed there and actually attended a few of their concerts.”

Zhala brightened and moved closer to the picture. “For real?” she said in disbelief. Then, “Wow. It’s autographed! You’ve actually met them?”

“Yes,” Jaada confirmed, as Zhala whirled to face her. “Long enough to get them to sign that.”

“Wow. That is so cool.” Zhala stared about her, at all the other knick knacks and pictures. “Say,” she continued. “Would you be interested in taking a walk and getting out of here for a spell? It’s really nice out, but it’s getting dark. I don’t care to go out alone and thought you might join me.”

“I suppose I should get out and get some fresh air. I’ve been cooped up here ever since everyone went home.” She moved to turn off the *v’d’mr* and some lights, then snatched an outer jacket, in case it got cooler. “I’m Jaada, by the way,” she said.

“That’s a nice name. Jaada.” She preceded her new friend out the door and waited for her to lock it behind her.

“I’d actually like to get some hot merida,” Jaada said. “If you are up to it. And perhaps a snack. I...didn’t eat much earlier. I just wanted to get some work done while it was still peaceful around here.”

Zhala shrugged. “Heck, we’ve still got nearly a menta before everybody returns. You’ve plenty of time to get everything done.” She turned to Jaada. “You’re not going home at all for *Kla’afon*?”

“No,” she said. “I’m not native to this system and may not go home at all until graduation.”

Zhala gasped. “Seriously? Why not? Where are you from?”

“Well, right now, my family is permanently settled on Degma. We’ve always lived in the Kathian system.”

“Isn’t that where Kaanig Altair resides?”

“Yes,” Jaada answered. “But he lives on Konatha, which is three planets away from Degma.”

“Ah,” Zhala said, understanding. “Still, it’d be cool to live so close to him.”

“Why’s that?”

Zhala giggled. “Well, he’s so gorgeous and all.”

“I’d have to agree,” Jaada said, laughing.

“I’ve always had a crush on him. What Valtorian girl hasn’t?”

But Jaada fell silent then, thinking of Jimmy. She couldn’t recall ever having a schoolgirl crush on the Kaanig but knew many girls that did. He had been the most eligible bachelor in all the galaxy...and the richest...for as long as she could remember.

“Hey,” Zhala said, taking her arm and steering her out of the building, in the direction of the nearest eatery. “Let’s go see who else is still on campus. Maybe we can form a little group for when we’re left behind for other holidays. We can do things together maybe.”

“Sounds like a good idea,” Jaada said, trying hard now to focus on her companion’s words. With Jimmy-on-the-brain again, it was difficult to think of anything else. “By the way,” she continued. “Why haven’t *you* gone home for break?”

Zhala jerked her head around, as if surprised by the question. “Um, actually, I don’t get along with my mother all that well. I thought it would be best to just stay away.”

“But won’t your father be upset?”

“Nah,” she countered. “He passed away when I was a scalon old. My mother hasn’t been dealing with it very well ever since that happened. I’m just a lousy reminder of happier days. She said she’d do better if I never came home at all.”

Jaada was shocked but empathetic. “I’m so sorry, Zhala. That must have hurt a lot.” She thought of how close she was to her own family, of how much her parents loved her. She could never imagine having them say such a thing to her.

“Yeah, well,” Zhala responded, her tone flat and defensive, “things happen. You just have to learn to cope in your own way.” As she spoke, she motioned Jaada across the street, to a local eatery that sat on the corner. A place called *R’atas*. So crowded, people were hanging about the entrance and milling around both sides of it, on the walk and in the cobbled street.

“Well, it looks like not everybody went home for break,” Jaada said, following Zhala inside as those blocking the door parted to allow them through. Many of the repast centers at Gedefon were closed, so they thought it better to stroll into the nearest village, Spilia, to try their luck there. Secretly, Jaada hoped she wouldn't run into B'noni S’d’mor, so kept a wary out out for him, ready to flee at first glimpse.

Once inside, the two girls were amazed there were so many people. Several familiar faces greeted them, but there were also many villagers around their own age, with few adults in sight. Seemed everyone had the same idea, so finding a table was a bit difficult until Zhala spotted some people she knew. Four male classmates waved them over and offered to share their table, a rectangular booth with green padded seats. With no other options, it was their best one.

Two of the patrons gladly gave up their seats to them, then hurried away to steal more chairs to place at the end of the table. Despite her discomfort at the idea, Jaada soon found herself squeezed in

between two rather husky classmates, from one of her education classes, she realized. One was rather rugged and dark, the other lighter skinned with longer, lighter hair, and wart-like growths on his face, signifying his Galerion nationality, from a planet on the far side of the Gehazi system. Zhala found herself sitting at the end opposite them, near a rather good-looking fellow, slim, who seemed to have eyes only for Jaada. Tall and broad-shouldered, he smiled a greeting at her, when Zhala introduced her to the group.

It seemed Zhala knew a lot of people, whereas Jaada hardly knew anyone, except by sight. Intent on getting good grades, graduating, and making it home to Jimmy, she hadn't made much of an effort at making friends since arriving at Gedefon. Especially after the incident with B'noni. He had sparked a fear in her that made her keep her distance from nearly everyone around her. If Zhala hadn't come knocking on her door, she knew she would still be hunkered down in her room, getting her paper finished. One blessing in disguise was that the Altair had arranged for her to have a private dorm room, which made it easier for her to avoid problems with other students. Leaving it posed risks she hadn't even expected until she had met S'd'mor.

It wasn't long before the girls had drinks in front of them. It wasn't exactly what they had been hoping for but, since the boys were treating, they found it difficult to refuse. For all intents and purposes, *R'atas* was more of a saloon than an eatery, and Jaada wished she had known that before entering the building. The signs outside made no mention of alcohol being served inside, but obviously everybody else knew about it.

"Ew, what is this stuff?" Jaada asked, crinkling her nose at the awful taste. "Tastes like sewer water."

At this, everyone guffawed at her remark, insisting it was a harmless drink that she would soon get used to, although Jaada wasn't convinced. Zhala, she noticed, seemed to inhale the swill like it was the greatest thing on the planet. And it became obvious the boys were trying to get them both drunk because as soon as Zhala had finished one drink, another miraculously appeared in front of her. By the third one, she was already slurring her words and displaying an uncommon lack of control. Jaada sensed Zhala as being somewhat shy, as she was, but the drinks made her much more flamboyant, loud, and flirtatious.

"Come on!" Zhala shouted across the din of the music and loud conversation, grabbing the lapel of the cute boy beside her, the one who kept his focus on Jaada. "Dance with me!" Shrugging, he grinned at Jaada, and rose to accommodate his companion, watching Zhala swaying dizzily toward the dance floor.

Disappointed at how her evening had turned out, Jaada frowned down into her glass. She really did want a cup of merida. It would have helped relax her. But now, it appeared she had to keep an eye on her inebriated friend so no one took advantage of her. Sighing, she lifted her head to peer around the crowded room, watching the people dancing, conversing with each other, laughing drunkenly, and swaying to the music. The two beside her were quiet, apparently waiting for her to finish her drink so they could buy her another, but she wasn't having any of it. Glancing over, she observed their disgruntled expressions and wondered what they had been hoping for when she had sat down between them. When she suddenly saw Zhala in a liplock with her dance partner, and the ways his hands were roaming freely over her body, she realized now what it was they wanted from her.

Suddenly, she was on her feet, murmuring her apologies to her companions. "I'm sorry," she blurted. "I must get back. I'm expecting a call from home." She had to wait until the chunky fellow

sitting to her right rose up to allow her out of the booth. “But th-thank you for the drink,” she said, pushing her way past him toward the dance floor. When she reached Zhala, she was quick to come between her and the one groping her. “Come on,” she said, aware of how flustered and lost Zhala was at this point. “We have to go.”

But Zhala’s partner was having none of it. “Now wait a minute,” he said, obviously perturbed. “Where do you think you’re going? You can’t just come in here, accept our drinks, then leave...just like that!”

“Watch me,” Jaada said, tugging Zhala after her.

“You’re not going anywhere,” the fellow spat at her, furious at having his plans ruined. He hurried after the two girls, apparently intending to carry out his plans once they made it outside. Jaada ignored him, kept her hand firmly on Zhala, and shoved her way to the exit and out of the building, only to run smack into an imperial warrior hovering there, waiting for her. She gaped at him gratefully, then quickly stepped aside, pulling Zhala with her, as the H’San waited to greet the one hounding them.

When he came out, Jaada saw his eyes widen in disbelief as he found his way blocked. Every attempt he made to get past the imperial was halted. But Jaada didn’t wait around to hear what was being said. She merely tossed Zhala’s short jacket about her shoulders and hastened to get her back to the dorm. A glance back revealed a second H’San who was silently shadowing them, making sure they made it there safely.

It wasn’t until after Jaada had taken Zhala to her own room, with the H’San’s help, that she was able to return to her own, shut, and lock the door behind her. Only then did she cease her fearful trembling over what might have happened had she finished the drink given her. Crumpling to the floor, with her back against the door, she released the tears that had been threatening and wondered if she would ever be able to leave her room safely for the next three or four scalons, other than to go to classes or other school events.

“Oh, Jimmy,” she whispered, resting her head against her knees. “I miss you so much.”

Chapter Forty-Five

Dammen sat glaring at his desktop as he listened to the report his H'San had sent Jeiel from Gehazi. Things were not going at all as he had hoped.

"Thank you," he told Jeiel, sighing. "You may go."

"Ziros." The cambra bowed and departed, leaving Dammen stewing in his chair over this latest incident with Jaada Gellon. He rose and abruptly shoved his chair back, to peer out the window behind him. He knew Jaada and knew she was not responsible for what had been happening. His men had reported her exemplary behavior since arriving at Gedefon. She appeared to be doing everything right, to experience those things she desired. Unfortunately, it seemed that her uncommon beauty was what attracted trouble from the opposite sex. Here he was trying to keep her focus on learning, only to have his plans corrupted by those who couldn't control their raging hormones and evil desires. *Maka!*

His door com sounded, drawing his attention. "Enter!" he growled, turning to greet the young man standing in the open doorway.

"You wished to see me, Ziros?"

Dammen ran a weary hand through his thick mane and sat down. "Yes, Jimmy," he said, indicating a chair. "Have a seat.

"Is something wrong?" Jimmy asked, obeying and eyeing his sovereign with some trepidation.

Dammen sighed and pursed his lips. "Yes, Jimmy. I'm afraid there is. It's Jaada."

At the name, Jimmy stiffened, almost jumping from his seat. "Is she all right?"

Dammen leaned back in his seat to eye the younger man with uncertainty. "I'm not exactly sure how to go about this," he said. "But yes, she is fine. So far. Although there have been some unexpected incidents on Gedefon I had not expected." He watched the worry draping across Jimmy's face at this news.

"What has happened?"

Dammen sighed again and stared down at his desk. Anything to draw his attention from the fearful look in Jimmy's wide, blue eyes.

"I know you are aware of my reasons for sending her there," he began, finally meeting his gaze. "But again, she appears to be drawing unwanted attention from members of the opposite sex. Dangerous attention, it would seem."

"Dangerous, Ziros? In what way? You said she was all right."

"Yes, James. She is, thanks to my vigilant H'San I sent to keep an eye on her."

"Then, what is the problem?" Jimmy straightened in his seat, his fingers clenching the armrests.

“It appears someone has been trying to possess her, through manipulative and controlling ways. My men rescued her both times, but I am afraid it may be difficult in future for them to always be there for her, especially if she is in the dorm rooms or other places on campus. I told them not to draw attention to themselves so Jaada could have a normal life there, but I think their presence may not be enough. Anyone can attack her, while in her room, or elsewhere. The H’San cannot be everywhere all the time.”

“So, what are you saying?” Dammen saw Jimmy’s eyes shining with unshed tears, at thought of his beloved being hurt in any way, and it bothered him greatly. Despite his own abilities, he was still unable to keep Jaada from harm.

“I am considering two or three options at this point,” Dammen continued. “One, I go to Gedefon, to halt whatever is going on there. Two, I send you to intervene and establish your claim to Jaada. Or three, we bring her home for awhile. She may be able to continue her learning at a school closer to Travaar. Or we can find a distance learning or computerized way for her to complete her education here.”

Jimmy dropped his head, considering these things. Dammen lapsed into silence, waiting for his response.

“Please, Ziros,” he began after a moment. “Send me. We can get someone to take over my job at the plant until I return, can’t we?”

Dammen nodded his agreement. “I was hoping you would choose that option, James,” he said. “We can expedite things by sending you through the *ga’lif*. This matter is too important for you to waste more time in space.”

Jimmy nodded and rose up expectantly. “How soon should I leave, Ziros?”

Dammen leaned back and entwined his fingers across his belly, his mien serious now. “Now, if you’d like, James. The sooner the better, I’d say. According to my men, Jaada has been keeping herself barricaded in her dorm room, rarely leaving it except to eat, attend classes, or do assignments at the digitext library. To keep her confined for the next four or five years was never my intention. She is too young and needs freedom to enjoy her life.” He pushed his chair back and rose up to peer down at Jimmy. “I don’t want her living in fear, James. I am hoping you will change all that. And if your presence works out, perhaps I will allow you to visit her more often than not at all.”

“Aye, Majesty. I understand.”

“Off with you then.” He reached for a paper on his desk, then handed it to him. “Here is where you can find her. And her course schedule. On the back is a map of the campus. The time difference is twelve orons ahead of us, so keep that in mind. I know you don't know Gefana, the dominant language there, but Kathian is universal, so you shouldn't have any problem conversing with anyone there. And keep me abreast of what is happening. If we need to take a different course of action, then I need to be aware of it.”

Jimmy nodded, giving a half-bow of obeisance. “Thank you, Ziros. I’ll keep in touch.”

* * * *

Jimmy stepped through the *ga'lif*, arriving ten micron later on the Planet Gedefon, just a stone's throw away from the university Jaada was attending. It was around 6:00 a.m. there, Gedefon time. Many dorm windows appeared dark, yet lights were seen in many of the other buildings, where classes were held. Figuring that Jaada was still sleeping and would go to the student food arena to break her morning fast, Jimmy chose to go in that direction, hoping to run into her there. He didn't want to frighten her first thing in the morning and figured he could find an out-of-the-way table facing the entryway, and nurse a hot drink while waiting for her to arrive. His main intention at this point was to just observe and see what was going on, hoping she wouldn't see him right away. Briefly, he wondered if stalking was illegal in Gedefon, but he didn't really care. Dammen could always override any trouble he got himself into. He already knew that Dammen had alerted the authorities and security people at the campus to his intentions there, just as a precaution.

As he entered the student converse area, he paused just outside the arena to look around, only to suddenly have someone barge past him like an Ulstran mining hauler, knocking him out of the way. Straightening, Jimmy glared at the fellow who didn't even bother to apologize. Shaking his head, Jimmy decided to move out of the line of collision and sit down. Parking at a small table hidden behind a small-leafed menkea tree, he sat down and observed the area. Time and again his attention was drawn to the oaf who had sided him earlier without remorse. It appeared the student was a jock and a bully and had no respect for anyone, especially females. He saw him palm a young woman's breast as he walked past her, only to have her gasp in embarrassment and clutch herself in pain. No apology there either, Jimmy noticed. Only smug laughter as he sauntered over to a food counter. Frowning, Jimmy shook his head at the scene, before turning his attention back to the main entrance.

He waited over an oron before catching sight of Jaada. She slunk into the food court, peering every which way as if hoping to avoid someone. Once satisfied she was safe, she hurried toward the food counters, grabbed some fruit and a hot beverage, ran her payment card through the scanner, then made her way from the arena. Drat.

Jimmy immediately got up and left, following her from a distance. She was hurrying down the hallway, only to turn off into another room. He peered through the door window, spying her settling herself into a large, comfortable chair. Setting her food aside, she drew open her pack, pulled out a text, and proceeded to do some reading. Snorting softly, Jimmy stepped back as others moved past him and into the room. But since Jaada seemed fine, he made his way outside, to stand guard outside the huge window of the room she was in. He had noticed the H'San coming down the hallway and knew they were going to stand in the hallway until she departed. Having been alerted to his presence on campus, Jimmy was aware they already knew he was there...somewhere. At present, he didn't think it necessary to speak with them just yet. Too hungry for any sight of Jaada, she was all he cared about just then.

When Jaada departed her study area a few orons later, Jimmy was careful to wait until the H'San passed before trailing their lead. So far so good. Jaada was okay and had encountered no untoward behavior from anyone as yet. He only hoped things would stay that way.

That afternoon, it wasn't until Jaada was making her way across the campus, to the sports complex, that B'noni appeared at her side. Having spent several orons in the imperial brig several vestas earlier, he was none too happy at the reasons for his incarceration. He knew it was because of Jaada the H'San had snagged him, and he wasn't about to let her get away with it. He'd only been waiting to get her alone.

"Hey!" he snarled, coming up behind her with a vengeance. "Why are the Kaanig's men hanging around you? Did you see what they did to me?"

Jimmy, from where he stood, saw the terror leaping across Jaada's face at B'noni's appearance, and she tried freeing herself from his grasp.

"Leave me be!" she snapped. "I'll be late for class."

"So what?" B'noni gripped her arm and was steering her off in another direction, to a copse of thick trees that was well off the beaten path. "You and me have a score to settle."

"No!" Jaada struggled against him, trying to free herself. But he was too strong. So in the end, she resigned herself to her fate. Jimmy had heard every word between them and was instantly riled by the scene. He made to step into the fray, until he saw the H'Sans coming to her rescue. Within a matter of micron, they had freed Jaada from the bully's grasp, threatening him with further confinement if he touched her again. Furious, he stomped off, cursing aloud at this second run-in with the imperials.

At least Jimmy now knew who had been attacking Jaada and was thankful the H'San had been there to stop it this time as well. He watched as the imperials escorted Jaada to her class at the sports complex, secure once more under their protection. Still, Dammen was right. They couldn't always be there to protect or help her. But he could. He could guard the areas the H'San would not go, like the dormitories. Younger, Jimmy could easily masquerade as a student and frequent areas these H'Sans did not care to venture into. They knew their presence might cause Jaada even more problems, for any number of reasons.

* * * *

Jaada was a nervous wreck. Sitting slumped in her seat, chin in hand, she vaguely heard the lecture, the professor's boring monotone barely registering in her ears. Her course on weston dynamics was usually her favorite, other than the sport itself, but after her confrontation with B'noni, she could barely focus on anything but her fear.

When her class ended, she plodded down the hallway, to the exit, conscious of the H'Sans mutely following. She was glad they were there, but felt guilty, too. No one else on campus had imperial warriors dogging their footsteps, and she hated that she had been forced to accept their protection. Believing her life would change once leaving Degma, she had no idea how much things would actually turn for the worse. Now she felt like a prisoner in her own room, allowed only out for meals and classes.

Blinking sadly, she dragged herself back to the dorm, bleakly thinking how dull her life was and would apparently always be. Another night in solitude was not something she cared to think about just then. It was depressing and, lately, it seemed there was nothing she could do to pull herself out of her doldrums. Even thoughts of Jimmy held no sway at the moment. In fact, she had been avoiding his calls altogether. She did not want him to see how dismal her life had become.

As she entered the building and made her way to the third floor, she felt as if the life had been sucked out of her. A nap and a hot shower was all she had to look forward to just then, and she was barely aware of anything going on around her. As she reached her room, she pulled her bag open to search for her pass card, only to hear a squeal of excitement from down the hall. Looking up, she saw her friend, Zhala, grinning broadly and hurrying toward her.

"Jaada!"

“What’s going on?” Jaada gave her a weak smile of greeting, as she ran her dicshen through the scanner, opening the door. Still grinning, Zhala hastened her inside the room, then closed the door firmly behind them. “What is it?”

“You’ll never believe it,” Zhala said. “There’s some gorgeous guy on campus, a Zarcon. Nobody’s ever seen one of those before, and all the girls are raving about him.”

“A Zarcon?” Jaada blinked at this.

“Yes. You know. A being from that place called Zarak. We’ve heard about them, but no one has ever seen one. Until now.”

“Where is he? Have you seen him?”

“Not sure. And no, I haven’t been that lucky. But word has it he was wandering around a few of the buildings earlier. We think he’s trying to decide on attending here. All the girls are wild with anticipation. I heard he was gorgeous. All muscles and everything. And he dresses like a H’San.”

Jaada tossed her bag on the bed and sat down in disbelief. “I’ve met a Zarcon. Back on Konatha.”

“Really? Well, why didn’t you say anything before?” Zhala stood over her, arms flailing with excitement. “What was he like?”

Feeling guilty at not wanting to share more about Jimmy, Jaada ducked her head. “Um, quite nice, actually.”

“Where did you meet him?”

“At one of my schools,” she admitted.

“Wow. What was he doing there? I thought the Kaanig only brought women back from Zarak, to join with his men. There was never any mention made of men or boys being brought here to Valtor.”

“Um...I really don’t know, Zhala. Truly.”

“Well, at any rate. There’s apparently one here now. If I see him, I’ll come and get you. I know you’ll want to see him. Perhaps he’s the one you met before.”

Jaada looked up and gave a tremulous smile, hoping. “Perhaps.”

Zhala let out another squeal, hugged Jaada, then got up and scampered out the door. As Jaada stared after her, she wondered what all the fuss was about over one Zarcon. As she thought of Jimmy, she wondered if it was him they were all drooling over, or someone else. Ah well. No matter, she decided, as she got up to secure her door. Then, shoving her bag onto the floor, she dropped onto the bed for a nap, too depressed to care about anything or anyone just then.

Chapter Forty-Six

It was nearly ten beohsa dae Gehazi time when Jimmy came to stand outside Jaada's door. He knew she had retired early, and he intended to stand watch until morning. The H'San were guarding the two main entrances and had secured the side doors so no one could get into the building from there. Having finally alerted them to his presence, he told them of his plans to keep an eye on Jaada in the areas they weren't able to go. Nodding at the wisdom of this plan, they seemed almost relieved that he was there. If something happened to Jaada they couldn't prevent, they knew Kaanig Altair would be furious. Now, with Jimmy there, the odds against that happening had increased tremendously.

Come morning, without incident, Jimmy hightailed it out of the dorm, standing just around a corner of the building to await Jaada. She had awakened early for it was barely seven when she exited the building, greeted the H'San, and made toward the food arena. Just as she made to leave the food court, however, B'noni, apparently on the look out for her, came charging past her like a bull cow, knocking the plate of fruit and hot beverage all over her. Giving a yelp of pain, she stood gaping at the mess, paralyzed with fear. Jimmy, as well as the H'San, had witnessed this cruel attack, knowing it had been deliberate.

Jimmy remained discreetly off to one side, hands on hips, watching as the imperials hurried toward her, to escort her back to the dorm. His heart felt for Jaada, knowing how a similar attack had occurred at the school in Zaratan.

He nodded as the H'San passed, having already informed them of his intent to deal with B'noni himself, if anything else happened to Jaada. Fortunately, she hadn't spotted him yet, which was just how he wanted it.

He stood watching the behemoth, now seated at a table full of fawning girls, who were laughing at Jaada's mishap. B'noni was smirking and nodding at their vicious comments, not letting on that he still considered Jaada his woman.

But Jimmy decided to wait. He wanted to catch B'noni with Jaada, just so he could beat the tar out of him and stake his claim. Publicly, so there would be no further doubt as to who Jaada rightfully belonged to.

Chapter Forty-Seven

Jimmy roused himself from sleep, groaned, and turned over. The digiscan read six beohsa. Plenty of time to shower and dress and return through the *ga'lif* to monitor Jaada's comings and goings.

The other H'Sans, he had learned, were relieved every six orons, so he made sure the relief were aware of what was going on. All four men had accompanied Jaada from Degma so that two H'Sans were always keeping an eye on her.

At night, when Jimmy returned to Travaar, he informed Dammen of what was happening. So far, the Altair had approved of his handling of the situation with Jaada but wanted him to hurry things along. Dammen had deliberately postponed some meetings on Vaalstra and Kenra so he could be available for the few solarities Jimmy would be in Gehazi. Just in case it became necessary for him to step in.

Jaada only had one class this solarity, so Jimmy planned to have the H'Sans keep an eye on her that morning while he kept an eye on the lout who kept harassing her. He had already discovered which dormitory he stayed in, which floor, and which room, should he have to confront the student there. Then he had gone to the admissions office and, by using Dammen's authority, obtained all the information he needed on B'noni S'd'mor, an all-star athlete with the crude manners of a Vultronian trundel beast. His grades indicated his low level of intelligence and disinterest in academia as a whole. He had only made it to Gedefon through a sports scholarship. Figured.

Jimmy frowned at the *v'd'mr*, double checking the information he had been given privilege to. It seemed that S'd'mor also had a history of violence, especially toward women. His mother had apparently died at the hands of his alcoholic father, who was now cooling his heels at Tango, a place of correctional confinement feared throughout the galaxy. He had been given a life term, having been spared disintegration for the sake of the boy, an only child.

"Well, that explains a lot," Jimmy muttered, snapping the *v'd'mr* closed. Of all people for Jaada to have come across, it had to be him.

* * * *

Jimmy was standing outside the robotics division of the university. Jaada had a keen interest in science and was hoping a few elective courses in robotic development and nano-engineering might help round out her teaching skills. So he waited for her class to end. At sight of the hulking forms of the H'San moving toward the main doors, Jimmy scooted to the side of the building, hiding behind some tall bushes, hoping Jaada wouldn't notice him when she came out.

Once outside, several other students were milling about, moving past her and the H'Sans as they went about their business. Used to the imperials now, few paid them much attention. It seemed only Jaada was annoyed by their presence.

She turned to them. "I, um, have some projects to work on, so I'll be heading to the tek-lab in a bit. I just need to return to my room to get what I need."

The two warriors nodded, mutely following her back to the dorm, two buildings away. Meanwhile, glad to have overheard that, Jimmy hurried off to the sports complex to find B'noni. He wanted to trail him from his degamon practice, to see where he went afterward. If B'noni was intent on seeking out Jaada, then Jimmy fully intended to be there for her.

It was a ten micron jog to the complex. Enjoying the exercise, Jimmy ran past several small groups of students coming and going from there. At one point, as he jogged past a group of females, they giggled at sight of him. Not wanting him to escape their curiosity, one shouted out to him. "Hey, wait up!" Curious, he paused to look back at them, then halted altogether.

"Ladies?" he said perfunctorily, in Kathian. "Is there something I can do for you?" As he spoke, he lifted his hands to his hips then cast a glance at the sports complex, hoping to catch sight of B'noni exiting the building.

Giggling even louder, in a more noticeably flirtatious way, the girls surrounded him.

"We've noticed you on campus the past few solarities," one greeted him, also in Kathian, reaching a bold hand out to touch his well-muscled chest, as if she had the right. "Are you a student here?"

Jimmy's lip curled slightly, aware of their real motives. "Um, actually, no," he said, politely removing her hand. "But I have a friend who is."

"Oh," gushed another girl, rather pretty, but in a snobbish sort of way. "Do you know a lot of people here?"

He chuckled, then glanced over at the stair well of the sports complex, three-quarters of a koron away. A smile creased his lips at sight of B'noni finally exiting the building and skipping down the steps to the walkway. It wasn't hard to mistake his oaf-like form, even from a distance. "Actually, no," he said.

"Well," said one of the girls, crinkling her crinkled forehead at him. "You know us now." She stuck out a hand. "I'm Cl'rom'a. That's B'ssa. And the short one is Nes."

"Ladies," Jimmy nodded politely, trying to figure out a way to free himself from their fawning attention. Then he started backing away. "I'm sorry, but I really must--"

"Oh, surely you can at least tell us your name."

"And why you're here," Nes interjected quickly, moving to block him.

The girls didn't hesitate then. They all had their hands on him, rubbing his chest again and squeezing his biceps.

"Um, the name's Jimmy Donaldson. I'm from Zarak originally. And...my reasons for being here are actually...none of your business."

"Jimmy!" they gushed. "Surely you can tell us. We won't tell anyone. Promise!"

But he tried easing away again, removed their hands, and took a step back. Unfortunately, the timing could not have been worse. He backed directly into B'noni's path. Furious at this, B'noni gave

him a nasty shove, which nearly sent him sprawling into the grass. The three girls gasped at this effrontery, hurrying to help him. But he quickly recovered, straightening to glare at B'noni's departing back as he hurried down the walk. Jimmy could hear his mocking laughter at this episode. And again, no remorse or apology.

"Excuse me, ladies," Jimmy said, silently appreciating what had just happened, if only to free himself from the girls. With that, he took off after B'noni, pacing himself so the bully wouldn't suspect he was actually following him. B'noni glanced back and smirked at Jimmy, but kept his rapid pace. Right into the tek-lab, apparently aware that Jaada planned to be there that solarity. Jimmy snorted knowingly, thinking how well things had played out. What he hadn't counted on, however, was having the three girls follow him. *Maka!*

Once inside the lab, Jimmy halted to survey his surroundings. *V'd'mrs* were lined up along three walls, with several in a square in the center of the room. A large reception desk was before him, in front of the entrance, with a room monitor sitting there, who glanced up curiously at Jimmy's entrance. Other high-tech computers rested behind him, which another lab monitor was fiddling with.

"Can I help you?" the one sitting asked him, in Gefana.

"Uh, no," Jimmy said again, in Kathian, having guessed at the interpretation of his words. He gave a little wave and headed off to the left, behind him, to a large, sunny alcove extension. "I'm just going to sit over here. I'm waiting for someone."

"All right. No problem. But if you need help with anything, let us know." It seemed that most knew the Kathian dialect at Gedefon, as Dammen had told him, and for which Jimmy was very grateful.

Jimmy smiled. "Will do." As he made to sit at the last *v'd'mr* in the farthest corner, he peered over at B'noni, who had already stationed himself at the back of the room, on the far side opposite the alcove. Still smirking, he gave Jimmy a little wave of victory before concentrating on his own computer. Although his back was to Jimmy, the young warrior observed B'noni's occasional glance back at him and, more frequently, at the front door, clearly expecting someone.

Jaada hadn't arrived yet, but Jimmy, from where he sat, had a clear view of the walk outside, which led to the entrance steps. There were also huge glass windows, with long, wheat-colored drapes in the corner where he sat. He could easily spy her coming and prayed she wouldn't see him there.

It was about twenty micron before he finally spotted her strolling toward the building, shadowed by the H'Sans. As did B'noni, who quickly turned back to his work, pretending he hadn't noticed. Jimmy snorted and shook his head before rising to sidle against the wall, hiding himself from Jaada's view. Fortunately, when she came in, minus the H'San who remained outside, she merely greeted the room monitors, signed in, then moved to the right side of the room. Absorbed in some papers in her hand, she barely glanced at the other nine people in the lab. Choosing a *v'd'mr* along a wall opposite Jimmy's position, across from the monitors' section, she sat down and dropped her bag beside her. Too intent on her purpose there, she quickly focused on the computer and work at hand. She leaned down to open and retrieve something from her bag, all the while being watched by both men.

She appeared distracted, Jimmy thought, because she kept returning to her bag for things. When she finally straightened in her seat and settled in to work, he saw her jump in her seat when B'noni suddenly plopped himself down at the *v'd'mr* next to her.

“B’yana!” Jimmy heard him say, as he leaned closer to rub her neck. Jaada scrunched up her neck to shrug him away, but he whispered something in her ear that apparently shocked her. She shot to her feet and stumbled backwards, trying to avoid him. “Oh, come on!” B’noni continued loudly, sarcastically, drawing everyone else’s attention. “Why not? You gotta eat! What does it matter where?”

“You keep using that same lame excuse,” Jaada reminded him, as she nervously rubbed her arms. She was wearing a long-sleeved, white, tekwan sweater, dark, slimming pants and tall black boots, which Jimmy thought looked exceptional on her just then, particularly with her dark skin and ebony hair. “Just go away and leave me alone. I’ve work to do.” Anxious, she bent to retrieve her bag and started shoving her things inside it.

“Excuse me,” one of the monitors said, coming over. “Is there a problem here? Do you need some help, pa’atay?”

“I...y-yes...”

“*No!”* B’noni blasted at the fellow, giving him a rough shove. Being tall and slender gave the monitor no advantage against the well-seasoned athlete. “She’s staying here with me.”

“*No! I’m not!”* Jaada was emphatic. She turned to leave, only to find her way suddenly blocked by a welcome, familiar figure. Looking up, her eyes widened and her mouth fell open. “*Jimmy!”* she gasped, paralyzed with overwhelming relief at sight of him.

“Hey,” B’noni said, rudely edging his way between them. “*Get away* from my woman!”

Jimmy lifted an eyebrow, his lip curling slightly. “*Your* woman?”

“Yeah. I saw her first. She’s mine.”

The warrior laughed at this one. He peered past him to question the girl now standing behind the oaf.

“Is this true, Jaada? You belong to him?” He took a step closer and gave B’noni a powerful shove. “Or to me?”

B’noni stumbled backward, almost colliding with Jaada who was quick to move out of the way.

“What do you mean?” he said, suspicious. He glanced from one to the other.

This time, it was Jimmy who smirked at him. “Jaada Gellon is *my* woman. Mine, understand? From the first moment I saw her, she’s been mine. Isn’t that right, Jaada?”

All eyes in the room turned to Jaada, who was trembling with both fear and the joy of seeing Jimmy Donaldson in the flesh. There, at Gedefon.

The girls who had followed Jimmy into the tek-lab were as shocked by this as B’noni was. They had stood outside a long while, wondering whether to follow Jimmy into the building or wait until he came back out. Having only just entered, it was just in time to overhear the unexpected exchange between the Zarcon and B'noni. They stood by the entrance, jaws now slackened in disappointment.

Jaada gulped and nodded her confirmation at Jimmy's question. All B'noni could do was stare in disbelief at the Zarcon, wondering who he was exactly.

Jimmy walked past him and collected Jaada's things. "Is this something that can wait?" he asked softly. "Or is it a pressing assignment?"

Still wide-eyed and gaping at his unexpected presence there, Jaada blinked away her happy tears. "I-It...can wait," she said.

"Good." He took her arm then, keeping her protectively against him as he led her past all the gaping mouths and outside. The other girls parted to either side of the door as they left, allowing them through, amid stunned silence and startled expressions. Silently, they followed the couple, watching with something akin to envy on their faces as Jimmy waved dismissively at the attending H'San and then led Jaada away until they were out of sight.

Once away from the lab and nosy people, Jimmy pulled Jaada around the corner of the nearest building. Then he drew her behind a tall bush and into his arms, where he kissed her possessively and passionately for a good...long...time.

Chapter Forty-Eight

B’noni S’d’mor was dumbfounded by what had just happened. Gaping at Jaada as she left with the blond-haired Zarconian freak, he stomped back across the room to gather his things. He wasn’t going to just stand by and watch the love of his life go off with someone else. She needed a big, strong protector. Him.

He plowed through the door, startling the girls who had witnessed the incident. They were now standing outside at the bottom of the steps. They stepped aside quickly, at the rage in B'noni's overall demeanor, as he barged past them.

“Outta the way, *ta'qus!*” he spat unnecessarily. Then he turned back, pausing to ask them which way the couple had gone. When they nervously pointed in the direction, he whipped around and started running that way, without even thanking them. Unsettled by the whole affair, the girls quietly departed to their own affairs, aware that Jimmy was clearly off the market and really wasn’t worth chasing anymore, much to their mutual disappointment.

* * * *

It was two solarities before S’d’mor saw Jaada again. Jimmy had insisted she skip her classes until everything blew over. Seeing the wisdom in this advice, she agreed. Jimmy accompanied her to the offices of her professors to help her explain the situation. They were all glad to accommodate any friend of the Altair and granted Jaada the short leave she requested. They also informed her that they would be glad to give her a shorter version of any lectures she might miss, once she returned and things settled down in her personal life.

Jaada couldn’t have been happier. Just having Jimmy with her for two whole solarities was sheer heaven. Unfortunately, both knew it wouldn’t last, so they made the most of the time they had together. Even the H’Sans were pleased with the arrangement since it gave them a few solarities to go through the *ga’lif*, to spend time with their own families. The ship they had arrived in was safely secured at the nearest air base, where they spent most of their free time.

Jimmy wanted to make his last evening at Gedefon extra special, so he walked into the village with Jaada, to find a good place to eat.

“How about that place?” he asked, pointing to *R’atas*. “Do you know if it’s any good? Seems to be hopping.”

“Um, well, I’m not sure about the food,” she said, then described in some detail her experience there. Jimmy scowled upon hearing this sorry tale, hoping that B’noni was the only problem he had to contend with while at Gedefon. Otherwise, he would have to stay there longer than expected.

“Well, then,” he said, “let’s keep walking. Maybe we can get a recommendation from an older person we come across. Hopefully a local.”

It wasn’t long before they happened upon a middle-aged woman coming from a local gift shop, with two children in tow.

“Oh, yes,” she exclaimed, happy to have such a handsome, polite young man ask her advice. “Just a block over, to the right, there is a place that serves wonderful meals. Very reasonable, too. I think you’ll enjoy it.”

“Thank you kindly,” Jimmy said, flashing her his award-winning smile. He observed the flush that swept across her cheeks, then took Jaada’s hand and led her in that direction. “Sounds good to me.”

“Me, too,” Jaada said. “I’m really hungry.”

The woman hadn’t exaggerated about the place called Sestenes. It was a fancy place, but they were quickly shown to a private booth, once it was learned who Jimmy was. “Any H’San is more than welcome here, ziros,” they were told, as they were swiftly ushered to a large, private booth. It was still early enough, so there weren’t too many patrons, and they were given specialized service besides.

“Any preferences?” Jim asked Jaada, who was excitedly skimming through the lengthy list of food items.

“All of it!” she giggled. He chuckled and took her hand beneath the table, squeezing it.

“It does look pretty good. I’m glad they have menus in different languages,” he said, “or I wouldn’t know what to get. Order anything you want.”

* * * *

The next oron and a half was spent sampling some of the favorite local cuisine, recommended by the owner of Sestenes, who came by to welcome them. They also took his recommendations on which of the beverages and desserts on hand were fit for the Kaanig himself. By the time they were finished eating, not only had they made a few new friends, but they were ready to roll all the way back to the dormitory.

“That was fun,” Jaada said, as they strolled hand-in-hand along the main thoroughfare. The ground was wet from the late winter rain, and aromas of certain foods and petrichor filled the air. As they neared *R’atas*, they could see the crowd of students milling about and hear the loud music blaring from within. “I’m glad we didn’t go in there.”

“It would have been too noisy,” Jimmy agreed. “I’m glad we listened to that woman. She didn’t steer us wrong, that’s for sure. We’ll have to remember to go back the next time I come and see you.”

Jaada nodded. “I would like that.” She lifted her hand, still entwined with Jimmy’s, and kissed his knuckles. “I so love you. You treat me so good.”

The young H’San looked down at her, then stopped in his tracks. Not caring who was about, he turned to her, drawing her closer. She peered up at him, nervously meeting his gaze, and smiled.

“I love you, too, Jaada. I always will.” He softly knuckled her chin and lowered his mouth to hers, giving her the lightest of kisses.

“*Get your hands off her, you freak!* You *f'ber!*”

At this, they instantly parted and turned, not all that surprised to see B'noni S'd'mor and several of his team mates glaring at them. They had just happened to be on their way into *R'atas* when they spied the couple walking toward them.

"Oh, great," Jimmy murmured. "Just what we need to round off a pleasant day otherwise. Next time, remind me to take a different route home."

B'noni, emboldened by his buddies flanking him, stormed over and got up into Jimmy's face.

"What the *fi'ara* are you doin' here anyways, Zarcon? Why don't you go back where you belong?"

Jimmy's expression turned stony. "And where might that be?" he asked.

"Jimmy..." Jaada said, intervening. "Let's just go. Ignore him."

B'noni shot her a miffed look. "Stay out of this! *I'll* be walking you home tonight."

"The heck you will!"

Jimmy could see Jaada's nostrils flaring angrily at this, so he took her gently aside, to calm her.

"Jaada, please. Just wait over there. Things could get ugly."

"Oh, all right," she acceded stubbornly, her tone conveying the fact that she really didn't want to leave him. But she did as he asked, moving to stand closer to the building, in a doorway that still gave her a good view of what was happening.

Meanwhile, Jimmy had turned to face his nemesis. Clearly, B'noni hadn't wanted to believe the truth about his relationship with Jaada. It rankled him, the fact that the bully had found him right after he had enjoyed such a great meal, one that was already making him feel tired and relaxed. Too relaxed for a fight, if it came to that.

"That woman is mine," B'noni insisted, so close now that he managed to spray spittle onto Jimmy's face. "So leave her be. I don't want you anywhere near her from now on."

Jimmy snorted. "You really are deranged," he said, wiping his face. "Just like your father."

Of course, that was the wrong thing to say to someone like S'd'mor.

B'noni blustered in rage at his remark, and Jimmy swore later that he had actually seen smoke coming from all of his orifices. Then, as anticipated, B'noni laid into him like a charging Zarconian rhinoceros, managing to clip his ear instead of his face. Jimmy was a bit slow just then, but not slow enough to dodge the punch coming his way.

"Is that all you've got?" he said, chortling at B'noni's upset as he rubbed his stinging ear. Having missed his intended mark, B'noni went off balance, landing on one foot. Putting a hand to his knee, he pushed himself upright. He scowled darkly, his expression showing his fury at having missed Jimmy's face.

"*Bas'jit*!" B'noni bellowed at him, charging him again. "*F'ber!*"

But Jimmy easily stepped aside, avoiding the ramming position.

"Bastard? Freak?" Jimmy said. "I can assure you, I'm no bastard. I had two respectable parents. But why do you consider me a freak?"

"'Cause you're an outworlder! No one in Valtor has hair like that. Or eyes. Or such light skin. You're a *f'ber*!"

"Does that mean you're afraid of me then?"

But B'noni refused to answer that one. Instead, his fist shot out with all his might. But again, Jimmy managed to avoid the assault.

Furious, B'noni moved away to recover and consider his next strategy. He turned to his comrades, for counsel, then unexpectedly whirled back. With a flick of his wrists, he directed the two friends closest to him to come at Jimmy from both sides.

Shocked when they grabbed him, Jimmy wasn't expecting the two athletes to be as strong as they were. They held his arms firmly, laughing loudly when B'noni punched Jimmy in the bread basket, knocking the breath from him. He bent double at the impact, a retching cough erupting from him. An immediate second punch brought him to his knees, where he vomited his recent dinner onto the roadway. He heard Jaada gasp at this, yet knew she would not dare help him. He knew she had never seen him so humiliated and probably had no desire to make him feel worse than he already did.

* * * *

Satisfied at the Zarcon's heaving episode, B'noni's two cronies released him and walked away, snickering. B'noni stood with his hands on his hips, a smug look on his face. He gave a haughty laugh at sight of Jimmy puking on the ground, in front of the whole establishment that had hurried outside to watch the fight. Still grinning, he glanced over at Jaada, who was fearfully hugging the corner of the building. He gave Jimmy another look, making sure he was down for the count, then made toward Jaada.

"Don't worry. He won't be able to hurt you anymore."

"What?" Jaada couldn't believe her ears. "He...has never...hurt me. What are you saying?"

He gripped her arm possessively and began dragging her away. "You're my woman and always will be. Don't ever forget it."

She tried to free herself, struggling against his strength, panicking at thought of his real intentions, when Jimmy's familiar voice intruded upon them.

"Let her go," he said, with deadly calm. Turning, B'noni saw Jimmy wiping his mouth and straightening with sheer intent.

"Some people never learn, do they?" B'noni responded. Releasing Jaada, he turned back to the Zarcon. "Ready for another lesson?"

Jimmy's eyes narrowed dangerously as he moved toward them.

“I think it is you who needs a lesson,” he said. “You actually did me a favor. So whatever is about to happen is all because of you.”

B’noni just stared at him. “Huh? What’s that supposed to mean?”

But Jimmy just grinned and motioned toward Jaada to stand out of the way. Even she knew what was coming and hurried to the security of the doorway. B’noni’s mouth dropped in confusion, his eyes following Jaada as she moved away. His cronies took a step back, leaving B’noni out in front of them, to face the Zarcon alone, until they felt their help was needed again.

Then, before B’noni even realized what was happening, Jimmy had whipped around and kicked him in the jaw, knocking him backwards. Stunned, B’noni put a hand to his bleeding mouth. Seeing the blood on his hand, a flood of rage darkened his spirit. He righted himself, then motioned his cronies to stand down. At Jimmy’s attack, they had instantly jumped forward to defend their friend.

“No. This *bas'jit* is mine,” he growled. Settling into a retaliatory pose, he raised his fists, glaring at the Zarcon. Then, as he made to punch him, Jimmy thrust himself away with a wide, backward flip. Gaping, B’noni then stared overhead as Jimmy repeated the move. Except this time he moved toward him, up and over him, landing in the center of him and his team mates.

In a matter of sclair, Jimmy had knocked them all to their knees as he whirled around, his booted foot connecting with their jaws. In a matter of sclair, and with a few well laid punches, he had them all down completely. Once they were incapacitated, he stared down at B’noni, who was staring around him in disbelief. It was in a painful daze that he still managed to stumble to his feet. “What in the...?”

But Jimmy gave him no time to consider his next move. In the twinkling of an eye, his fist shot out to smash B'noni in the face over and over again until he was lying bewildered on the cement, right where Jimmy wanted him, with his foot secured on his neck.

“Had enough, tough guy?” But when B’noni refused to answer, Jimmy increased the pressure. “What was that you said?” He sensed his victim’s embarrassment, especially in front of his friends and, after a glance around, it seemed the entire patronage of *R’atas.* Everyone was standing outside the door in awed curiosity and amazement at what they had just witnessed. No one had ever seen anyone move that fast before.

“Now,” Jimmy continued, making sure everyone was listening, “hear me well.” He paused for dramatic effect, glancing around again at the crowd. “Jaada Gellon is mine and always has been. We are to be joined once she graduates, and I do not want you anywhere near her for the rest of her time here. Understand? In fact, stay away from her for the rest of her life. If I see you near her or even get an inkling that you have done something to her or made trouble for her, I will be back to finish what I started. Is that clear?” He peered down at B’noni, lying still on the walk, his darkly ruddy face more red than usual. He struggled to rise, but Jimmy held him firmly in place.

“Well?” he demanded.

“Y-Yes,” B’noni rasped, his tone one of defeat and humiliation.

“Very well then.” Jimmy released his foot, then turned to B’noni’s team mates. “And that includes the rest of you. Stay away from my woman. Or else.” So saying, he made toward Jaada who was standing nervously, proudly in the doorway. Without a word, he took her hand and led her away,

toward her dorm. Jaada snagged his arm securely, more closely, as they walked through the crowd, past a sulking, humble B'noni. She glanced back as the group parted, allowing them through.

Not one made a move toward either of them again, and they kept their comments to themselves until well after the couple were out of sight.

Chapter Forty-Nine

"Well done," Kaanig Altair said when Jimmy Donaldson returned to Travaar several solarities later. "Now that you have staked your claim, I'm hoping we can return things to normal. My men will alert me to any more problems with Jaada. But hopefully it won't be necessary."

"I hung around a few extra solarities, just to make sure nothing would happen."

"It's possible that S'd'mor either learned his lesson or was just waiting for you to leave," Dammen said. "I intend to keep Jaada well guarded, but I want you to return every few vestas to check on her. Considering who we are dealing with, this young man may be making plans, even as we speak."

"Yeah. I thought so, too," Jimmy agreed. "Only I hope not. Jaada deserves some peace after all this time."

"As things stand now, I must be off," Dammen told him, rising to load his travel size *miÆ* and *v'd'mr* into a large black case. Snapping it shut, he made to leave. "I'll expect you back at work in the morning, James. If anything untoward happens, you will be contacted. After I leave Kenra, I'll be on Garit in the Ta sysem for the next few vestas, if you need me."

Jimmy nodded. "I understand, Ziros. And thanks for your help."

Dammen paused at the door. "I'll always do my best to be there for you, James," he said solemnly, staring intently at him. "Never forget that."

"Yes, Ziros. I won't." Jimmy smiled, watching as the man he loved most in the world departed. As he considered how his life would be without the Altair in it, he followed, praying that neither of them would have to be called back to help Jaada.

Chapter Fifty

B'noni S'd'mor, sorely disgruntled by his latest upset with Jimmy Donaldson, sat stewing on a bench in the student square, idly noting the many students walking about. Leaning over, with chin in hand, he puzzled over Jaada's importance to the Altair. The security of H'San around her had doubled since her boyfriend's departure. He was going to find out just who that fellow was if it took him until graduation, which was at least two scalons away yet. A complete education past the secondary schools, by Gedefon standards, took at least four to six scalons.

Two of his friends were leaning on either side of the bench, a third sitting beside him, playing with his *v'd'mr*.

"So what do you intend to do?" Palas asked him, the one beside him. "How are you going to track down her special friend? Find out who he is?"

"Not sure," B'noni muttered, suddenly straightening in his seat as Jaada Gellon happened by with her quaternion. He glared at her as she slunk past, and Palas lifted his head to watch the small group. Only one H'San turned his head to look at him, raising a dark brow as if in dare. But B'noni and his friends refrained from voicing aloud their thoughts or moving anywhere near them. At least until after Jaada and her guards were well out of hearing range.

"Maka," B'noni growled. "I still want some of that. She's too luscious to pass up. And I don't care who she's involved with."

At this, Palas put a hand to his shoulder. "Careful," he cautioned. "That guy made it clear he doesn't want anyone near her. Why obsess with her? There are plenty of other pretty girls here."

B'noni shrugged his hand away and rose from the bench. Turning, he faced his three friends. "I don't care. I want her. Ever since I first saw her. And besides, I didn't see a mark of selection in her wrist yet. That means she's still up for grabs, as far as I'm concerned."

"Oh, come on," K'nonn blurted. "You're going to get yourself into all kinds of trouble. Why not put her behind you? Find someone else. Or buckle down with your school work? You know the profs didn't like your grades last term, and you're close to losing your scholarship."

"Quiet, 'Nonn! That ain't none of your affair."

K'nonn just shook his head with disgust, aware he was fighting a losing battle.

"Well," began the fourth fellow, a student from the Fr'on'tla system named B'tas'l. He shoved his notes back into his bag and started off. "All I know is that that guy kicked your butt fair and square. And quite thoroughly, I might add. I'd be careful, if I were you. You don't know what nest of *usalens* you're stirring up."

B'noni, not wanting to hear any more sound advice, threw up his hands, washing it all away. "Look! I don't want to hear anymore. Just leave me be. I've gotta get to class."

His friends, much wiser than he, collected their things and made off to their own classes, not one wanting to get involved with anything B'noni was apparently planning. One brush with Donaldson had been enough for them to want to stay away from him.

"You're stubborn," Palas commented, rising to move past him. "Wasn't one day in the H'San brig enough for you?" He snorted and shook his head. "Catch ya later."

"Yeah," B'noni said. "Maybe."

He stared at his friends' retreating backs, then slung his pack over his shoulder to move in the opposite direction.

"Your day's coming *f'ber,*" he muttered. "Just you wait."

Chapter Fifty-One

It was spring again. The birds were singing, and the smell of budding plants and trees was a welcome change from the gloomy gray skies of winter on Gedefon. It never snowed there, but it was depressing just the same. Jaada shoved open the window of her dorm room, to allow some fresh air in. She inhaled the scent of the mashalia tree just outside. Closing her eyes, she smelled its sweet aroma and smiled with pleasure. Soon it would be blooming its deep purple blossoms, which attracted many birds, who chirped happily for solarities on end as they thrived on the tree's small white berries.

Jaada opened her eyes, imagining what that would be like. As she peered out the window, her thoughts turned to daydreams of Jimmy. Of wishing he could be there with her, to walk in the sunshine on such a beautiful solarity. A scalon had passed since his scuffle with B'noni, and B'noni hadn't bothered her since. Thanks perhaps to the continual H'San presence as well. Although that didn't mean he never would. She saw him watching her every chance he got, although drooling over her seemed closer to the truth. He made her nervous and self-conscious, despite the added protection of H'San warriors with her. Secretly, she believed he was up to something. Something which didn't bode well for her, or maybe even for Jimmy. She kept her suspicions to herself because she just wasn't sure. Although B'noni hadn't done anything or even spoken to her for an entire scalon, that didn't mean he wouldn't.

Jimmy had been fairly consistent in coming to see her every few vestas or so, to check on her. Whenever he was able to get away. It helped with her homesickness more than anything, although she still missed her family. She tried contacting them as often as she could, when school affairs didn't get in the way. Even now she couldn't believe how big her brothers had grown since she had left Degma. But knowing she could talk to them, see them on the *v'd'mr* each solarity, still didn't help her feel completely safe and at peace. Until she graduated and left Gehazi for good, she realized she probably never would.

She turned from the window, at the page on her *v'd'mr.* Activating it, she sat down, drawing forth a warm smile when she saw who it was contacting her.

"Hi, Jaada!"

"Jimmy," she breathed. "I'm so happy to see you."

As usual, he looked handsome and well rested, completely at ease and happy, unlike her just then.

"I miss you!"

"And I you," she said. "Are you coming to see me?"

"Well, actually," he began, lowering his gaze, "I have news I wanted to share with you."

"Good news?"

"Yes," he said, shrugging. "Well, for me anyways."

“So, what is it?” She braced herself, as a feeling of dread washed over her.

“Well, Dammen contacted me. He wants me to return to the farm I used to work on, where I trained. On Zarak – *Earth* - we have a holiday there called Christmas, and Dammen told me he wants me there for my reunion, and to celebrate that particular holiday.”

“Reunion? With whom?”

His grin widened, his eyes sparkling happily. “My sister.”

Jaada sat up straighter. “Your sister? I never knew you had a sister.”

He chuckled. “Actually, I was told to keep her presence in Valtor quiet, until we were reunited. I can’t tell you why just yet.”

“So you’re going to be gone awhile? You won’t be coming to see me?”

“Actually, Jaada. I spoke with Dammen, and he wants you there. To celebrate Christmas with us, and to meet Cassia.”

“Your sister?”

“Yes.” Jimmy met her gaze, his tone growing more serious. “Would you like to meet her? To enjoy the holiday? Dammen says it is only a one time deal. He doesn’t like the idea, but since it will make Cassia and her friends happy, he gave his permission. So, they are going all out.”

“Will I have to miss school again?”

“Probably. But I’m sure Dammen can take care of all that for you. So what do you say, Jaada? Will you come? As my guest? If your family comes, too, you can enjoy a reunion of your own, so to speak.”

Her entire demeanor brightened at this. “Really? My parents? My brothers? We’re all invited?”

“Yes.”

Jaada let out a squeal of joy and jumped to her feet. “Oh, Jimmy! That sounds wonderful! When? When will this be?”

Laughing at her reaction, he waved her back to her seat. “Next menta. Dammen said I can bring you through the *ga’lif*. I’ll be leaving earlier, so you and your family will take a different ship from Travaar to Ulstra.”

“But, why can’t we go with you?” Jaada asked, her tone one of disappointment now.

“Well, truth is, I have to meet with my sister privately.”

“Why’s that?”

“Well, to be honest, Cassia thinks I’m...dead.”

“What?”

Jimmy batted at the screen. “It’s a long story,” he said. “But, once everything is out in the open, I’ll be able to share the whole thing with you. It’ll just be easier without a lot of people around.”

“All right.”

“Now, you are free to contact your family. They already know and have agreed to attend. They’re all excited about seeing you again.”

“Oh, Jimmy,” Jaada sighed. “I’ve missed all of you so much. This will be like a heavenly vacation.”

“I expect so.”

“Okay. So now, Jimmy. Can you please tell me all about this Christmas thing?”

“I’ll be stopping in to see you in a few solarities. I’ll tell you then.” He glanced behind him, to speak to one of his workers in the background. “Be right there.”

With that, he blew her a kiss. “Gotta go. Love you, Jaada.” Then, the screen went blank.

Jaada stared at the screen awhile, unable to calm the excitement churning in her belly at everything she had just heard.

“Source be praised!” she whispered aloud. “I can’t wait!”

She rose, humming, happy with the world just then, glad to have something to look forward to. Overcome with joy, she paced back and forth a few minutes, resisting the urge to shout out loud. Then suddenly she hurried to the door, dashing from the room to find Zhala. She just had to share this news with someone she could trust.

Chapter Fifty-Two

"How much longer?" Jimmy asked, turning anxiously from the port hole to peer over at the older man accompanying him, Iddo Aemons. The Kathian, middle-aged by Valtorian standards, crinkled his face into a smile. Dressed in a dark blue tunic, a black vest and boots, the leather belt he wore accentuated his leanness more than usual.

"Impatient, are we?" Iddo said, his voice tinged with a trace of humor, as he pushed aside a lock of his graying black hair.

"Come on," Jimmy said with a frown, knowing how much the older man enjoyed teasing him. "It's only been what? Nearly ten years since I've seen her?"

"Then I'm certain another few orons won't matter, James."

Jimmy grimaced in frustration, then turned back to peer out the large port hole, at the myriads of glowing stars and gases moving at light speed past them. He knew that any further comments would bring a similar response from the elder. Iddo had been a passenger on one of the Altair's transport ships sent to retrieve him and take him to Hemenek.

It was a long three orons later before the craft finally landed on the outskirts of the small village. With a population of nearly 896, the village was quaint yet manageable. A large creek flowed through the center, with a wide wooden bridge over it, which led into the main square. Jimmy recalled it well.

"So, what next?" he asked, peering out the port hole, at the snowy field surrounded by dense woods. "It doesn't look like anyone's around."

"Now," said the elder, "we wait until the Altair summons us."

"And how long before that happens?" Jimmy wanted to know, his deep voice displaying a tone more of impatience than excitement.

Iddo gave his charge a weary look, tired of his endless questions, yet his dark eyes glimmered in secret amusement. He cared much for the boy, but teasing him was just something he couldn't help. Ever since James's first prank against him, he had sought to even the odds. Still, in the process, the two had formed a deep bond that could not be broken. Iddo was much like an uncle to Jimmy Donaldson, and Iddo did not mind at all. In fact, he knew he would die trying to protect the sovereign's ward, if it ever came to that.

"Well," he began, squinting out his own window, "I'd say…just about…now." As he spoke, two imperial warriors were observed plodding toward them, across the snow-covered landscape. Iddo immediately rose to greet them, moving to open the main hatch.

"Stay here," he told Jimmy, although he knew the young man was having difficulty maintaining himself after so long awaiting this reunion with his only sibling and family member there in Valtor. He sensed Jimmy's disappointment as he watched him slump back into his seat and cross his arms in

exasperation.

"This is torture, Iddo," Jimmy complained, as the older man descended the gangway.

Fortunately, he didn't have to wait long. He was on his feet as soon as Iddo returned inside the ship.

"Well?"

The elder merely stared at the youth, his expression sober.

"Come on, Iddo!" Jimmy pleaded. "Don't do this to me. *Please!*"

But Iddo could hold out no longer. At last, his face cracked into a wide smile. "It is time," he said, unprepared for the young man's loud yelp of delight as he threw his arms about him and jumped up and down with excitement.

"*Yes!"* he shouted aloud, squeezing Iddo so tightly that the older man thought he'd crack one of his ribs. After releasing him, Jimmy raced past him to the exit, halting just inside the door to wait for him.

Iddo placed a hand to his heart in an effort to ease his rapid heartbeat, then slowly turned to observe the younger man.

"Now remember, James, what Kaanig Altair told you," he cautioned. "Cassia has no idea that you are even alive, so be careful you don't shock her too badly."

"I know, Iddo. Don't worry. I'll get all of this out of my system before we even get there."

"You'd better," the elder said, his tone stern, "or Dammen will have both our hides."

Shaking his head at the foolishness of youth, Iddo followed his charge from the small transport vessel, as eager as Jimmy to see Kaaniga Altair's reaction to her brother's unexpected presence.

* * * *

"Grif will take it from here," Iddo said, when they stood just outside the door of the large farmhouse, owned by Manaham Zehemerata. "I'm going out back. My daughters are waiting for me in the barn."

"Okay," Jimmy said, somewhat nervous now.

Iddo turned to Grif, the former imperial, and nodded, then walked off. Jimmy saw the grimace on Grif's gnarled face as he turned to raise a hand to knock on the heavy wooden door of the house, as if dreading this particular chore. Then they waited, but it wasn't for long. The wide door swung inward with a squeak, and Manaham Zehemerata stood gaping at them in surprise.

"Grif? What are you doing here?"

"I came at the request of the Altair."

At this, Manaham stepped aside as the Altair, having heard, quickly made toward the elder. As Dammen stepped outside, the door closed behind him, giving them some privacy.

"Did Iddo explain everything, James?" Dammen asked nervously, directing Jimmy away from the house, and out of hearing range of both Grif and the H'San standing guard. "I don't want you making a major scene that will frighten everyone or give them information they don't need to learn just yet."

"I understand, Ziros," Jimmy said, knowing that when Dammen used his given name, he was serious.

"Remember, Cassia has no knowledge of your being alive or even being in Valtor. It is sure to be a horrific shock."

Jimmy chuckled. "Ziros, we both know it's going to be all right. I'm sure I can handle it, and I know she's stronger than you think."

"It's her anger I'm worried about, James. She has a temper and an attitude problem sometimes. She may never forgive me for having withheld this secret from her for so long. But...I had to be sure."

"Ziros," Jimmy said, putting a hand to his arm. "I know my sister, and I doubt you'll have anything to worry about." He stared up at his guardian with some surprise, never having seen Dammen so agitated before.

"Well, all right then. Let's just get this over with, so we can enjoy the festivities."

"I'm ready," Jimmy said confidently. He and Grif followed Dammen into the house, pausing quietly, just inside the door.

"Where's Kaaniga Altair?" Dammen asked Manaham, looking around.

"In the bake room, Ziros," Manaham told him with reservation. "I believe m-my mate has her…helping prepare the meal."

"What!" Dammen said in outrage. "She knows better than to—" He made toward the bake room, only to have Grif grab his arm to stop him.

"No, Highness!" he said gruffly. "Don't stop her! The people will love her for this. It shows her willingness to understand them and to help them, if necessary."

Dammen glared down in fury at Grif's hand grasping his arm, then shook him away. Calming himself, he gave a loud sigh of resignation.

"You're right, Grif," he said. "Once again." He turned to Jimmy, giving him a nervous once over and clenching his fist in indecision. Jimmy was dressed in his brown-black warrior togs, typical H'San dress. "I guess that now is as good a time as any. Go on in."

"Aye, Majesty."

* * * *

The three women in the bake room were so busy, they barely noticed whenever anyone else happened to wander in from outside or trudge through to the back door. But, as Jimmy pushed open the door and peered in, the two older women, Jina Zehemerata and Mrovia Aemons, Iddo's wife, glanced up, then at each other, then nodded at him. They put their stirring spoons aside and recovered some of the pots. Checking to be sure all was in order before leaving the room, they glanced over at Cassia, busy at a table in back of the room. She seemed content and oblivious to Jimmy's presence. Since Jina and Mrovia had been forewarned by the Altair, they were quick to vacate the room and leave Jimmy alone with his sister.

Jimmy politely held the door for the two women, keeping his gaze on Cassia, who seemed oblivious to anything going on around her. She was cutting up fruit and humming softly to herself. Once alone, he noiselessly made his way over to stand just behind her, looking her over. Her hair was longer, but still white-blonde in color. From this angle, she appeared even more beautiful than he remembered. She was humming a lighthearted rendition of a Christmas song they used to sing as children.

"You know," he said finally, "that's exactly the way Mom used to chop up stuff. She was always humming or singing when she worked, too. So I'd say you're a chip off the old block."

His perfect English words brought Cassia to an immediate standstill. He sensed the cold chill that enveloped her, as she pondered his words.

"Cas," he whispered softly, putting a hand to her shoulder and slowly turning her around to face him. As he met her blue-violet gaze, he smiled at her. But it was if she was frozen. "Here, let me take that," he said, carefully prying the peeling knife from her cold, bleeding hand. Her shock at seeing him again had caused her to grip the knife so tightly, it had cut into her flesh. Laying the utensil safely aside, he hastily grabbed some linen to wrap her wound. "Yes," he assured her, as he carefully wound the cloth around her hand. "It's me. Jimmy." At this, he saw her face pale, and her slim frame began shaking with disbelief. "Cas?" he repeated, his tone full of concern.

"J-Jimmy?" she managed after a moment, before snaking a hand out to grip his arm. She squeezed it as if to convince herself he was really there. "Donaldson?"

"Yes," he chuckled. "Sis, it's really me. I'm not dead, like you thought. Kaanig Altair rescued me from the Maddock barn that day and helped me recover. The coffin was empty when they buried it. Hammersfeldt knew it. And I've been here in Valtor since that day, waiting, wanting to see you again. Dammen had promised Dad he would look out for us, so he kept me here so I'd be safe, yet away from you.

"Dammen told me he had fallen in love with you when he first saw you, Cas. He wanted to be certain you would love him back. He said he wanted you to love him for who he was as a person, as a man, and not as the powerful ruler of an entire galaxy. He wanted to be sure of his relationship with you before he would let us reunite because he didn't want you to love him because you were grateful to him for taking care of me. Cas," he continued, searching her face intently, "do you understand?"

* * * *

Cassia gave a mute nod, a large tear rolling down her cheek, and continued gazing at the man before her, no longer the boy she had known. Raising a hand to his smooth, handsome face, she choked back a sob then fell into his arms, wrapping hers about him and crushing him to her.

"Oh, Jimmy! How I've missed you!"

Chapter Fifty-Three

Jaada and her parents arrived an oron or so after Jimmy, although they were not allowed to disembark until Kaanig Altair gave them permission. It was an oron after Jimmy's reunion with his sister, late afternoon, that they were finally allowed from the ship, where the H'San directed them safely to the Zehemerata homestead.

"*Jaada!"* Jimmy exclaimed, rushing from the house to greet her and her family. Lifting her into his arms, he swung her around, both laughing as clods of snow from her feet flew about them. He set her back down and kissed her. Then he welcomed her family, a broad smile on his face. "I'm so glad you could all come," he said, meaning it sincerely, as he took Jaada's hand and led her and the small group to the house.

"I'm glad the Kaanig told us about the snow," Pasana Gellon said. "I never would have thought to bring heavier clothes and snow apparel."

"Yeah, he's thoughtful that way," Jimmy said. "He's made arrangements for you to stay at a local inn since there's not enough room here. Hope you don't mind."

"No, that will be fine, son," said Jaada's father, as he stomped the snow from his feet and entered the large stone-and-wood farmhouse. They were quickly greeted by Manaham and ushered inside.

"And this is my daughter, Ashton," he volunteered when a pretty little girl came dashing into the room to meet them. "My mate, Jina, is in the bake room, but I'm sure Jimmy here can introduce you around to our other guests," he told them, as he took their outer garments from them and indicated the large family room by way of invitation. "I'll just put these aside for you."

Still holding Jaada's hand, Jimmy, grinning from ear-to-ear, proudly led her and her family into the room where lounged a huge Christmas tree, with an overabundance of gaily wrapped packages underneath. Awed by this strange sight, the Gellons could only gape at it and at all the other strange decorations around them.

"This is so...lovely," Jaada said, looking about.

Still smiling, Jimmy led her over to the beautiful, blonde-haired woman sitting in a large, cushioned chair beside the tree. Holding a drink, she was chatting in Zarconian with the two friends who had accompanied her to Valtor, Jim Tompkins, who was sitting in a chair across from her, and his daughter, Jenny Tompkins, who was sitting cross-legged on the floor in front of the tree. Jenny had Dammen's son, Arian, on her lap and was playfully bouncing him up and down, enjoying his giggling, as was everyone else. All had happy grins on their faces.

"Cassia," Jimmy began, in Kathian, so almost everyone would understand. "This is my intended, Jaada Gellon, and her parents, Astar and Pasana Gellon. And these are her brothers, Timson and Jedido."

Cassia set aside her drink, smiled, and rose to take Jaada's hand. "It's a pleasure, Jaada," she said kindly, also in the universal language. "Jimmy has told me a lot about you already. All wonderful things."

"It's so nice to know you, too," the girl responded, somewhat awed at meeting Kaanig Altair's life mate. She waited politely as Cassia then moved to greet her parents.

"We had heard from some of the imperials awhile ago that the Altair had chosen a life mate," Astar Gellon began. "We never dreamed it would be Jimmy's own sister. It explains a lot."

"Yes, we are honored to know you, Majesty," Pasana said, giving a shy curtsy.

"Thank you," Cassia said. "I'm still getting used to the idea myself. And with the fact that my brother is still alive. That was quite a shocker, believe me."

Although the Gellons had no idea to what she was referring, everyone still politely grinned at this and nodded as she directed them to a seat. It had taken only a moment for Kaaniga Altair to put everyone at ease.

"Can we go back out and play in the snow?" Timson asked, disgruntled at being in a house full of strangers, despite the enticing gift-laden tree before them.

"I can show them around," Ashton volunteered eagerly, giving the boys a shy smile.

"Well, just for a little while," his mother told the two boys. "They may have plans for us, so don't go too far."

"Okay! We won't! Thanks, s'lma!" Excitement tore through the boys as they dashed away with Ashton for their coats. They then scrambled their way back outside, much to the amusement of the adults present.

As if on cue, Mrovia and Jina suddenly appeared with refreshments for the Gellons. As the Degmans settled in, Cassia quietly observed Pasana's unusual interest in Arian, who was, by all accounts, an exceptionally beautiful child.

"Um, Pasana," Cassia began. "You may hold the baby, if you'd like. Seems everyone here has at some point."

Overwhelmed by this suggestion, the woman blushed in amazement. That Kaaniga Altair would actually say such a thing to her. To be allowed to hold the heir to the throne of Valtor was indeed a great honor.

"Oh? May I?" Pasana put a nervous hand to her throat. "Well, I do so love babies," she admitted. "And he is such a lovely little thing."

Cassia didn't hesitate. She rose as Jenny made to hand the boy to her. Then, smiling, she carefully placed him in Pasana's arms. Everyone watched as Arian grinned up at her, putting a hand to her cheek in wonder.

"Oh, Astar," she said, meeting her husband's gaze, with tears in her eyes. "He's adorable."

Later, she was overheard telling her husband she thought she would faint in sheer disbelief at having been allowed such an honor.

* * * *

Jimmy was standing beside Jaada, who was perched on a small chair near the fireplace. He couldn't remember smiling as much as he had in the past few solarities. He had been reunited with his beloved sibling, who was married to the greatest guy in the galaxy. He had a lovely girlfriend, whose family accepted him as one of their own. And now he laid claim to being the only uncle of a galactic heir, since Dammen had no family members who could officially claim that title. Menakam M'yata was only a half-brother, after all, and serving a life sentence at Tango, in the outer realm of the galaxy, because of his crimes against the Altair family.

As he glanced about the large room, cozy with friends and family alike, Jimmy smiled to himself, at how wonderful this particular Christmas was so far. He hadn't celebrated it in like...forever. The few he remembered with his parents were filled with wonderful memories.

The happiness among the guests at that moment, at all that was happening, was immeasurable, and Jimmy wished it would last forever.

"Hey," Jim Tompkins suddenly shouted above the din of voices all speaking at once. He stood up and produced a sprig of mistletoe he had somehow fashioned from some native plants. "A Zarconian Christmas isn't complete without some mistletoe hanging in an open doorway somewhere." He raised a green-leafed twig with small red berries on it. "Of course, this plant isn't common here, so I did my best to make one, so you could at least get an idea." He turned to Jenny beside him. "And this…" he began, "…is what we do with mistletoe on our home planet…" So saying, he held the sprig above his daughter's head and leaned down to kiss her cheek, to the delight of everyone present. "Here," Jim continued, passing the sprig to the next person. "If you want to experiment, feel free, then pass it along to the next person." Grinning as the excitement over this mounted, Jim put his hands to his knees and sat back down. Once Jenny had passed it along, she rose to her feet.

"I'm going to check on the ladies in the bake room, to see if they need any help with the clean up. After a repast such as we've just enjoyed, I'm sure there is still much to do."

At her father's nod, she moved away, ignoring the joyous chatter over the mistletoe as it made it's way around the room. She halted in surprise at sight of CambraVernier, standing just inside the doorway of the adjoining room. He had only just arrived, apparently. She half-smiled and nodded in greeting. Ducking her gaze demurely as she made to move past him, he hastily snatched the twig away from a surprised recipient, holding it between his fingers as if waiting to use it. His abrupt action caused a stir of surprise from the guests, especially when he blocked Jenny's path and deftly raised the sprout above her head.

"This should be good," Jimmy murmured, leaning down to Jaada's ear when he realized Jeiel's intentions.

Then, the entire room watched in fascination as Cambra Vernier held the mistletoe over Jenny's head and kissed her. Smack on the lips.

"Merry Christmas," he said softly, gazing at her as if mesmerized.

Jenny raised a hand to her lips with uncertainty. “M-Merry Christmas, Cambra Vernier,” she responded, before scampering off to the bake room with reddened face.

Jeiel seemed amused by her reaction as he turned to the grinning crowd and handed over the sprig of mistletoe to another eager hand. His eyes met those of Jimmy, and he gave a wink, smiling conspiratorially.

Never in a million scalons would Jimmy have ever realized that Jeiel had a thing for Jenny Tompkins, who the cambra had met during the rescue operation on Zarak. As he smiled at the cambra, his glance soon shifted to someone standing behind him. Jeiel turned, startled to find Kaanig Altair viewing him with mild displeasure.

“My apologies, Ziros,” Jeiel began. “I couldn’t resist.”

“Outside, Jeiel.”

“Aye, Ziros.”

Everyone watched as the handsome cambra obediently followed his sovereign from the house for a private discussion.

“I hope he goes easy on him,” Jimmy said. “I know what it’s like to have those talks with Dammen.”

Jaada glanced up worriedly. “Do you think he’s in trouble for kissing your friend?”

Jimmy shrugged. “Hard to say.” He watched a few micron as the mistletoe finally made its way to the last person. When Pasana Gellon had to lean over to kiss Jim Tompkins on the cheek, everybody laughed, knowing how embarrassed she was. But no one seemed to mind, not even Astar who looked on with a pleased grin. It seemed everyone, including some of the town folk who had been invited, was having a good time.

“Hey,” Jimmy whispered to Jaada. “Wanna take a walk before it gets too dark? The sky here looks really cool at twilight.”

“All right,” she agreed, as she rose to excuse herself. At her parents permissive nod, she smiled and allowed Jimmy to lead her away.

“Don't be long,” Cassia said. “We'll be opening gifts soon and enjoying some dessert.”

Once outside, they saw Dammen in deep discussion with Jeiel, who didn’t appear too offended by whatever reprimand he was getting just then.

“Let’s go this way,” Jimmy said, just as Ashton and the boys came scampering out of the woods, giggling at whatever mischief they were probaby involved in. “A nice walk past the woods and into a dark field might be just the spot to get you alone.”

Jaada gave him a wide smile. “Oh, Jimmy. How ever did you read my mind?” Sharing a laugh at this, Jimmy clutched her hand to him, then led her off into the growing darkness.

* * * *

"Finally," B'noni S'd'mor snorted to himself sometime earlier, shoving open the lid of the large trunk-like container he was hiding in. Stiff from being cramped inside for orons, he was slow in his movements as he carefully eased his way out of it. Making his way to a port hole, he observed the Gellons and their accompanying H'San walking across the large, snow-covered field until they were out of sight. Turning with satisfaction, he made a quick search of the vessel he had stowed away on, just to make certain he was alone. Having followed Jaada through the *ga'lif* when she left Gedefon, it had been easier than he had expected to sneak aboard the ship without being seen. "Eavesdropping certainly has its benefits," he chortled quietly, as he hurried from the ship, moving in the direction the others had gone.

* * * *

"I can't believe we're finally alone like this," Jaada said, squeezing Jimmy's hand and leaning into him as they made their way along the snow-covered path. Fortunately, many feet had trampled the snow enough to make the way easy. "At last."

"I know. It's great, isn't it? And we even had your parents' permission?"

She laughed. "I know, right?"

Jimmy halted her and peered behind them. "I think we're almost there. A little farther." Taking her arm, he then put his own around her. "Come on."

The couple resumed their trek along the path of footprints, which led from the Gellons' ship. The sky was still blue, with a smattering of stars blinking down at them.

"It's so frosty," Jaada remarked, referring to the snow. "Everything's all sparkly."

Jimmy tightened his hold on her. "Are you afraid to be out here like this? In the dark?"

"Not really. But I am a bit cold though. I wasn't exactly sure what to wear here on Ulstra. The cold air goes right through my outer clothes. My father was never stationed here, so we weren't sure what to bring with us."

"Not to worry," Jimmy said. "I'll keep you warm."

She laughed merrily. "I've no doubt of that."

They soon reached the edge of the large field, noting the Kathian vessel sitting alone near the center of it.

"If it weren't for my vow not to touch you again until we're joined, I might be tempted to take you into that ship and do wild things to you."

She chuckled mischievously. "I wouldn't mind at all."

He snorted softly. "I know. But a vow is a vow." He fell silent, then pulled her aside, along the tree line of the forest, so that no one coming along the path would see them. "But I can do this."

Drawing her close, he kissed her. “And this. And this.” He repeated his kisses until he sensed she couldn’t stand it any more.

“Oh, Jimmy,” she breathed against his lips. “How I want you!” Putting her hands to the back of his head, she pulled him closer, molding herself fully against him. Claiming his lips, she sighed softly, kissing him with all the affection she had been restraining for so long.

“Well well well,” came a sneering male voice from the darkness. “What have we here? A whore and her *Ho*’San!”

At this the couple froze at the familiar voice, then drew away to peer over at him in shock. They hurried to straighten their clothes.

“What are *you* doing here, S’d?” Jimmy asked, still breathing heavily as he tried calming his erratic heart rate and brushing away the hair from his face.

“Why, I came here...to kill you. Why else would I be here?”

“B’noni, stop this,” Jaada cried. “Why can’t you understand that I belong to him?”

B’noni bristled at this, as if hearing it for the first time. “You belong to me, Jaada! I’ve told you that! Why can’t you get it through *your* head?” He glared at her as if she were a nitwit. “And as soon as I’m done killing your boyfriend, you’re going to do to me what I just saw you doing to him? Got it?”

“No, no,” she choked out. “You’re crazy.”

But he stepped forward and shoved her away. He stood in front of Jimmy, who was still shocked at B’noni even being there, on Ulstra.

“Shut up,” B’noni ordered, “and watch while I gut your friend here like a fish.”

Jimmy sprang to life then. “Like hell, you will!” In an instant, he had back-flipped away, putting some distance between them. His heart was already pumped, so it was only the snow that might slow down his efforts to beat B’noni to a pulp. Hopefully for the last time. “You touch her again, and you will regret it, S’d.”

“Yeah? Well, we’ll see about that.”

B’noni leaned down and yanked a dagger from his boot. Trying to be impressive, he tossed it back and forth in his hands, hoping to intimidate his opponent.

“How did you get here anyways?” Jimmy said.

“Ha! Wouldn’t you like to know?”

Jimmy snorted, keeping his eye on the weapon as he inched back and away from the woods, toward the wider expanse of the field.

“You’re a real joker, aren’t you, H’San? Well, before I slit your throat, I’ll tell you.” He glanced over at Jaada who seemed to be looking about for a weapon of her own. “And don’t interfere, Jaada, or you’ll be dealing with me later.”

“Wouldn’t dream of it.” Jaada put her hands up with dismissal, then edged her way along the woods, toward the path, barely visible now in the growing darkness. Were there more than a sliver of a moon tonight, Jimmy knew she could probably see better and hoped she wouldn’t get hurt.

“Her friend, Zhala,” B’noni began, “told me how Jaada was going away for awhile. She told me about the Kaanig’s secret means of travel, the *ga’lif*, and how Jaada was going to use it to go to Travaar, to board a ship bound for Ulstra.” He shot Jaada a smug grin, who was now staring at him in dismay. “All I had to do was listen in on what was going on and follow Jaada, right through the *ga’lif.* Although it took a bit of care in order to board the ship, I did manage to do it without getting caught. And now, well, here I am,” B’noni said, outstretching his arms for dramatic affect. “And as I promised. I am going to kill you and take Jaada back with me to Gedefon, where I’ll make her my woman...in every respect. I hadn’t realized she was such a slut before, but after seeing her with you, I can hardly wait to get her alone.”

“Over my dead body,” Jimmy said, his fists clenching at what he had just heard.

“Well, that’s the idea,” B’noni said, noticeably shrugging.

“You’re insane,” Jaada hissed at him.

“Perhaps. But what does it matter.” He ignored her and focused on Jimmy, who now stood several criminas away from the wooded area. His arms were crossed as he considered his options. “Afraid, are we?” B’noni said. “What made you stand over there?”

“I didn’t know there were specific rules to throat cutting. Why don’t you come over here so I can kick your ass into the outer realm?”

A loud chortle of glee erupted from the huskier man as he moved toward Jimmy. It seemed this was a sport for him, something he enjoyed. When he suddenly made a dive at him, Jimmy made an attempt to sidestep him, but found himself hindered by a knee-high drift of snow. A sharp, quick cut to his wrist brought a grimace of pain and a growl of fury from him as well.

“Maka!” he cursed, as he gaped at B’noni, who stood sneering at him with delight, his face barely visible now, in the darkness.

“That’s just a taste,” he promised. “I’m aiming for the jugular.”

Jimmy lunged at him then, ignoring the blood dripping from his wrist. He snagged B’noni by both arms, surprised at how strong he was, and shoved him backwards. Only his weight was no match for the bull-like opponent, who grunted with the effort of retaliation. Using his superior weight and strength, he fought with the advantage, managing to bring a knee up into Jimmy’s gut with a damaging blow. Jimmy groaned and released him, to cradle his stomach.

If it weren't for the fanged snow...! And how did B'noni always seem to catch him off guard right after a full meal?

“If you hold still, we can get this over with,” B’noni advised, holding his blade out as he readied for his next attack. “It’s dark and cold out here. I need to get Jaada home to a warm bed.”

“Yeah. Like I’ll ever let that happen.”

* * * *

Jaada, still standing at the edge of the forest, was beside herself with worry over Jimmy's safety. It was too dark now to tell what was happening, but she heard Jimmy's gasp of pain. That he had been injured was clear to her. She had to do something, but what? She had hoped to find a large branch to use as a club, but it was too dark to really look for one now.

Glancing about, all she could see was the ship, sitting like a dark, silent sentinel in the middle of the field. Slowly, she made her way towards it.

* * * *

"You thought you were so great with all those fancy acrobatics, didn't you?" B'noni goaded. "Well, it seems the snow is on my side since you haven't been able to swing those nasty feet my way. Or jump around. Ha!"

Jimmy had quickly recovered from his latest injury and was slowly moving around the athlete, hoping to find a weak point that could bring him down. Next time he trained, he was going to have to do it in the snow, in the sand, in every conceivable form of terra that might present itself to him. Why hadn't he had the foresight to do that before? *Maka!* Although he was skilled at fighting, keeping his footing and moving as he usually did while fighting was something else altogether. He made a mental note to ask Dammen about training in the Ordum, the private training course he used at Travaar. That would help develop the skills he was obviously lacking, even if he was already a legitimate H'San warrior.

He narrowly missed B'noni's next swing at him with the blade. Getting cut again was not something he intended. Being weaponless certainly didn't even the odds either. Fang, he should always have a weapon on him. He had been taught that but, considering the circumstances, he hadn't thought he'd need one today. He had left his own orpod guns and fighting points back at the farm. Well, he'd never be that stupid again, he vowed.

"Come on, H'San," B'noni continued, rounding him with more stealth than Jimmy had imagined he had. That he had had some training of his own was a bit of a surprise to him, having considered him more into balls and bats and weston rackets. "Show me what else you got."

Another swing of the blade came at him in the darkness, this time gouging into his left forearm.

"Ah!" Jimmy clutched at his arm, amazed B'noni had gotten him a second time.

"Just give up, and we can end this," B'noni said. "You're obviously losing."

"I'm not done yet," Jimmy growled, by way of promise. "I'm just getting warmed up." He figured that once he matted the snow down around them, he might have a better platform with which to fight, in the best way he knew how.

But their attention was drawn by Jaada, whose velvety voice sparked out at them from the darkness.

"Jimmy, I have an orpod gun! From the ship."

That was good news, but Jimmy knew he couldn't get around B'noni without getting cut again.

"Can you see to aim it at him?" Jimmy asked, as the two men refocused on their disagreement.

"Um, no," Jaada said, her tone filled with agitation. "I'm afraid I'll hit you by mistake."

Damn, Jimmy thought, trying to figure out how to reach her...and the gun. Since B'noni now knew of it, he was going to block his every attempt to get hold of it.

"I think I can throw it to you, if you can catch it, Jimmy."

"No, don't!"

But before Jaada could react to his words, she had tossed it in his direction, hoping he'd see it coming in the darkness.

"I'm sorry," she gasped upon realizing her mistake, as she saw B'noni make a sudden dive for it. Closer to her than his opponent, he had been able to make out Jaada's movements in the darkness. Before Jimmy even knew what had happened, B'noni had snatched the gun from the snow, then made toward Jaada. Jimmy couldn't see what he was doing, but he heard Jaada's yelp of pain as B'noni knocked her to the ground.

"*Stay out of this!"* he blasted at her. "Now," he said, turning back to Jimmy. "I'm going to finish this. Maybe not the way I'd intended, but it will be efficient. And permanent." He gave a sardonic laugh that seemed to echo all around Jimmy.

He listened as B'noni readied the weapon, his heart racing at thought of being killed like this, weaponless and in front of the woman he loved. He heard the click of the safety release. Then the snap of the hood as B'noni yanked back on it, readying it for fire. But he wasn't about to make himself an easy target. With a flying leap to one side, Jimmy dove face-first into the snow, just as the orpod sounded, its loud fire sounding like a muffled crack of thunder in the open field. Amazingly, B'noni missed.

"Hold still!"

Yeah, like that was gonna happen. His angry tone gave Jimmy some satisfaction. He got up slowly. He hurried to move out of the line of fire. He rolled off in another direction, as B'noni once more took aim and fired at him. Again, missing him by inches - *nelas*.

B'noni's rage at this seemed to bounce off every tree. His voice was tinged with seething anger. Jimmy could now hear him fumbling to take another shot at him.

"*No!"* Jaada's voice screamed.

"Aarrr!" B'noni bellowed. "Get off me, you miserable *ta'qu*!"

Jimmy could barely make out their forms in the dark. Apparently Jaada had jumped onto B'noni's back and had a stranglehold about his neck. B'noni was whirling around, trying to shake her off. Eventually, he resorted to punching her in the face. Jimmy grimaced at her cry as she lost her hold and fell back into the snow.

B'noni wasted no time. He whirled the orpod gun in his direction, as Jimmy struggled to get away. His pause at Jaada's pain had cost him precious moments to flee.

He knew he had to keep moving. Half rising from the snow, he again rolled away, coming to his feet, then rolled quickly in another direction. Anything to keep B'noni's aim off kilter.

But the next shot grazed his shoulder, and he landed backwards in the snow. Lying there, he felt like the wind had been knocked out of him by the orpod gun. Struggling to rise, he watched B'noni moving closer, pointing the gun at him. This time a real fear overcame him as he realized his failure to protect Jaada.

"Ha!" the athlete said, standing but a few criminas away. "Say your goodbyes to your sweet mate now, H'San. 'Cause you're dead meat."

Jimmy turned his head to glare at him, then made a sudden move onto his uninjured shoulder, rolling away again. But instinctively he knew it wasn't far enough or fast enough.

A sudden blast of energy lit up the sky as the sizzling sound of burning flesh and a man's shocked, dying screams filled the air. Jimmy cringed and covered his head, believing this was the end, until he realized he hadn't been hit. Turning, he saw the charred remains of B'noni S'd'mor lumped in the snow, smoking.

"Are you all right?" he heard a voice call through the darkness.

He gave a sigh of relief, turning his head in that direction. "Yes, Ziros." Dammen and his men were everywhere then. "H-How came you to be here?"

"Ashton and the boys. They were playing by the woods and saw S'd'mor sneak from the ship. They came to tell me about the strange man they had seen." Jimmy took the Altair's outstretched hand, allowing him to pull him to his feet, wondering, with some embarrassment, what else they had seen. At his groan, Dammen instantly reacted. "You're hurt!"

"Yes, but I'll live, I think. But, what of Jaada?"

There was a pause, then "Jeiel?"

"Here, Ziros," the cambra replied. "Jaada is all right. But I fear she has a facial injury."

"Well, let's get them to the ship. We'll see to them there."

"Aye, Majesty."

Once aboard, Dammen quickly laid healing hands on the two young people. Jaada had a swollen nose and a black eye, which he quickly took care of. Jimmy, bloody and aching, soon had his tunic torn off and warm hands placed on his wounds. They, too, were quickly healed through the Kaanig's powerful gifts.

"I thought for sure I was dead this time," Jimmy commented, peering up at his sovereign. "I...I couldn't fight as well in those deep drifts, especially after that big dinner we had just had. And I was...unarmed."

"You do realize how foolish that was," Dammen said, frowning.

"Yay, Ziros." Jimmy shrugged, grimacing a bit as his shoulder healed. "I just didn't think I'd need a weapon here, considering."

"Well, since you've learned your lesson, I won't ruin your holiday by reprimanding you this time. But this is a warning. I may not be so lenient next time."

Jimmy grinned up at him. “I understand. Thank you, Majesty.”

“Come now, you two. You should be well enough to return to the farm. Change your clothes, Jimmy, then come back down for the rest of the festivities they've planned for tonight.”

“Me, too, Ziros?” Jaada asked from where she sat on a med table, with Jeiel hovering near.

The Altair turned to consider her appearance. “You may want to wash up a bit,” he said. “Then you can join us as well. I’ll have one of my men take you to the inn where you’ll be staying. I’ve already had your things taken there.”

“Thank you, Ziros.”

Jimmy, still lying on one of the bunks inside the ship, watched her rise and leave with Jeiel protectively behind her.

“I really am sorry about this, Dammen,” he said. “I never meant for any of this to happen. I certainly didn’t want B’noni dead.”

Dammen nodded at him. “I had to do what I had to do, Jimmy. I would have preferred sending him to Tango, but there wasn’t time. You’d be dead now if I had hesitated.”

Jimmy frowned and carefully sat up. “I know. Thank you for saving my life. Again. Seems you’re always around when I need you.”

“You were fortunate I made it here when I did, James. I had just officially proposed marriage to your sister a few micron before the boys came to get me.”
Jimmy grinned up at him. “Seriously? You just now asked her to marry you?”

“Well,” Dammen said, smirking, “I wanted to make certain I did everything right so she wouldn't run away from me again. I wanted to be sure she had no regrets about anything. I never gave her a choice in the beginning, if you'll recall.”

Jimmy dropped his gaze, considering this. “Yeah,” he said. “I remember.”

“If you’re ready to go now, you can tell me all about how S’d’mor found his way onto one of my ships, assuming you know. I’m sure it’s an interesting story.”

“It is,” Jimmy agreed, “but I doubt you’ll like it.”

“Probably not, but tell me everything, James. Every little detail. If security is at fault here, then I need to know about it.”

“I understand, Ziros.”

So it was, for the next ten micron, as they walked back along the dark path near the woods, that Jimmy explained to Kaanig Altair just what had happened and how B’noni S’d’mor had found his way to Jaada Gellon once again. And for the very last time.

Chapter Fifty-Four

The joyful cheers of the graduation ensemble on Gedefon filled the air.

Jimmy stood beside his sister and Kaanig Altair, waiting for Jaada. She was somewhere in the mix of exuberant Valtorians, among the huge crowd of people spread about the school's gigantic weston stadium.

The solarity was sunny and warm, and beaming, excited graduates and their families were milling about in no particular fashion. Some were posing happily, proudly holding aloft the golden plaque with their names engraved on it, a sign they had completed the required academic requirements. Others were chatting with friends, just standing around, or dashing to and fro, looking for stray guests or family members.

All of the professors and school administrators were in attendance, making the rounds to congratulate their now former students. Many paused in awe at sight of Kaanig and Kaaniga Altair standing among the crowd, then smiled at them, bowed respectfully, and moved along.

"There!" Jimmy pointed, spying Jaada carefully making her way through the bustling throngs of people. "*Jaada!*" Her head lifted at the page, and she turned in their direction. She smiled and waved, then hurried toward them.

"*S'lma! S'lpa!* Hi, Tim! Jedido!" she shouted, seeing her parents and brothers standing alongside the Altairs. "I *did* it! I'm done!" She shot Jimmy and Dammen a wide smile before moving to hug her brothers, then her parents.

"Congratulations!" they said, embracing her with great enthusiasm, knowing she would no longer be so far away from them.

Freeing herself, Jaada shoved her plaque at them. "Look," she said. "Isn't it great?" Then, as her family moved closer to scrutinize the lovely item, she turned to Jimmy and flew into his arms. She glanced up at the Kaanig, grinning.

"Congratulations, Jaada," he said softly. "I'm proud of you."

"Yeah, me, too!" Jimmy set her away from him, to admire her blue-and-yellow tobana robe and hood, the traditional Gedefon regalia for graduates. "You look beautiful."

Blushing, Jaada suddenly appeared shy at this. "Thank you."

"Dammen has a celebration party planned for you at Travaar. All we need to do is get all of your stuff together and head through the *ga'lif.*"

"I'll help you," her mother interjected, overhearing their conversation. "We'll be staying at Travaar for a few solarities."

"Yes," Dammen said, "I want all of you there."

Jaada mouthed an ‘o’ of surprise upon hearing this.

“Majesty,” she began, “you’ve done so much for us already.”

“Nonsense,” the Altair said. “You and your family will always be welcome in our home.” He gave Cassia an inclusive smile. “ And you are well deserving of a celebration, with our compliments.” Smiling at Jaada, he then took his life mate’s hands and nodded at Jaada’s parents. “I’ll send someone to guide you back through the *ga’lif* in an oron, if that is acceptable.”

“Oh, yes, Ziros. That should be fine,” Pasana Gellon said, glancing at her husband for confirmation.

“We’ll be ready, Ziros. And thank you,” Astar Gellon said, bowing with reverence.

“See you then,” Dammen said, smiling and nodding as he led his wife and Jimmy away.

* * * *

“I think the time has come,” Dammen said to the young adults now standing nervously before him.

“Ziros?” Jimmy Donaldson said. “The time...for...what exactly?” He squeezed Jaada’s hand by way of reassurance, not really certain why they had been called into the Kaanig’s office when there was a cool party going on.

“Why, for your joining, of course.”

“What?”

Dammen chuckled at their wide-eyed expression at this news.

“I think you both know what you want by now. Jaada has proven her feelings for you and you for her over and over again, so I no longer doubt that your joining will last indefinitely. The fact that she put her own life in danger when trying to bring B’noni S’d’mor down displayed her loyalty as well. She risked her personal safety to assist you, James.” He cocked an eyebrow at them, as if daring them to deny his words.

aada met his gaze with a surprised laugh. As did Jimmy.

“Of course. That is, by all means, Majesty,” they said, stumbling over their words as they chimed in together. Gripping each other’s hands, they gaped at the Altair, hoping they were finally hearing what they had waited so long for.

“Good. Then, in two solarities, at precisely two beohsa dae, we will have the joining ceremony, if that is all right with you. Since your families are here, then that is as good a time as any to get this over with.” He peered at them with a unusual twinkle in his ebony eyes. “James, are you in accord with this?”

“Um, why...yes, of course, Ziros. By all means!” He turned to Jaada, who nodded emphatically, with tears in her eyes, at this unexpected blessing.

“Good.” Dammen rose with finality. “Then Jaada, tomorrow morning at eight, be ready to begin preparations. My people will await your pleasure, for whatever you desire for this joining ceremony.

Be it for a dress, flowers, whatever you would like. Feel free to go with your wildest dreams because I am giving this to you as a gift."

"Oh, Majesty," Jaada managed, choking back a sob and wiping away a stray tear. "How can we ever...thank you?" She put a hand to her throat, swallowing back the lump growing there. Even Jimmy seemed overcome by the Kaanig's generosity.

"Ziros," he choked out, extending a grateful hand. "Thank you! *So* much!"

"Off with you now," Damman said, his words warm with inflection. "You have another celebration at present. Enjoy." With that apparent dismissal, he moved to open the door and ushered them out.

Once outside the room, Jimmy and Jaada gasped and hugged each other with glee, neither having expected to hear these words so soon after Jaada's graduation.

"Oh, Jimmy! I can't believe it!'

"Me, either. I told you he was a great guy!" Releasing her, he snatched her hand. "Come on. Let's go tell the others."

Chapter Fifty-Five

The nuptials were a private affair, performed by the Kapaya, a Valtorian holy man whose only job was to perform selection ceremonies throughout the galaxy. Held in the palace garden, at the outlook, hanging far above the city of Zaratan below, only the couple's immediate family members and a few friends were allowed to attend Jimmy and Jaada's joining ceremony. No one minded, especially the happy couple. What made it more special was that the Kaanig and his life mate were asked to stand with them, as attendants. Which made everything complete.

Afterward, a small celebration had been planned for the Donaldsons, although Dammen doubted the couple were barely aware of it since they were completely wrapped up in one another.

"So, what do you think, James?" he asked, approaching the grand table set up for the two, with sparkling crystal and brightly lit candles on it.

Jimmy turned curiously. "Ziros?"

"Your mark of selection. I know you didn't have a chance to see it beforehand." He paused, aware the younger man wasn't quite focused on the conversation. He sighed and rolled his eyes at being kept waiting. "So, what do you think of it?"

Jimmy gave himself a mental shake, then slowly raised Jaada's wrist to examine the small piece embedded there. Small, in the shape and all the spectacular colors of the Milky Way, the galaxy of Jimmy's origin, the mark of selection was indeed an impressive piece of Valtorian workmanship.

"It's awesome, Ziros. I absolutely love it."

"No one in Valtor has one like it, James," the Altair said. "Therefore, no one can ever doubt again that Jaada belongs to you."

At this, both young people smiled up at him with pleasure.

"Thank you," Jaada whispered, as Jimmy placed a possessive arm about her. "I will never forget all you have done for us, Ziros."

Dammen grinned and nodded. "It has been my pleasure to be able to do this for you," he said emphatically. "For both of you."

* * * *

Cassia, standing on the other side of the room chatting with Pasana Gellon, excused herself and made her way toward the newlyweds.

Beaming at them as she took her life mate's arm, she turned to peer up at him.

"Have you told them yet?"

Jimmy glanced curiously between them. “Told us what?”

“We have another gift for you,” Cassia explained before Dammen could respond.

“Yes,” he said, carefully removing his arm from his mate’s grasp to put it about her. “Since you neglected to plan some time alone together, I have taken the liberty of discussing it with your sister. So we have decided for you.”

“*Yes!”* Cassia erupted with a joyful squeal. “You’re going to love it.”

Jimmy shot Jaada a look of uncertainty. “Okay,” he said. “So what sort of honeymoon have you planned for us? Please tell me it’s not on Ulstra...or even Degma.”

At this, the royal couple laughed.

“Heavens no, Jimmy,” Cassia said, practically bouncing up and down with anticipation. “Go on, Uri! Tell them.”

Dammen chuckled and brought Cassia tighter against him, as Pasana and Astar Gellon, upon overhearing their conversation, hurried over to learn what the royals intended for their daughter and new son.

“I am sending you to F'lask, in the Wiod system,” Dammen said. “To an area so secluded that no one will bother you. A place of lush greenery, gardens such as you've never seen, wide open spaces, numerous bodies of water, and an overabundance of tropical plants, fruit trees, and waterfalls. It is incredibly beautiful and peaceful, and I have made arrangements for you to spend a full menta there. There is a luxurious way place I had built especially for the two of you, with everything you might possibly need. We've provided your own ship for you to explore, and there are plenty of other things there for you to do. I have an itinerary for you to follow that will help you enjoy your time alone more completely. There will be no H’Sans around to guard you, and the only connection you will have with the outside world is the *d’lab'r* I will give each of you. If you need me for any reason, you only have to call.”

Jimmy gaped at him in disbelief. “Oh, Dammen - *Ziros!*” he said, rising. “I didn’t expect, that is, I never dreamed you would do this for us. Th-Thank you!” He moved away from Jaada, who now had tears streaming down her face at this news, and hurried around the table. He gave Cassia an embrace that shocked her, before he moved to Kaanig Altair. “I...don’t know what more I can say,” he told him, before wrapping him in a big bear hug. “Thank you so much!”

Cassia impatiently tapped her husband on the arm. “Go on,” she urged. “Tell him the rest.”

Jimmy’s eyes widened as he released him. His blue eyes shot from him to Cassia and back again. “There’s more?” he said, his tone one of growing incredulity. By then Jaada had come around the table to join them.

“Following your...honeymoon, as you call it, James, I will expect you back at the mining facility on Ulstra. Adjustments have been made for you there.”

“What kind of adjustments?”

Dammen’s lips twitched. “I expect you’ll find out when you get there.”

Jimmy grinned broadly and turned to Jaada, not sure what to expect, but knowing that it was probably something great.

"Can you believe this guy?"

Still wiping her eyes at all she had heard, Jaada merely shook her head in response. Then, unable to contain herself, she hurried over to do the unthinkable. She hugged Kaanig Altair with all the gratitude she could muster. He had done so much for her already, she had trouble stopping her heart from bursting with warm feelings for the man.

"Thank you, Majesty," she said, separating herself from the shocked ruler. "Surely you are too good to us."

Then Dammen amazed everyone by yanking her into his burly arms for a tight squeeze of affection for the girl.

"You are well deserving," he told her. "You are now part of my family. With that go all the perks that come with this status."

Overcome, a sob erupted from Jaada as more tears of joy trickled down her cheeks. Jimmy, understanding her feelings, drew her close and hugged her. Then her parents stepped forward to share their gratitude as well, before turning to again congratulate the couple on the many special blessings given them that day.

* * * *

"It's hard to believe he's a man sometimes," Jaada commented. "The Kaanig's powers and intelligence make him seem like more of a god."

"I know," Jimmy agreed, as they disembarked from the imperial cruiser that had brought them to Ulstra following their wonderfully memorable honeymoon, where he would resume his duties as overseer of the mining facility. "But, knowing Dammen as I do, he would probably get angry if he heard us saying anything like that. He serves the true God of Heaven who gave him his awesome gifts. Valtor is just one of the billions of galaxies that God created, and Dammen takes nothing for granted. He never fails to pray every day, so he can govern Valtor in a good way. It would be so easy for him to use his powers and gifts to do bad things."

Jaada listened quietly, thoughtfully, nodding at this.

"Come on," he said, changing the subject. "I'm anxious to see what *adjustments* Dammen has made for us." He thanked the imperials who had transported them to the planet, waving as they returned to their own business. Turning, he took Jaada's hand and escorted her away from the huge vessel and into the administration building. His temporary replacement, his former plant foreman, Jarrel Fanta, came hurrying out to greet them.

"*Jim!* Heard you got joined," the man shouted with exuberance, clearly excited to see them. "*Congratulations!* Pa'atay." He slapped Jimmy on the back and gave a respectful nod of greeting at Jaada. Grabbing Jimmy's arm, he then led them toward the house sitting just on the outskirts of the mining facility. "You won't believe what the Altair has done. Why, you won't recognize the place!"

Jimmy smirked at Jaada as they followed the man across the wide square of the compound, along the refinement area, through the tall gates, then toward the mansion Jeiel had had built for Jimmy.

"Oh, Jimmy," Jaada breathed at sight of the huge structure. "Is this...*yours*? When I saw it before, I hadn't realized..."

"Yep. Ours now, actually." They all paused to look upon it. The Donaldsons' new home.

"Wow. Look at how high the wall is now," Jimmy said. "I guess the Kaanig doesn't want anyone getting inside again, like last time."

Jarrel chuckled. "That was only one reason. Those white tempen stones were quarried on Kenra and brought here just for this purpose. They are pretty much indestructible by ray gun, explosives, or any other means. The Altair installed the latest security measures as well. Your home," he continued, "is to be your place of safety and refuge. No one should be able to get in it now without your express permission."

Jimmy stood with hands on hips, eyeing the wall with interest. "Imagine carting all those huge rocks here just so we'd be safe. The wall is certainly a lot higher than before. Nicer to look at, too. Sorta looks like marble, with those black streaks running through the whiteness of the stones."

"Come on," Jarrel said, squeezing his arm. "There are a lot more changes." So saying, he moved closer to the entrance gate, then pulled out an envelope. "This is from the Altair. For your eyes only."

Curious, Jimmy accepted it, tearing it open to peruse it's contents. A single sheet of melathen paper, made from the trees of A'ndr, on Konatha, and two small dicshen cards. He glanced at Jaada and smiled.

"It's the emergency passcode information and cards for our security scanners here. One for each of us, Jaada. No one else has one except the Altair and Cambra Vernier. Here. Dammen said he'd get our palm prints encoded into the system later, for even better security."

He handed Jaada her card. Then, after slipping his own across the security plate, he put a hand to her back and escorted her through the wide, tall gates. The foreman followed, as the gates closed slowly behind them.

"Well," Jimmy said, halting just inside the gate to look at the surrounding yard. "This hasn't changed. Still nothing but dry dirt and a few stray weeds. But, I suppose, if we want to see grass, we'll just have to take a vacation somewhere."

"Yes," Jarrel agreed, "but just wait until you see the inside." He moved past the couple, to the front door, now wider and reinforced against future break-ins. It looked more like it did before, when Jimmy's house had been violated. "The dicshen has to be used to gain entrance here as well. As you can see, the Altair had the door strengthened and reinforced with strong metal plates this time."

"Yeah, I can see that," Jimmy said, running his hand along the panels. "I wonder if Dammen can even break through it." They all chuckled at the thought, wondering if it was possible, considering his miraculous powers.

"If necessary, he may install eye or thumb scanners. But only as an added safety precaution," Jarrel said, directing them inside. "Now, the front may look pretty much the same. But it's the back the Altair changed." He led them through the wide foyer, through two adjoining rooms, both open and airy, past the huge bake room they observed with some awe, then through a set of glass doors.

"Kaanig Altair had some additions added here," the man continued, "which even includes a library, two dens and extra work rooms, and a large entertainment area. There is a huge exercise room, complete with all sorts of equipment, for men and ladies alike, plus a swimming pool adjoining a separate room. Said he had it designed like the one he swam in with your sister once, in the Saagernon rainforest. He even added a cool waterfall, which keeps the water fresh. It has an overflow system, to prevent the water from spilling over. That water is then transferred through a special system his engineers designed."

"For what?" Jaada asked, awestruck at sight of the enormous pool.

The foreman winked at Jimmy, then quietly led them back to the bake room, through it to another large, glass door.

"*Oh!* A greenhouse!" Jaada gasped.

"Cool," Jimmy said.

"The Altair wants you to be able to eat healthy, although he'll be transporting in other food and supplies each menta, as he does for the plant. He's added special additives to the pool water that won't be harmful to the plants grown here, if it overflows. Nor to you," the foreman said. "Considering how dry it is here, he wanted to be sure what water you have is put to good use, and drinkable."

"It's just...*won*derful," Jaada said again, moving through the large greenhouse, admiring not just the many vegetables growing there, but the brightly colored flowers and greenery as well."

"He's thought of everything," Jaada breathed.

Jimmy watched, barely able to contain his happiness at all the Altair had done for them yet again. He shook his head in disbelief at the small pond filled with orange, glowing fish in the center of the room. Small colorful sprites were also flying about the room. Their happy twittering filled the air with a pleasant sound.

"Jarrel," he said, turning. "This is more than anything I expected."

The man grinned broadly. "Believe it or not, there's more," he said. "Come on."

He led the amazed couple back through the house, then up the wide, curving staircase to the next level.

"The guest rooms are still as they were before, but Kaanig Altair remodeled your bedroom, making it wider, and refurnishing it. With your bride in mind, I suppose."

"Cool," Jimmy said as they followed Jarrel into his room, looking up at the huge skylight above them. "Dammen really did think of everything."

“You can go up to the outlook he had installed on the roof to catch a fresh breeze now and then, Jim. There is a hidden staircase over there in the closet. And then...there’s this.” So saying, Jarrel swung open the door of the adjoining room, just off the master bedchamber.

A loud gasp of delight erupted from Jaada as she entered. “A nursery! Oh, Jimmy!”

Jimmy smiled at her. “It seems the Altair is expecting us to have children,” he said. “By the looks of the size of this room, many children.” He laughed as he watched his life mate darting about, touching the Kathian-style cribs and pastel-colored bed linens. It seemed the room had everything necessary for a new mother to spoil her babies...and with style.

Jarrel had remained silent as they observed the lovely room and seemed embarrassed at sight of Jaada’s joyful tears at the sight. Covering her face in her hands, she moved to bury herself against Jimmy, who well understood her feelings.

“Maybe he is some sort of a god,” Jimmy said softly, for her ears only. Smothering a laugh at this, Jaada straightened and brushed away her tears.

“Um, there’s actually more,” the foreman interrupted, leading them from the room and back down the stairs and out the front door. “This way.” He led them around the side of the huge house, to another gated, enclosed area.

Another swipe of the dicshen card allowed them access to a huge play yard for children. “There is, of course, a door leading directly into the house from there, too.”

“Oh, man,” Jimmy murmured, as overjoyed as Jaada at sight of the incredible play set spread about the yard. The ground wasn’t dry dirt, as he would have expected. It was some sort of gravel that kept the dirt and weeds at bay. “This is awesome. I wouldn’t mind playing here myself.”

He had earlier memories of going to playgrounds with his parents, but he quickly shoved them aside, afraid he would break down himself then.

“Are you okay?” Jaada asked him, observing his trembling lips.

He snatched her to him, hugging her tightly. “I’m fine,” he said, choking back a sob of sheer joy. “I’m more than fine.” He bit his lip and turned to Jarrel. “This is more than wonderful. Dammen really covered everything, didn’t he?”

“He’s a great man, to be sure.”

“Yeah,” Jarrel agreed. “Now, just wait till you see the two sporty rallids he has waiting for you out back...”

* * * *

Jimmy was sitting in his newly remodeled study, with Jaada nestled on his lap, when the Altair’s handsome face popped up on their own personal *miAE*, at their page.

“James? Is everything okay?” he asked, his brow furrowing.

“More than okay,” Jimmy replied. “I...We...can’t thank you enough for all that you’ve done for us, Ziros. We are just...overwhelmed.”

“Yes, Majesty,” Jaada confirmed, straightening to meet the Altair’s black gaze. “We love everything you’ve done here. And we're so very grateful.”

“Did Fanta inform you that whenever you need to visit your parents on Degma, or return to Travaar for any reason, that all you need do is let me or Jeiel know? We will dispatch a ship to you immediately to take you to wherever it is you need to go. If there is something more pressing, I may allow you to use the *ga’lif* I had installed at the back of your wardrobe. Aside from us, you two, Jarrel, and the workmen are the only ones aware of it, so share this knowledge with no one else. But it’s only for emergencies, you understand.”

“Yes, Ziros,” Jimmy replied, along with Jaada’s nod of agreement, both having discovered the unit there, next to the stairs leading to the outlook. Still overcome by Dammen’s generosity, it was all he could do to keep his own voice steady. “I...We understand.”

“If you have any problems with anything, please let me know, will you?”

“I will,” Jimmy assured him. “Oh, and Dammen...”

“Yes?”

“I love you.”

Dammen’s face warmed. “And I you, Jimmy. You know this.”

“Yes, I know. But, Ziros. I *really* love you. And I just can’t thank you enough...for everything. So, just...thank you.”

Both Jaada and Jimmy observed the sudden sheen of tears in his own black eyes then, as he nodded at them and smiled.

“When you're older, and I feel you're ready, I'll provide you your own vessel. For now, I expect you to do as I tell you, James. Is that clear?”

“Yes, Majesty.”

Dammen settled back in his chair to consider his final words.

“So, now that your house is in order, get back to work, Jimmy,” came his gruff reply, as he struggled to contain himself. “Alert me to any problems, and I’ll get right on it.”

“I will, Ziros.”

Jimmy nodded as the communication abruptly ended, and the screen went black.

Jaada put her arms around him, to snuggle against his neck. “I love him, too,” she said. “He's too wonderful for words.”

“I know. So hard to believe a man like that even exists.”

“He is a very unique and special man.” She waved her hand at the luxurious study they were in. “He knew exactly what to give us that would make us happy and keep us from being bored.” She giggled. “That teaching job he lined up for me here at the plant, to help the miners stay in good health and better shape and to help them with their math and reading skills, is more than I could have ever asked for. And if we ever do have children, I won't be korons away from them...or from you, for that matter.”

“I know, I know,” Jimmy said, shaking his head in disbelief. “But let me say. If Dammen's not a real god, he comes pretty close, what with his powers and everything. Regardless,” he continued, “after all I’ve been through, I still wouldn’t want to live anywhere but in his galaxy.”

“And I’d go through everything all over again, Jimmy. All the bad things. Just so I could be with you forever. In this one galaxy, under Dammen, under Heaven, and under God.”

Jimmy sighed and relaxed back in his seat, the joy he felt filling him to bursting.

“Me, too, Jaada,” he sighed, as he brought her lips to his. “I would gladly go through all my trials again just so I could spend the rest of my life with you. Here, or anywhere else the Kaanig chooses to send me. He told me once that the rewards I would receive, when everything worked out as he wanted them to, would be worth waiting for. And he was right.”

* * * *

As Jimmy and Jaada Donaldson considered all that their Source had blessed them with, they realized that they truly were in good hands, and that, for the first time, all was right with their world and their new life together.

How well they knew it.

THE END

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

L. M. Ridd was born and raised in upstate New York but currently lives in the Midwest. A graduate of SUNY Brockport, she holds a bachelors in health science, with a concentration in alcoholism and chemical dependency counseling (B. S.), together with a masters in public administration (MPA). She writes poetry, nonfiction, and romantic fiction.

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